Responsibility: Pick a Nightmare and Run With It

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/37199002.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Catra & Hordak (She-Ra), All the canon ships

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Horde Prime Clones (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst, Hurt/Comfort, Post-Canon, Post-War, Aftermath of Violence, Spacebats, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Hordak Redemption (She-Ra), war-weary everyone, Everyone Needs A Hug, More Inclusive Friendships, Light dusting of crack, Fanart, Illustrations, smattering of smut, [Entrapdak smut ch. 4), [Catradora smut ch. 7]

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Part 6 of Season of the Survivor

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by AintGonnaHauntItself

Summary

A powerful potential threat arrives on Etheria's space-doorstep and nobody really has the time or energy for this shit. Catra gets pulled into an upsetting mystery while she tries to help her friends cope. Hordak won't admit how difficult it is to keep up with Etheria's, Entrapta's, and his own problems. The Alliance really hoped things would have gotten easier by now.

Notes

This series is a post-canon story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization angle. So uh, expect all the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you're dealing with tough stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anybody for anything.
Centered around Catra and Hordak. Aged up significantly for super adult themes, but it's still set in the canon universe so truth spells are a thing and the only sociopath involved was Prime. If you're not into easy redemptions or quick-fixes for Catra and Hordak, I totally get it, but I spent a lot of time and effort on hashing shit out in the five stories leading up to this one, and you are welcome to inspect those to your heart's content.
Thank you, and happy reading :)

Also, the art is anonymous and the artist said they're fine with people posting it elsewhere.

"...I am not Prime, children."

Chapter Summary

> Catra helps Hordak with his problem in the lab and ends up getting sucked into an uncomfortably familiar story. Hordak frets over the delegation from Tarsis while Glimmer and the crew hold their own. Catra joins the meeting in time to learn more about Sivtria's real intentions.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra silently thanked Adora for pushing for more cardio as she skidded around corners and leapt down flights of stairs on her way to the cellars. The sooner she could defuse Hordak's predicament, the better off they'd all be, and Catra tried desperately to think of how to calm a crying child. All she could think of, however, were Shadow Weaver's proffered methods, which she was pretty sure was a bad choice in references.

She made it to the lab doors in record time and was panting for breath as they slid open loudly. And, of course, it was only then that she made a vital realization: She'd helped destroy Salineas too, and she might be about to make things much worse for the terrified child. She probably should have sent Glimmer for Scorpia. There was no time to change her mind, however.

"You're here," Hordak breathed through a relieved sigh the second the doors had stopped sliding open. She looked up to where he was standing with his back to her and quickly stepped inside, smoothing her short hair down and letting her jacket flop open. She turned her body slowly until she was facing the tiny Aquatic Etherian in the corner, eyes as wide and terrified as ever.

She had no clue what to do. She knelt on the ground to try and signal her passivity, and the girl scrutinized her every move. "H-hi," she began awkwardly. The girl neither moved nor spoke. "I

know Hordak is scary, but you're safe, okay? He can't do anything to you." She cast a glance over at the back of Hordak's head and watched an ear quiver while he listened. "Isn't that right, Hordak?"

She saw the glow of his eyes through the reflection on the black screen he was using to watch the scene behind him. "Catra, I have repeatedly intimated as much and-"

"Alright, alright, no need to be grumpy," Catra cut him off before he could complain more. Finally, she saw a flash of something behind the girls eyes as she observed their interaction.

"I am not *grumpy* ," Hordak retorted in an offended huff.

"You're always grumpy. You're the definition of a grump. It may as well be your subspecies, Hordak." She thought perhaps a corner of the girl's mouth twitched. She sighed and softened her tone, addressing the girl again. "Can we get out of here, yet?" Catra asked her quietly. "I just want you to get home safe, okay?" Much to her surprise, the girl slowly shook her head, still staring at Catra. "Wait, what?" she asked, thoroughly taken aback.

"See?" Hordak pouted.

"Why can't you leave the lab?" Catra asked, cocking her head. The girl went back to watching Hordak and remained silent. After a while Catra sighed and tried again. "If I make him go to his room, will you talk to me?" She heard Hordak make a disgusted 'tsk' sound at her choice of words and she stuck her tongue out at the back of his head. This time she definitely caught the girl's flash of a smile.

"Please inform me when I am *permitted* back into my workspace," Hordak complained as he turned and limped back to his bedroom. If she didn't know better, she could have sworn there was the faintest tinge of amusement in his sarcastic tone. Catra flopped onto the ground and crossed her legs as he went, watching him grip at his thigh with one tense hand and clutch the fabric at his

chest with the other, and was relieved to see some of the terror melt from the girl's posture.

"Alright," she said when the door had closed behind Hordak, turning back to the blue child. "What's your name?"

When the girl finally did speak, it was in a voice that was richer and clearer than she'd expected. "Chelle," she said, "C-H-E-L-L-E. I'm nine and a half," she recited, not meeting Catra's eyes.

"My name is Ca…" she hesitated, "Catra," she finished, wincing slightly. But it seemed to her that Chelle did not know who she was, and after a quick huff of relief she continued, "I'm here to serve Salineas, so how can I help you, tiny lady?"

The girl finally took a small step forward away from the corner and slowly lowered herself to sit on the floor a few feet away from Catra. She stared at her wringing hands in her lap without speaking for several moments, but Catra didn't press her. "I didn't want to come. I had to."

"Why did you have to? Did somebody make you?" Catra frowned, and scowled deeper when Chelle slowly nodded yes. "Can you explain to me how it happened?"

Chelle scooted slightly closer and kept wringing her hands. "Some of the other kids made me."

After another stretch of silence, Catra prompted, "Why'd they do that?"

She started toying with her dress, worrying a frayed ruffle between her fingers. "They said if I snuck in here and proved it with something that belongs to Hordak, they'd let me get water before them."

Catra scowled ever harder. "Why is that a problem?"

Chelle scrunched her face up and stuck her bottom lip out slightly. When she spoke again Catra saw adorable, sharp little teeth that

still had their ridges. “We live in the refugee camp and there’s always a really long line for all the kids getting water for their families.”

Catra took a deep breath, processing the child’s words. “Did you come here because of bullies?”

Chelle nodded before she finally lifted her face to Catra’s gaze so that she could see righteous anger behind bright aquamarine irises. “They’re really mean and stupid, but they’re bigger than me and I have to do what they say.”

Her tail flicked lightly on the floor as she considered Chelle’s words for several long seconds. “Well then, that needs to change, doesn’t it?”

Chelle frowned at her. “My mom says it’s not right, but that it’s just how things are and I need to stay safe. So I guess this is just how it is.”

Catra sighed and shrugged. “Your mom’s not wrong. But me and my friends are working on making things better, so I’m going to try and help, okay?” The child believed her so easily, so gladly, that her eager nodding brought a smile to Catra’s face. “Do you mind if I get some of my friends to help too?”

“Yeah!”

Catra assumed the yes was affirmative and broached her next suggestion. “So, I know Hordak used to be a big f-f” she caught herself gracelessly. “-fiendish bully… He used to be a big bully,” she looked back into the girl's uncertain gaze, “but he’s learned a lot and now he doesn’t like bullies at all. And I know he’s still scary,” Chelle nodded quickly, “but I bet he would want to help with this too.”

Chelle considered for a very long time, and Catra could practically see her mind working. Her brow puckered up as she weighed concerns and factors that were far too big for such a little kid. It

made her heart ache for the girl. Finally, she asked, "And he has to do what you say? Even if you boss him around?"

"He might even let *you* boss him around," she said honestly.

Chelle made another series of agonized expressions while Catra held her breath, then she finally nodded again. "You have to promise not to let him hurt anyone."

Catra nodded and smiled. "I promise that Hordak will do his best to never hurt an Etherian ever again." Her promise seemed to soothe Chelle's worries somewhat and the girl's shoulders relaxed.

Chelle nodded slowly through her serious expression. "Okay then. He can help."

Catra beamed. "I know Princess Mermista will want to handle the water problem, and if the bullies keep bugging you, Hordak and I will ask them to stop being jerks, okay?" Chelle beamed at her and smiled. She scooted closer to Catra again and a spark of hope and excitement lit her green/blue eyes. Catra thought she might have room to press one last idea. "So… do you want to meet Hordak?" A flash of alarm crossed her face. "Those kids said they wanted proof you were here, right?" She nodded slowly. "I bet he'd like to help with that."

Chelle fixed her with a stern gaze. "You *promise* he's nice now?"

Catra suddenly felt some of the weight behind the promises she was making to the girl on the cellar floor. "I promise. Hordak and I want to help."

Chelle didn't react for several seconds while Catra marveled at the shocking shade of the irises before her, but finally she nodded.

Catra beamed back before she raised her head and shouted at Hordak's door, "Did you catch all that?"

"Yes," came Hordak's muffled reply. "A moment, please."

Catra smiled sideways at Chelle's curious look. "It's the big flappy ears. Clones can hear a lot more than most of us."

The girl gave a slow, comprehending nod as they heard the sound of increasingly impatient rummaging from Hordak's bedroom. A small crash and grunt filtered through the door followed by the sound of more rummaging and muttering. Before long, however, the door opened and Hordak was back.

Sour, dour, and generally unlikable, he limped his way slowly toward them, looking down at whatever he carried in his hand. Chelle let out a nervous breath and scooted back a bit, but he didn't seem to notice. When he did look up, he bounced his gaze between Catra on the floor and the small child beside her a few times before grimacing his way down to a kneel. It must have been hell on his stab wound but he bore it gracefully enough, eventually lifting his glowing eyes back to Chelle's face.

Hordak held out his giant paw, palm-up, to show a little gold alliance pin resting there. Chelle slowly reached out, hesitated just out of reach, then determinedly took the small metal wing. Her hand looked ridiculously small compared to Hordak's and Catra had to bite back a smile. *There is absolutely nothing cute about Hordak interacting with a child*, she told herself. When Chelle brought the pin up near her face, Hordak spoke in a tone so low and gentle that she'd never heard him use it with anyone but Entrapta. "My name is inscribed on the back. I believe my alliance pin should suit your needs."

Chelle looked back up at him and mustered a shy smile. "Thanks," she said, closing her small fist around the pin and holding it close. "Sorry I screamed at you so much."

"Nonsense," Hordak said brusquely. "You behaved as a person of your stature should if you sense imminent danger." Catra's eyebrows shot up in surprise and Hordak himself looked a little shocked by his positivity. Maybe the Princesses were starting to wear off on him after all. He cleared his throat and squared his shoulders before adding, "Although, for future reference, I would

suggest that you flee when met with a threat, then wait for the enemy to retreat and return at a later time to accomplish the mission."

"Speaking of threats and enemies," Catra added, "the really cool thing about these pins is…" She unclipped the one on her belt so she could show her. "If you pinch it on the end until you hear a click, it becomes a little distress signal. So if you or your people need help, you can make it click and somebody from the alliance should be there soon."

Hordak raised a questioning brow, likely doubting the wisdom of giving a seven-year-old access to an alliance distress signal. Catra shrugged, however, reasoning that she'd gotten her hands on much more serious materials at a much younger age, and she was still kicking.

"Thank you," Chelle repeated a little louder, giving Catra a wide smile.

"C'mon," Catra said, rising to her feet. "Let's get you home, okay?"

Chelle stood and made to follow her, but Hordak had more to say from his awkward position on the ground. "I must remain at the palace with my work, however I shall speak with Princess Mermista about refugee resources. Perhaps Catra could gather information for the Princess when she returns you to the camp." He phrased it as a quandary but Catra answered with a nod.

She and Chelle had nearly made it to the door when Glimmer's voice sounded from Hordak's, and she sounded stressed as she launched into speech. "Hordak, we're about to receive a diplomatic party from Tarsis and Queen Sivtria is going to be there. What can you tell me?"

"Tarsis?" Hordak's sharp reply had Catra spinning around in alarm before he'd drawn another breath. "And Sivtria herself is coming?"

"Yeah… how bad is that?"

Hordak took a deep breath and Catra waved at him dramatically to hurry up and answer. “There is no need to panic yet, but there are some things you should know,” he said while looking at Catra. He didn’t make any move to rise from the ground, but instead waved a hand vaguely at her to let her know that she wasn’t needed. She turned back around reluctantly, throwing glances back over her shoulder at Hordak as she went. Before the lab doors slid shut behind her, she heard Hordak’s tone become more clipped and serious. “Queen Glimmer, you are about to encounter one of the most powerful political bodies in the Universe. Powerful enough that Horde Prime tolerated an alliance with them rather for the time being rather than immediate conquest. You absolutely must not…” The lab doors were shut before Hordak finished his sentence.

Catra stood in silence for a moment, hair on end, trying to shake the chills that had just swept over her. She closed her eyes against creeping paranoia and tried to remind herself that the Alliance was well up to the challenge. Her worry would not help, nor did it credit their defeat of Prime and subsequent victories in reconstruction.

“Are you okay?”

Catra jumped and looked around, having completely forgotten about Chelle for a moment. “Yes,” she breathed down at the little worried face peering up at her. “I’m okay. Are you ready to go home?”

Chelle looked down at the gold pin in her hand and nodded.

* * * * *

Once they were out of the cellars and far away from Hordak, Chelle opened up and talked with Catra freely. She kept talking as they walked through town, chatty and cheerful as Catra listened with her hood up and kept an eye out for trouble. She was even still talking when they passed the docks. Catra managed to lead her flow of information with carefully chosen questions, so she was still eagerly listening when, somehow, the child was still talking as they neared the last of the warehouses. Catra had asked about how many people generally shared the temporary shelters in the refugee camp, and now Chelle was enthusiastically describing her life at home with her family.

"I live with my mom and my uncles and my grandma right now. We sleep in the same tent because my mom says it's warmer and safer, but we try not to spend too much time there because there's not much room. My mom and my uncles go out and work lots of jobs, so I spend a lot of time with my grandma, and she's the one who always cooks and always makes us all come to dinner. She's a really really good cook, my favorite is when she makes clams. Oh! And when we can get the ingredients, she can make the *best* yellow cake." Catra wore a genuine smile as Chelle took a few moments to breathe before launching ahead. "So what's your family like?"

Of course. "Uuuuhhh," she stalled as her face fell, "it's not like yours," she evaded.

"Do you still have parents?"

"I, uh… um…" Catra squinted ahead as they walked, trying to choose her words carefully. "They found me at the Fright Zone a long time ago, but that's all I know. No note."

"Did you run away and get lost?"

"Nah, I was too little to be wandering around on my own. Somebody definitely abandoned me at the gate. The Horde took

me in and the soldiers raised me."

"Wooow," Chelle muttered, pulling different faces as she processed Catra's words. "I wonder if that's what happened to my aunt."

Catra wasn't sure what 'aunts' were, but asked, "Did your aunt go missing?"

"Um, when my mom was little and their refugee camp got attacked, her little sister went missing and they never found her. They still act weird when they talk about her, and my grandma cries about it on holidays."

Catra frowned, trying to keep up with what she was hearing. "How long has your family been refugees?"

"Oh!" Chelle chimed happily, "They weren't refugees the whole time. They got a little house and stayed there for a while. We only had to be refugees again when Salineas got destroyed."

Catra nodded slowly and sighed again as they began passing the large wall tents on loan from Bright Moon. Conditions in the refugee camp were actually a little better than Catra had expected. People were adding matts and sheeting to the sides and roofs of their tents for extra warmth, but it looked like everyone had access to shelter. She didn't see anyone who was obviously starving or dying of disease, which was a good sign, and the people there didn't seem frightened. Aside from these redeeming factors, however, the setting was grim. The discarded materials the people were using to reinforce and insulate their tents gave the structures all an air of decay, and the road between tents was pitted with puddles and uneven. Refuse receptacles were filthy and overflowing, public bathroom shacks were fucking foul, and Catra thought she could smell the fish processing from the docks on the air. Or maybe it was the dump?

"Catra?" Chelle asked.

She sighed and refocused her attention. “There’s no good reason for the people here to be living like this. I’m going to make sure this is next on the alliance’s list of things to do, okay? You guys are going to get some of the help you’ve been waiting for.” Chelle beamed at her.

“Come on, I want to show you my house!” The girl grabbed Catra’s hand and dragged her down the lane with surprising strength.

“I’m going to make sure you get back to your place, but then I should really go start working on this back at the palace,” Catra said. She wasn’t exactly in the mood to socialize with Chelle’s family, especially as she'd already caused them so much trouble.

“Okay, but I bet my grandma’s going to want to meet you,” she cried over their slapping footfalls as they trotted to a halt outside of a comparatively sturdy looking shack.

Before either of them had time to do anything else, a frantic call sounded from behind the heavy burlap that functioned as a front door. “Chelle?! Is that you, Sweetheart?!” The curtain was torn aside as a woman burst through at a run before falling to her knees in front of the child, pulling her into a tight hug.

Catra was frozen where she stood, hardly breathing. For a few full seconds her brain buzzed at a full stop as she sorted through what she was seeing. It was not Octavia who had been frightened for her child, but *holy shit* did she look like her. As soon as she realized it wasn’t her previous coworker, a new trickle of dread started filtering into her thoughts. She started thinking hard about the possible timelines around Chelle’s long lost aunt.

“Where were you?” The wide-eyed woman said as she held Chelle out at arm’s length, frustration finally vying with the terror in her voice. Chelle didn’t answer immediately and the woman gave her arms a tiny shake. “Look at me! What happened?”

Catra was still rooted in place but she jumped in without thinking. "Some kids bullied her into sneaking into the palace, I was just walking her home," she said in a faraway tone, still struggling to snap out of her initial shock.

"What? Wha…" She did a hard double take at Catra's face, and at the alarm in her eyes, Catra knew she'd been recognized.

"Chelle!" A second woman came through the doorway and bustled toward the child. "You scared the tar out of your mother and I, where have you been? And who is this?" she asked, looking up at Catra. She also looked much like Octavia, albeit an older version.

"That's Catra, she found me and brought me home," Chelle said before Catra could answer.

Chelle's mother gave her a long, hard look, but the grandmother, who Catra assumed was Chelle's mother's mother, threw her hands up and immediately stepped to pull Catra into a tight hug. "Thank you so much for seeing her home safe," she said, squeezing a bit tighter. "Come in! Come in! Have a cup of tea with us."

"Oh no, I don't think that-" Catra was cut off by her own soft grunt when Chelle grabbed her hand again and yanked her forward.

Fifteen minutes later, Catra sat on one of four small beds in the small square space, clutching a tin cup of tea with her ears down and tail flicking uncomfortably. Chelle's mother, Oceana, sat with her daughter in her lap, holding her close and watching Catra closely, though she showed no signs of hostility. Chelle, who was apparently *very* close with her family, had only just finished explaining the fight that had led her to the palace early that morning, her journey to the cellars and even her brief interaction with Hordak. Now, despite Catra's constant warnings against high expectations, Chelle was assuring her mother and grandmother

that Catra was going to help the refugees and that things would be better soon. Thankfully, the two older women seemed realistic to the point of cynicism and Catra was enormously relieved when the grandmother gave her a gratuitous wink and knowing shrug over Chelle's head.

The cup in her hand grew cold once it was empty and Catra listened to the wind whip the canvas beneath their scrap roof as Chelle rambled happily. She would have let the family be and been long gone by now, but there was one more piece of information she wanted. She just hadn't figured out how to ask for it yet. Before she had to, Chelle solved her problem for her.

"I was telling her about us being refugees, and she told me about how the soldiers took her in when she was little and I thought, maybe, what if that's what happened to Aunt Octavia?"

There it was. The grandmother fumbled Hordak's Alliance pin and dropped it as Oceana swallowed audibly. "Maybe, Sweetheart," she said quietly to her daughter as her mother retrieved the pin. "But we're probably never going to know for sure. You know that."

Chelle sighed dramatically as the grandmother recovered her composure. "I know, I just thought maybe that's what happened to Catra, too."

For the second time that hour, Catra's brain sputtered and stalled out. She'd been so caught up thinking about Octavia that she hadn't considered her own origins. She'd always suspected that Shadow Weaver was lying about the whole 'abandoned and unwanted' storyline… Chelle had a point.

"Are you alright, dear?" Catra broke her reverie and looked around at the old woman who'd placed her wrinkled blue hand gently on her shoulder.

"Yeah… yeah I'm sorry." She needed to get back to that town with the gross drainage. She needed to get back to the tavern where she'd seen Octavia out the window, and she needed to ask

questions until she had answers to bring back to Chelle's family. First, she needed details for any possible corroboration. "Let me know if it's too painful to talk about, but do you mind if I ask what happened?" Catra asked, putting more effort toward politeness than she had in years.

The two aquatic Etherians exchanged a quick sigh before they both nodded. "It's painful," Oceana said, "but it's our story, and we try not to shy away from it." Catra nodded and clutched a little tighter at her empty cup. "She was my little sister. I'm the oldest, then it was Octavia, then the twins."

"She was about five," the grandmother added.

"How did you lose her?" Catra prompted.

"Oh, same as anyone else," the older woman sighed. "The Horde showed up, the refugee camp was the first to dissolve into chaos. Oceana was alone with the littler ones while I did some extra washing for the money." She threw an apologetic look at her daughter, who didn't seem to notice.

"We had a meet-up point, where Mom would find us if things got bad," Oceana said, picking up the tale for her mother. "She and I were playing nearby, so when we heard the noise I took her there and told her to wait for us while I went and got the twins. When I got back to the meeting spot, she was gone."

"I finally showed up and she handed off the twins," the grandmother went on, "and then she was off again, back into that crowd looking for her sister." She gave her daughter a sad smile, but Oceana merely shrugged. "The crowd wouldn't leave me there, not with two little ones," she explained, more pain seeping into her expression. "Thankfully, another refugee family we'd been friends with saw Oceana and snatched her up, found me in the nearby woods and got her back to me." She leaned over and gave Oceana's hand an affectionate pat, and this time the younger woman offered a fond look.

“But nobody brought back Octavia?” Catra suggested.

The women both shook their heads. “Never saw her again,” Oceana muttered quietly, as if to herself. Chelle looked up at her before squeezing the hand holding her around the waist.

* * * * *

Hordak ended the call with Queen Glimmer while he was still kneeling on the ground, thinking hard about the situation that Tarsis had brought to Etheria’s proverbial doorstep. As he thought, he rubbed vaguely at his thigh above the staples. When he’d knelt, he’d kept his thigh straight and put his weight on that knee. Luckily that combined with the binding around his thigh had kept the wound shut, but it still hurt. After a while, he made an attempt at standing on his good leg, but lost his balance and fell heavily on his ass. He flopped onto his back for a few deep breaths, staring up at the dark ceiling. Then rolled onto his three good limbs and pushed himself up. Once he was finally on his feet and stood up straight, however, he was hit with a wave of dizziness.

He managed to stay upright and reach a nearby generator, trying to focus while his mind cleared slowly. He hadn’t received much concrete information on Tarsis while he’d shadowed Prime, other than that he didn’t like Sivtria and was planning to erase her once he’d finished with Etheria. What he’d felt from Prime, however, was that she was no mere nuisance. Sivtria was not to be underestimated, not in cleverness and not in ruthlessness. She wasn’t much younger than Prime and even he had been impressed by her appetite for power.

Hordak didn’t like the situation one bit. Why was Sivtria here herself, where Prime had been defeated. There was no way she was so desperate to secure them as allies, and she was too shrewd to expose herself to an unknown threat without urgent motivation. At some point he realized he was having a hard time catching his breath but was too preoccupied with worry to focus on it at the moment.

A familiar, sharp pain shot through the center of his chest as he walked across the room to where he’d left the communicator. When he could feel the stiffening in his joints and the throbbing in his leg even through the suit’s influence, even he had to admit it was time to take a moment for rest. But first, Sivtria was here and there was a good chance that Etheria was in trouble.

He knew that agonizing over it wasn’t going to help anything, but he stared down at his communicator for some time, scowling and trying to think of what to do. Hordak didn’t want Sivtria anywhere near Etheria or anyone he knew, but their best option was to keep communication open and amicable. If he said the wrong thing, he risked stirring up unnecessary paranoia, or perhaps making himself a distraction she might notice. He wished he could just be there, but he was technically a prisoner who had no business in a meeting between diplomats, and it seemed like a generally bad idea to risk revealing that a clone had betrayed Prime.

A cheerful message from Entrapta lit up his screen and an uncomfortable chill swept his chest. Etheria was still appallingly vulnerable… for light’s sake the spires from their last alien invasion were still all over the planet. He thought they’d have more time before any of Prime’s allies moved on them, time to gather more resources, gain more allies. Another pain in his chest made him scowl harder and he opened the messages on his communicator, determined to warn somebody before he abandoned himself to uselessness.

Still, he hesitated, hovering on the edge of a decision. The next moment, he paused as a constructive idea finally struck him. It was a stressful idea, but at least he wouldn’t be doing nothing. He

opened a new message and tapped out just a few words before sending it. Then he took a deep breath and tried to focus on calming himself.

Before he'd managed it, however, the swish of the lab doors had him turning around with his back hunched, on the verge of growling. A very frightened-looking magician stood just behind the doorway, holding a patterned bag between clutching hands.

"He-he-hello. I'm here… to help…" he gulped loudly. "I'm here to help with your leg. Princess Glimmer and Castaspella said so.

Hordak sighed, turned around, and smoothed his hair back, recovering his composure and arranging a calm expression. "Her title is *Queen* Glimmer, and thank you. Please make yourself comfortable and inform me of your requirements."

* * * * *

Catra was back to begrudging gratitude for Adora's cardio bullshit as she ran through the palace at Bright Moon after using Entrapta's portal loop to get there. She concentrated on Melog and hoped they were nearby, that they might even be able to sense her agitation. They were better at reading people's true intention than anyone else she knew, and she wanted their eyes on Sivtria as soon as possible. And hers. Melog's and hers. Now.

She wasn't panicking, but the words of Hordak's message flashed through her mind on repeat. "Prioritize peace, but DON'T TRUST SIVTRIA." She was terrible at prioritizing peace, but she was very,

very good at not trusting people. Better at it than the other Etherians involved, anyway.

"Where's the diplomatic thing?" Catra asked breathlessly as she skidded to a halt before a Bright Moon guard. For a moment, she seemed to debate whether or not Catra was trusted enough to tell. "I was sent to get a message to Queen Glimmer about the people from Tarsis."

The guard nodded reluctantly. "They've been touring various spots around the planet, but I just heard from another guard that they're back on Bright Moon grounds."

"Thanks!" Catra remembered to call out over her shoulder as she ran on.

It took a little running around and intense listening, but she managed to find the large party just east of the castle, grouped loosely around Darla, all of their backs conveniently turned toward her. The foreign diplomats shone crystalline in myriad jewel tones, accentuated by glittering robes in metallic shades. They were certainly the most striking beings she'd yet seen in her life, and though they looked angular and cold, they were undeniably gorgeous. Sivtria was immediately recognizeable in her black, high, spikey collar, her bald head glittering purple in the afternoon light.

A little apart from the party from Tarsis stood several of the Alliance's most influential or powerful members. Adora stood between Glimmer and Bow, and flanking them she could see Mermista, Micha, Perfuma and Scorpia. The sight of such a tough team drew a small sigh of relief from Catra's lips. No matter what Sivtria might be up to, she'd have a hard time doing damage past the likes of them.

As she approached them, she tried to stand straight and walk with confidence. It was the way she had walked back when she'd run the Horde, emulating Hordak's arrogant strut and vaguely condescending air of confidence, not to mention making it look so

much better than he did. When she was still a significant distance away, she picked up the sounds of polite chatter between Sivtria's entourage over the wonder of such an ancient artifact as Darla surviving intact and functional.

She wanted their take on the interaction thus far without supervision from Tarsis, so she picked up a handful of rocks and threw them until one bounced off Adora's back. She looked around, frowning, then brightened when she saw Catra. She leaned close to Glimmer and Catra heard her murmur, "Catra's here. I'm going to go fill her in and bring her back."

Glimmer turned, gave Catra a tense smile, then nodded at Adora before turning back toward Darla and the diplomats. Adora jogged up to Catra, wearing an odd expression that might have represented concern or agitation, or merely intense boredom. "What's up?" Catra asked, keeping her voice low and backing up still further as Adora tried to close the distance, paranoid over how sharp Sivtria's hearing may or may not be.

Adora rolled her eyes and pulled a face. "Sivtria reminds me a lot of Shadow Weaver," she whispered back, following Catra's lead on volume.

"Oh, great… *awesome* ," Catra muttered back, careful to keep her face neutral so that the visitors wouldn't read her expressions.

"I know you had to go handle stuff with Hordak before you heard him brief us, but he pretty much just said that Sivtria may have been around 1,000 years ago to witness the last magic vanish from the universe."

"Oh shit," Catra said. "Bitch is old."

Adora sighed and crossed her arms. "Yeah, and she might even have had something to do with it."

Catra grabbed Adora's arms and uncrossed them. "Put your hands on your hips or something. Remember you're the badass here, not them."

Adora nodded and followed her instructions before continuing, "He also made the point that if Prime kept her around for so long, chances are it wasn't for any good reason."

Catra nodded and frowned. "For sure. Did he say anything else?" Adora shook her head and she pulled out the communicator she'd brought along. "Look at what he sent me," she said, handing the opened message to Adora.

She bit her bottom lip. "He… is he really that worried?" she asked, looking back up at Catra and returning the communicator.

"I don't know, but I think underestimating her is the worst thing we could do right now."

Adora heaved a sigh and moved to cross her arms before she caught herself and put her hands back on her hips. "Well, we did a tour and she did a lot of talking. She came in with the whole 'oh, thank you so much, you saved the universe from Prime, blah blah blah.' I guess Tarsis had magic before Prime took it, and it's like this big wound in the planet's past or whatever."

"And?" Catra prompted, though not impatiently.

"And she was *super* condescending the entire time. You know how Shadow Weaver was so good at making someone feel inferior?" At Catra's expression, she continued, "Right. Of course you do. Well it was mostly a bunch of that. Acting like we don't value our magic as much as Tarsis did before they lost theirs, or like, hinting that we're not doing enough with it? Like not using the magic to help enough people or making it more available and stuff."

"But she's also acting like she just wants to make sure we're all okay and that the magic is being protected and looked after properly?" Catra guessed, rolling her eyes.

"Exactly."

"Yeah, this bitch is Shadow Weaver all over." Catra looked past Adora at them again. "Where the fuck is Melog?"

Adora shrugged, looking around as well. “Hang on, Sivtria is talking to Glimmer again. We should get back to them.”

Catra nodded and followed as they strode as quickly as they could without trotting, listening hard to what Sivtria was saying.

“So you were his prisoner? And he held you while you negotiated?” Her face was the picture of concern. “Poor child, so young to be in the clutches of such a being. You must be very, very strong.”

Glimmer blushed as Catra and Adora arrived at her side and deflected. “This is Catra. She was also a prisoner on the Velvet Glove, and she saved my life.”

Sivtria turned toward her and bowed her glittering head graciously. “Another brave Etherian. It seems yours is quite the race of heroes.”

Catra shrugged, squinting at the foreign Queen before asking, “What was it like for you? When you had to deal with Prime. How did you survive?” she tried to make her voice sound impressed and apologetic.

She felt the Etherians around her stiffen, but Sivtria gave her a gentle smile. “I flattered him, of course.” That tracked, and Catra imagined it was likely the truth. The Queen of Tarsis sighed wearily and continued to the group at large, “I am only a queen. I have only ever been, and will only ever be, a queen. He wanted to be a god, and he became one. Once I realized he was capable, it was already over, and a queen has no choice but to bow to a god.” Catra’s eyes flicked to Glimmer’s and she worried that she saw sympathy there. “Until you,” Sivtria said, bringing her shining palms together before her. “Until Etheria took his power, brought him low, and freed us all. God’s reign of terror is finally over.” She made a dramatic show of a deep bow and her entourage mimicked her. Glimmer rubbed an arm uncomfortably and Adora shifted on her feet.

“Why do you think he kept you around?” Catra asked, trying to maintain the pressing conversation. “Why would Prime have let you keep so much power?” Sivtria cocked her head and narrowed her eyes slightly at Catra, considering her. “You *are* powerful, aren’t you? We heard you were one of the most powerful forces beneath Prime.”

“You flatter us,” she said, bowing her head again. “I’m surprised he allowed me to live for so long as well. I often hoped that he believed Tarsis to be useful, but I think it more likely that he was merely waiting for a convenient time to subsume us and our territories.” She waved a hand delicately. “Regardless of his intent or reasoning, we all knew it was but a matter of time before we ended up on the proverbial chopping block. We were well aware he never intended our privilege to be permanent.” A shadow that seemed genuine crossed her face. “There was nothing we could do to stop him. All we could do was try to buy our people time.”

Glimmer sighed and gave her a sad smile. “I understand that feeling. It’s an awful position to find yourself in." Sivtria nodded and smiled down at the young Queen.

In the next instant, however, several things happened in very quick succession. Catra heard the sound of running feet pound toward them at high speed and the sound of Melog’s vicious roar sent a thrill of dread through Catra’s body. Sivtria did not break eye contact with Glimmer, did not jump, did not even change her facial expression other than the briefest narrowing of her eyes. Yet, before Catra had even managed to scream for Melog to stop, her arm had shot out straight, lightning fast, and she caught Melog around the throat before they reached her. They became visible again, pawing and kicking at the glittering Queen, choking through her iron grip.

Before anyone could make another move, she threw Melog over all their heads as if they weighed nothing, and they hit the ground hard at least twenty feet away, rolling a few times before finally halting. They sprang back to their feet, snarling, but Catra leapt before them, holding her arms out wide to keep them from

attacking again. She heard the rest of the group slowly approach from behind and sensed Sivtria drawing near her. Then a cold, hard hand rested on her shoulder and she tensed, her tail bushing as she listened to Melog. Adora, Bow, and Glimmer hurried to join Catra between Melog and Sivtria.

"Ah. Yes. Krytis," Sivtria said in a low voice above Catra. The Etherians all turned to stare at her in shock. Catra took a few reflexive steps away from her, turning to face her fully as all the hair on her body rose again. "Another magical world that met a tragic end. I could not save it."

Adora, Bow and Glimmer all exchanged looks, but Catra shook her head slowly, taking another step backward. "That's not what Melog says…" Everyone switched their gazes back to Catra and she felt her heart rate rise with her nervousness. "Melog says you sold them out. You delivered them to Prime." The eyes of her fellow Etherians widened with alarm and returned to Sivtria. "You said you wanted to protect the magic, but you sold them out."

She and her friends moved slightly closer together as Sivtria regarded them passively. "We did not survive Prime with clean hands," she finally said, raising a crystalline eyebrow at them. "We had to make grievous sacrifices and compromises to last this long."

She heard Glimmer's and Micah's knuckles crack as they both clenched their fists at their sides. "Tell us what happened, and tell us the truth, right now," the Queen said slowly, in a deadly serious tone.

Sivtria seemed utterly unphased as she gave her entourage a sympathetic, long-suffering look. "Sweet child. How noble you all are." Catra fought the urge to sneer. "In exchange for our lives, I surrendered my world's magic to him."

After a few angry meows and a hiss from behind her, Catra interrupted, "and then used your knowledge of magic to betray other magical planets to Prime."

She stared at them and folded her hands before her. “I did what I had to do to keep my planet alive. If you've been to Krytis, then you've seen the alternative.” Her manner stayed demure, but Catra knew the jig was up. They didn’t trust her and she knew it.

Melog stepped forward, still red but much calmer, bumping her hand with their nose and growling quietly. “Time out. Team? Huddle up,” she commanded tersely. She marched off a little ways before turning back to Glimmer, Bow and Adora, who hadn’t moved. “Hello?” she asked, waving them toward her. They looked around in uncertainty before approaching her. “Okay, tell me why we’re tolerating this lady again?” she asked, very genuinely confused.

“Diplomacy.” Glimmer said simply. “As much as I might want to, I can’t just tell her to fuck off. I’m the Queen and Adora’s the benevolent hero. It would reflect terribly on Etheria.” Adora shrugged in helpless agreement.

“Sooo…” Catra squinted at them each in turn. “Can *I* tell her to fuck off? Because I’m totally down to be the asshole, you know me.”

They all looked at each other before Glimmer shrugged. “Actually I don’t see a problem with that, as long as we can act like we’re shocked and appalled. Anyone else?”

Bow and Adora shook their heads and Catra rubbed her hands together in excitement. “Yes!” she hissed before leading the others back toward the party from Tarsis.

“Wind her up and watch her go,” she heard Adora mutter to Glimmer, lending to her smirk.

“Alright lady,” she said, trying to reel herself back into some semblance of politeness to start out with. “You don’t have to go away angry, we can all still be civil about this, but we’re going to need to you leave. There needs to be more distance between us before we figure out how we feel about you.” She walked up close

and planted her hands on her hips, feet spread apart in a strong stance.

Instead of getting angry or being offended, Sivtria let a slow grin split her face, though her eyes stayed unnervingly still and cold. “I see we’ve finally dropped our tedious pretense,” she smiled. “Very good, children. Very good indeed.” She gestured to the other Etherians around them, as if in congratulations. “But we will be finishing this conversation before we return to Tarsis.” Catra bared her fangs and clenched her jaw, glaring.

She sensed hostility begin to rise in her teammates and resolved to follow Glimmer and Micah’s lead and keep her stance non combative. “Is that so?”

Instead of answering directly, Sivtria let deep, bubbling laughter spill from her mouth, her eyes crinkling with much more genuine mirth. Her laugh was beautiful, but it sounded cruel. “A passel of whelps like you won’t be meddling with Tarsis’ affairs. You will be answering my questions, promptly and honestly.”

Glimmer touched Catra’s arm before she could fire back and cut in. “Ask your questions.”

Catra shot a scowl over at the Queen but agreed. Now was not the time for a fight. Instead, she kept frowning as Sivtria continued breezily. “Clever girl,” she said to Glimmer, “I wish to know what you are doing with your magic.”

Glimmer glanced around at them before saying firmly, “Explain.”

“What you’ve shown me is… charming,” she said, and the disdain that dripped from her tone made Catra want to hit her. “But I do wonder, now that you’ve unlocked the secrets of the First Ones, why aren’t you doing more with such powerful knowledge?” Catra very much hoped Adora had managed not to react to Sivtria’s words. “The scientific nature of your innovations are, excuse my candor,” she smiled widely again, “shockingly primitive. A paltry measure for your people, considering the value you claimed to see

in them.” Her eyes zeroed in on Adora’s face and her lids lowered lazily. “Surely, you’re channeling such a wondrous resource into something more productive. The universe is still full of predators, children.” She continued to smile and stare at Adora. “Please tell me your people are protected.”

“And why the fuck would we tell you about how we’re using our power?” Catra asked, trying to bluff over whatever Adora’s face might be revealing.

“How are you keeping the Velvet Glove suspended above your atmosphere? It’s engines are silent, and even if your magic didn’t interfere with technology, there aren’t any mechanisms still in place to hold it in orbit. What about the field of your magic interferes so successfully with technology? How did you rediscover the secrets of dead cultures?”

Catra felt Adora twitch beside her and glanced over in time to see her face harden. Again, she tried to deflect from answers they didn’t have. “Again, we’re not about to tell you. So why don’t you get back to wherever you came from, and leave us the fuck alone?”

Sivtria’s terrible smile returned to bisect her face. “You don’t know, do you?” She looked around at the Etherian’s faces, pulling her shoulders back and lifting her chin. "You have no idea how it works. You don’t have the secrets, you only benefited from them.” Nervous energy began to rise around her and Melog growled louder. Sivtria sighed and shook her head, still smiling. “Imagine! Here I am trying to assess your threat level, and what do I find? A collection of infants who have stumbled their way into accidental supremacy.” Her cruel laugh sounded again.

“We didn’t accidentally beat Prime. We fought and we sacrificed until we brought him down,” Glimmer said, anger clear in her voice. “We were stronger than him. And we killed him.”

Sivtria smiled down at them, completely at ease. “Hardly,” she chuckled. “You are nothing but a world lost to time and progress.”

She raised her eyebrows at them, her smile growing more confident and condescending by the second. “To say that we lost significant respect for Horde Prime when he was defeated by the likes of you would be quite an understatement.” She clasped her hands together and walked right through their midst, heedless of their aggressive stances and looking around herself as if appraising new property. “Your planet was lost for too long, children. It’s magic has gone feral.” A chill ran up Catra’s spine as Sivtria turned back to them, robes swishing gracefully. “It’s become wild, full of rage and aimless. No elders have passed down the wisdom necessary to guide such magic effectively.” She laughed again, as if to herself. “Of course it’s gone feral. And of course Horde Prime had no idea what he was doing, the brutish fool.” She took a deep breath and slowly lowered her gaze to regard the Etherians. Again, her smile was vaguely apologetic as she lowered her folded hands and tilted her head toward them. “But I am not Prime, children. I am something altogether different, and I know exactly what I’m doing.”

Chapter End Notes

If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you’ve got. It is very much appreciated.

"...even the bravest hearts must be tended,”

Chapter Summary

> After the diplomatic conflict, the alliance tries to remind themselves of their progress.

Chapter Notes

> FYI, this series is a post-canon story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization angle. So uh, expect all the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you’re dealing with tough stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anybody for anything.
> Centered around Catra and Hordak. Aged up significantly for super adult themes, but it's still set in the canon universe so truth spells are a thing and the only sociopath involved was Prime. If you’re not into easy redemptions or quick-fixes for Catra and Hordak, I totally get it, but I spent a lot of time and effort on hashing shit out in the five stories leading up to this one, and you are welcome to inspect those to your heart’s content.
> Thank you, and happy reading :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Of course it’s gone feral. And of course Horde Prime had no idea what he was doing, the arrogant fool.” She took a deep breath and slowly lowered her placid gaze to the Etherians. “But I am not Prime, children. I am something altogether different, and I know *exactly* what I’m doing.”

They were on their back foot and Catra knew that was a very bad thing. She scrambled for a moment in the tense silence as she tried to think of a way to parry Sivtria’s menace, but she was flustered and agitated as she saw Micah, Perfuma and Mermista step nearer in her periphery.

Although no other Etherians had addressed Sivtria since Catra had arrived, their presences were loud as they raised their guards, and she felt the energy heighten around her. Catra realized that although they were nervous, none of them were frightened. They'd taken too much shit for far too long to be pushed around by some snooty asshole on their own homeworld. For a moment, Catra was tempted with pride. Then she realized that their meeting was devolving toward violence too fast for common sense to keep up, and became desperate to stop the breakdown. But, she realized through her rising stress, she'd already tried to call things off, tried to kick them out. Sivtria clearly wasn't interested in making anything easy.

Of all people to come to their rescue in this diplomatic fiasco, Catra would never have guessed it would be Adora's fucking horse. "SWIIIIFT WIIIIIIIIIIIIND," the loud-mouthed equine bellowed in his strong tenor, swooping down from the sky with Wrong Hordak clinging to his back. "What's going on here? What's happening?" he shouted aimlessly as Wrong Hordak hopped off and they walked toward the assembly. "What's upsetting Adora?" he swung his head around, looking at them all as they stared back in stunned silence. When he saw that nobody was fighting and Adora was standing just as confused as everyone else, his ears and head lowered slightly. "I felt a weird thing. It reminded me of the war and I didn't like it."

The jarring interruption was exactly what Catra needed. Watching Swift Wind and Wrong Hordak looking from each other, to Adora, back to each other- it was absurd enough that the slow laughter now spilling from Catra was actually genuine. And this laugh was a good one. She started low and slow, built with the regular arc, and ended with a gut-deep cackle. She even had a bit of extra moisture to wipe from her eye when she'd finally stopped and had everyone's attention. "Whatever," she laughed, still gaining control of her voice. "You said you wanted to assess what threat we posed to you." She blinked hard for focus and took a deep breath, recomposing herself. "Now, if you're done telling us how defenseless we are, would you kindly fuck the fuck off already?"

“Don’t think I’m underestimating you, little ones,” Sivtria murmured gently, as if soothing them, “I’m sure your magic is powerful indeed to have defeated Prime. But you are young, naïve, and foolish.”

She rolled her eyes. “*And what*? We still kicked his ass and we can kick yours too. Don’t make us prove it.” Catra waited for Sivtria to open her mouth and begin speaking so that she could interrupt her, which she did. “Right, right, right… the ‘secrets of the first ones’ and all that crap.”

A vaguely amused smile continued to play on Sivtria's lips. “Secrets that are valuable enough won’t stay hidden forever,” she said, looking between them before raising an eyebrow. “Though with your reckless eagerness for conflict, you might not live to see your secrets brought to light.”

“What the fuck is that supposed to mean?” Catra said. She felt her fellow Etherians square up across from Sivtria and her diplomats. “Are you already trying to threaten us?”

“I am merely referencing what you yourselves flaunt,” she laughed again and swept her arm out in a grand and elegant motion, but this time she nearly sounded exasperated. Her arm stayed up, however, and Catra realized she was gesturing at Wrong Hordak. “You welcome in enemies like abandoned strays, forgetting that you are as vulnerable to their treachery as Prime was.”

“The clones aren’t treacherous,” Scorpia growled. The sound shocked Catra and she felt her tail bush out slightly.

Sivtria took a few steps toward Wrong Hordak, who appeared vaguely confused as she looked him up and down, cruel smile in place. “You even allowed them to keep their Horde whites? He wears the symbol of your greatest foe on your very soil.” She turned back to them, positively sneering. “Such is the reckless ignorance of which I speak.”

The next to speak was Glimmer, and her tone was as deadly as Scorpia's had been. "Were there clones on Tarsis?" she asked in a low, calm voice. Another chill shot down Catra's spine and her tail bushed further.

"Of course there were, is it not customary to station troops among allies on Etheria?"

"And what did you do with them when they lost the Hive Mind?" Perfuma asked. Catra began to feel a sickly sinking sensation in her gut as dread slowly overwhelmed her wariness.

"We isolated the potential threat they represented in quarantined sectors for a time," she said casually, as if they were chatting over brunch. "They were quite peaceful about things. Shockingly obedient, aren't they?" Catra's gut clenched and she heard Adora's breathing grow shallow. "But of course," she made her fake-sympathetic face at them, "when we heard it was a rogue clone who murdered Prime, we were only affirmed in our instincts. For a clone to be capable of turning on his master…" she shook her head with in mournful disapproval.

"What did you do?" Scorpia demanded, and this time tiny sparks of red electricity flashed at the tips of her claws. Catra had a feeling she knew exactly what Sivtria had done.

Sivtria quirked an amused brow at the display, still smirking at them with clear disdain. "We didn't survive Prime by taking chances on who to trust." She sighed and rolled her eyes. "I knew you were simple, but I thought you'd at least understand that much."

"*What did you do*?!" Perfuma shouted.

Finally, Sivtria's smile widened with genuine satisfaction over the answer she had to give them. "We liquidated every vestige of Prime left in our territories, which is exactly what you should do here." Nobody breathed, and her smile glittered.

Waves of anger so powerful that Catra could feel them were rolling from Adora, who was staring at Sivtria with an expression Catra had never seen her wear before. The closest she could remember was the day of the portal failure, when she looked at Catra after Angella had sacrificed herself for them. She realized with a flash of nervousness that what she was looking at was hatred. Hatred fueled by pure, righteous rage. Her hands were clenched into fists at her sides and were trembling badly.

"How many?" Bow asked Sivtria, eyes closed and face screwed up against his own words.

"How many what?" Sivtria asked, feigning confusion.

"How many dead?" He ground out between clenched teeth.

"Dead clones?"

"Dead people!" Bow bellowed into her face, spitting in his fury. "How many dead people?"

As Sivtria grinned widely down at his brazen emotion with no sign of an answer, rumbling sounded around them and their gazes were all drawn back to Adora. "How dare you?" she said shakily, now glowing. As tears spilled from her eyes, they began to blaze bright blue. Her hair pulled from its ponytail and started floating on localized wind as she shouted, "HOW. DARE. YOU."

Catra exchanged looks with several other princesses, all thinking the same thing. This was different. This felt dangerous. "Uh, guys…" Swift Wind said nervously as Adora's eyes glowed brighter and Sivtria's expression grew more interested. "This is not good. This is not good, they need to go away, right now."

She realized what Adora was doing just in time to act. As she raised her hand slowly, opening her palm and mouth to summon her sword, Catra lunged and grabbed her arm. Adora's head snapped around, and Catra felt icey fear at the expression she now aimed down at her.

“Go. Go right now! Go!” Micah shouted at the party from Tarsis as the diplomats behind Sivtria pressed closer together.

Cracks of light began to appear in the ground below Adora, slowly branching out. Her hair began to blow straight upward and none of the rage eased from her features as she stared down at Catra, who was still holding fast to the other’s forearm.

“Go!” Bow shouted, and in her periphery vision Catra saw him raise his bow and and aim his arrow aimed directly at Sivtria, though he did not release it.

The crystal queen smiled her cruel smile one more time before saying calmly, “We were never actually here, silly boy." She turned to address Glimmer. "You’re going to wish you had me on your side before the end. I am but one. There are many more.” Then she snapped her fingers, and the delegation vanished.

Catra kept the focus of her gaze on Adora’s face as the rest of the remaining party stood and stared. Adora’s face continued to reflect pure rage as her manner oozed venom, and the skin beneath Catra’s palm began to warm uncomfortably.

“Adora, please,” she said, tears now coming to her own eyes. Adora didn’t move, but her hair stopped whipping around quite so fiercely. Her eyes were still glowing though, even as tears still streamed from them. “I’m angry too,” Catra said.

Finally, the glowing from within and beneath Adora abated and her eyes went back to normal, if tearful. She let the arm that Catra was still holding drop limply at her side and lowered her eyes to the ground. Catra stood and hugged her briefly, pulling away when she didn’t respond. Nobody seemed to know what to do as they approached, gathering nearer to Adora.

A giant, clawed blue hand appeared on Adora’s shoulder as Wrong Hordak reached her, ears drooping low. “It’s alright, brother. Don’t cry,” he said gently as the others pressed closer together. “We’re doing our best.”

* * * * *

Hordak was about to completely disregard his prisoner status and show up in Bright Moon without permission. He had his cloak in hand, was in the throne room on his way to the Salineas portal, and was planning out his excuses when a puff of pink glitter heralded the appearance of Queen Glimmer and a large portion of alliance members. The second he saw Catra and Glimmer he began walking toward them, still limping slightly even after the magicians ministrations.

"...well I love that it's wild," Catra was saying. "That's exactly how magic should be, big and scary and weird and old and awesome."

"Yeah, Glimmer agreed, "If they don't like it then clearly they're in the wrong place."

"Petty ass space snob," Catra muttered.

"Hello, my broody friend!" Sea Hawk called merrily when he spotted Hordak. "What draws you out from your layer today?"

Hordak ignored him and opened his mouth to ask about the meeting, but Catra cut him off. "Nobody's dead, we're fine," Catra drawled. "No need to come rushing to our rescue." She rolled her eyes at him as the group gathered near.

"I," he stalled, taken aback. Then he straightened and folded his hands behind the small of his back, conveniently holding his cloak out of sight. "I have every confidence in the Alliance's ability to conduct successful dealings with Tarsis," he said stiffly, avoiding

Catra's gaze. I was merely on my way to leave a message for Princess Mermista."

"Uh-huh," Catra affirmed sarcastically. Melog meowed at him and he shot them a glare.

"Message about what?" Mermista asked.

"We must discuss the water supply among the refugees at Salineas," he said, trying to sound casual enough to keep her from changing the subject.

"And the living conditions," Catra added, giving her a significant look, "but that can wait."

Mermista sighed. "Right. The shiny lady with the ego." Hordak pressed his lips together, nervous at her obvious lack of respect for the foreign politician.

"Talks with Tarsis… broke down," Glimmer said.

"What do you mean?" he asked ominously. Sivtria was not somebody they wanted as an enemy.

"I mean they broke down," Glimmer said defensively, crossing her arms. "They started well enough, all fake and tense like diplomacy always is."

"What did she want?" He asked.

"She wanted to see our magic," Catra said. "Kept asking us how it worked."

"And she seemed pretty happy about it when she realized we've got no clue," Bow said.

Hordak closed his eyes and pinched the bridge of his nose. "I don't suppose you parted ways as allies."

Adora snorted derisively. “We don’t need her to be our ally. We don’t need anything to do with her.”

Hordak looked up at her, annoyed. “What happened?”

“She was a giant fucking bitch and then she told us she killed all the clones in Tarsis territory,” Catra answered, crossing her arms and frowning at Hordak.

“And?” he prompted. “Did you insult her?”

“How can that matter to you right now?” Adora shouted, drawing a confused look from Catra.

Hordak gritted his teeth. “I am concerned we gave Tarsis a reason to turn on us," he said, forcing patience, "We are in no position to be making enemies right now.”

“What is wrong with you?” Adora shot back at high volume. Everyone else stared, open mouthed as he focused on controlling his breathing and heart rates. “How are you more angry at *us* for telling her to fuck off than you are at *her* for killing a ton of your brothers?”

“Because I do not have the luxury of mourning!” Hordak shouted back before another pang in his chest stopped him short. He covered the brightly glowing crystal beneath his dress with his fingers and lowered his voice. “And we do not have the luxury of taking the moral high ground when we are so vulnerable to a universe full of predators.”

Adora glared right back. “You’re wrong,” she said. “Doing the right thing isn’t a luxury. You’re just scared.” She hit a cord and he couldn’t keep his lip from curling. Adora gave him her own look of disgust. “All of this was wrong,” she said, her voice raising again as her eyes grew overbright. “I should have killed her when I had the chance. I should have put her down like Prime,” she cried so loudly her voice cracked before turning and running from the room.

He stood with the others in stunned silence before Catra started jogging after Adora. She paused before she'd gone far and addressed Hordak. "It'll be fine, they just don't get it," she said before turning and running the way Adora had exited.

Several more moments of silence stretched and Hordak lowered his eyes to the ground, suddenly feeling the exhaustion he'd been staving off since he'd awoken that morning. "Not mad or anything," Bow said softly at his side, "but what don't we get?"

Hordak heaved an enormous sigh and let his shoulders sag with weariness beneath his armor. "Sometimes there is no right thing to do." He waited another moment, gathering his thoughts, before he turned back to Glimmer and the others. "You said she kept asking how the magic worked?

* * * * *

Catra caught up with Adora before she'd gone very far. She was standing at a window, looking out over Salineas and wiping at the angry tears in her eyes. "Hey Adora," Catra said softly as she slowed to a walk. Adora didn't answer, so she sidled up to look out the same window.

"I hate this," Adora whispered.

"Hate what?"

Adora sniffed hard and shut her eyes tight. "This anger is too big for my body."

Catra’s heart sank and she wrapped an arm tight around her girlfriend, wishing she could make the problem go away. “I know,” she muttered instead.

Adora wiped the last of the witness from her face and shook herself visibly. “I probably shouldn’t have yelled at Hordak. I just... I forgot the star siblings said some worlds were executing their clones. Or maybe I just hoped it was a rumor or something.”

“I thought maybe it was a rumor too," Catra lied, reaching out to scratch Adora's back lightly. "And trust me, Hordak's fine." She snorted and shook her head. "I don’t know shit about shit, and I’m certain about even less. But I know for a fact that Hordak can take a little yelling.” She tried a chuckle and squeezed Adora’s shoulders lightly, earning herself a small smile.

Adora sighed and rubbed her forehead. “We were supposed to be here to talk about Sivtria.”

“The others are handling it,” Catra cajoled. “They all saw what we did. And you’re not going to be much help if you’re too worked up to strategize.”

“But did they feel the vibes you felt?”

“Would you stop worrying?” Catra said, rolling her eyes. “Melog felt more than I did and they’ll make sure Hordak hears it all.”

Adora hesitated, but after a while she nodded and turned back to look out the window.

Catra let thoughtful silence stand for several long moments while both of them sorted through the day’s events. “You okay?” Catra finally asked.

Adora scrunched her face and did not turn from the window. “I don’t feel very okay.”

“Sivtria? Or her Spacebats?”

“Both.”

Catra leaned her head on Adora’s shoulder and sighed heavily. “I know.” She had nothing else to offer, so she kept quiet.

Silence stretched as they both lost themselves in thought, staring out the same window with Catra’s arm still slung around Adora. She was about to go check on the meeting when they heard one of the doors they’d come through open and shut. They shared a look and stepped away from the window to wait for the next door to open. When Glimmer, Bow, Scorpia and Perfuma walked through and saw them, Glimmer walked up to hug Adora tightly. Melog ran and leapt at Catra, knocking her to the floor so they could lay on top of her.

“Done so soon?” Catra asked from the floor. ‘*You okay, buddy? I’m sorry you had to see her.*’ she added silently to Melog. They mrped at her sadly and rubbed their face against her cheek.

“Not much to discuss,” Glimmer said, releasing Adora so that Bow could hug her and crossing to pet Melog. "We still don't know exactly why she decided to come here in person, and it went about as badly as it could have without getting in a fist fight." She shrugged helplessly.

Perfuma was next to hug Adora, and Scorpia wrap them both in a tight embrace. “Anyway, we… hngh, we were thinking-” Perfuma grunted from where she was sandwiched between the two larger women, though she made no move to escape.

“Do you guys want to come visit some of our clone friends with us?” Bow asked, offering a kind of sad half-smile. “Just… see them safe and happy?”

Catra looked over to meet Adora’s eyes as Scorpia finally released them. She had shit to do, but Adora was forever her first priority. They smiled and nodded in unison, linking arms with their friends so that Glimmer could take them away.

First, the little group went to the place in Bright Moon where rows of tents had provided temporary shelter the night that Prime Died. Now, however, several large new buildings and a huge hangar had been constructed near the tree line. Between themselves and the buildings, clones and Etherians seemed to be running drills together, or else practicing different modes of combat.

"Adora!" Swift Wind's shout brought her head snapping around toward the talking horse, now approaching them with Wrong Hordak.

"I'm gonna go find the guys," Bow said hurriedly, already peeling away toward the buildings.

"Me too," Glimmer called, running after.

Perfuma and Scorpia hugged Wrong Hordak the second he was in reach and they held the pose while Melog twined through and rubbed against their legs. Swift Wind shook out his mane and stepped near Adora, bowing his head slightly for neck rubs. "How are you?" he asked her gently.

"I feel a little better now," she said, leaning her head against his neck and closing her eyes. Catra reached out and gave him a few pats herself. "How about you, Swifty?"

"Ah, I'm fine. I'm not scared of that old grump or her dumb kingdom," he said soothingly.

"Come along, brothers," Wrong Hordak said as Scorpia finally released her hold. "See what is being achieved here."

They walked leisurely across the field that Bow and Glimmer had just run over. Perfuma rode Swift Wind so she could braid flowers into his mane as he talked animatedly and Adora and Catra held hands. "What you're looking at there," Swift Wind said as they approached a roped off area where a dozen or so clones and Etherians sparred happily, surrounded by another handful of Etherians taking careful notes, "is clones teaching us everything they know about different kinds of combat, and Etherians using

their help to develop new knowledge around fighting much bigger, stronger opponents." As he spoke, a reedy looking young man managed to redirect a Clone's attack and knock him off his feet once his balance was compromised. They both exchanged cheerful words as the smaller helped the larger back up.

Bow and Glimmer appeared next to them in a sparkling pink cloud. "Come see what Truth and Dale are working on in the hangar," Bow said, gesturing the group further on.

"The third guy named himself Dale?" Catra muttered sideways at Glimmer, who smacked her arm playfully. Melog meowed at her and she rolled her eyes.

"So this is all military stuff, huh?" Scorpia asked toward Swift Wind and Wrong Hordak as Bow caught back up with them.

"Official go-ahead from the alliance just came down last week," Bow said, "but you're looking at the beginnings of a space worthy, standing Etherian military."

Catra cocked her head as she listened, holding Adora's hand while they walked again. "It's so obvious, I don't know why we didn't think of it sooner," Swift Wind continued.

Wrong Hordak answered the rhetorical question happily. "Etherians usually want to try things their way and fail before considering less familiar options."

"So, a lot of clones," began Bow.

"Like *a lot* a lot," interjected Swift Wind.

"About a full third of all the clones that ended up on Etheria were having a really hard time adjusting to mainstream civilian society," Bow explained. "And that ratio was lowering slowly, but too slowly to call temporary, you know?"

"Hang on," Glimmer interrupted with a small laugh. "What's going on over there?" They all stopped and looked out at what she was

pointing to. Some distance away, it looked like a distraught Etherian was pontificating to a loose clump of soldiers, mostly clones, who were lounging over one another on the sweet-smelling grass."

"Uuuhhh…" Bow said, squinting. "It looks like Eduardo is trying to explain why strength training and exercise is important again."

"In the Horde, our physiques were maintained via electrical manipulation during periodic stasis," Wrong Hordak explained in his ever-upbeat manner. "Clones do not understand why we must learn lengthy, boring, and potentially injurious exercise routines when the electrical system still works perfectly well."

"Because exercise is *good for you* , and it's an important thing to know how to do," Swift Wind said pointedly.

"But *whyyyy*?" Wrong Hordak whined.

"Yeah, we might not be totally ready to fight Tarsis," Catra whispered at Adora's ear.

"Anyway," Scorpia said while Perfuma giggled into her hand, "what was going on with the clones? Were they having problems with names, or…" she trailed off in uncertainty.

"No, most of them are fine with names," Bow hesitated, "It's more…. like… everything else."

"You want to have a really wild time, try explaining capitalism to a clone," Swift Wind interjected. "It is a transformative experience."

"It's a major hang-up for a lot of them, they're so communal by nature," Bow continued. "I mean, none of them have ever used money or owned anything. Plus their priority is to each other instead of themselves, you know?"

"But why make them participate in the things they don't like or understand when we've got options?" Swift Wind continued. "An Etherian martial force will be a system that we already know how

to make and they already know how to participate in! It's the structure and security they crave, and as much duty and fulfilling labor as they could ask for," he cried, throwing his head back in triumph and nearly head-butting Perfuma.

"It's a very, very long way from perfect," Bow broke in, "and it'll definitely be a work in progress for a very long time, but we're excited about the potential we see here." They reached the civilian door and Bow opened it up for them. "Dale?" he called. "Truth?"

Truth, with the blue roots and eyes waved happily at them as Dale, with the yellow eyes and pink roots, approached them with a matching smile, wiping mechanical grease from his hands. Adora and Catra stayed focused long enough to hear about the lasers and shields, but glazed over as Truth and Dale expounded upon the process of retrofitting Prime's available armada. Catra didn't process a single word from the clones' mouths as she peered around the hangar, determinately avoiding Melog's disapproving looks and marveling at the scale of everything around her. She had thought the hangar was gigantic until she saw the little bits of spaceship it housed. She hoped some of the manuals they were no doubt developing would include graphics with size comparisons.

Neither she nor Adora realized the conversation was over before they were seized by their friends and teleported into Plumeria. The light and surrounding noise changed, and the sudden onslaught of pollen triggered a sneezing fit in Catra. She growled at Bow between sneezes as he giggled and cooed at the sounds she made. Finally, Catra managed a rushed "fuckyouBow," after her last sneeze and leaned over on her knees, catching her breath while Adora lightly thumped her on the back.

"There they are!" Perfuma cried, and Catra looked up through streaming eyes to see her pointing across the central meadow at Daisy and Moonshine.

"Oh, oh gosh, come here. Come here boys," Scorpia half-sobbed in a strangled voice as the four rushed to meet each other, alarm

all over the clones' faces. Perfuma flung her arms around Moonshine and burst into tears, while Scorpia caught Daisy up in a bone crushing hug, lifting him up off the ground and swinging him back and forth. "I will never, ever, ever…" she set him down and traded brothers with Perfuma, picking Moonshine up to repeat the process, "ever let anyone liquidate you. Do you hear me?"

"Awe," Bow said, watching the two princesses have miniature emotional breakdowns all over the baffled clones.

Catra finally regained her composure as Truth stepped toward her and Adora. "We heard about your meeting with Sivtria," he said, slate blue eyes as soft as his tone. "Needless suffering is a bitter thing to feel." Dale gently patted the tops of their heads in what was apparently a gesture of sympathy.

"How are you guys so calm about it?" Adora asked, but there was no accusation in her tone, only pain and the desire to escape it.

Truth took a deep breath and looked away thoughtfully. "They are muddled, but most clones have memories of foreign wars."

"So it's nothing new, huh?" Catra suggested, offering a sympathetic half-smile that was not returned.

"I don't remember such orderly erasure," Dale said, squinting into the distance. "But I do remember such anger."

Catra heard Adora swallow beside her as she asked, "Anger?"

Dale nodded. "I remember a fortress that changed hands multiple times. I was part of a reclamation effort, I think…" he scrunched his stumpy nose, thinking hard, "yes… yes we were there to take it back from the Natives…." he gestured vaguely with one hand, "the natives had taken it back from us…" he gestured with the other hand, "after we took it from them…" he switched his hands in mid air before him. "Yes, I think that's right." He heaved a sigh and recentered himself, smiling politely. "Regardless, as an act of revenge, the Natives used my brother's bodies to decorate the fortress walls and gates."

At their appalled expressions, Dale and Truth looked at each other, then at Wrong Hordak, who shrugged. "Considering the destruction we brought," Truth said, "such bitterness is to be expected."

Dale nodded, yellow eyes serious. "If an outside force were to treat Etheria as we treated planets under Prime, our brothers and ourselves would be equally as distraught."

"Oh," Adora said faintly.

"Alright, alright," Glimmer interrupted loudly. "Nobody needs to be worrying about decorative corpses, okay people? This is Etheria. We're past that."

"Weeeeell I'm going to take the guys to see all the kinds of apples they grow here," Swift Wind said loudly. "Want to come?"

Glimmer, Adora, and Catra exchanged looks before Bow said, "Actually, Glimmer and I had apples for breakfast, so we're pretty much appled out."

"Me too," Adora said. "Just, wow, so many apples." Catra nodded in agreement and hoped she wouldn't have to dignify the terrible lie with repetition.

Swift Wind, however, was already walking away with Wrong Hordak, Truth and Dale. "Your loss," he called cheerfully before addressing his attentive companions. "So there's not as many kinds of apples here as in Alwyn, but there is one kind of apple that Thaymore doesn't have and that's because *this* kind of apple only grows near the Heart Blossom."

As Swift Wind's voice faded into the background, Perfuma and Scorpia returned to their side after relinquishing Daisy and Moonshine, who still looked as confused as ever. "Alright," Perfuma said with a sigh, patting at her hair while Scorpia sniffed heartily. "Scorpia and I are going to go soak up some comfort in the Platonic Cuddle Hut. Any takers?"

“Did I just hear you say Cuddle Hut?” Bow asked, eyebrow raising.

Once Bow had dragged Glimmer away by the hand after Perfuma and Scorpia, it was just Adora, Melog and Catra, standing in the middle of the central meadow and staring about themselves. In every direction, they saw clones mingling with Etherians in nearly equal numbers. “I forgot just how many of them Plumeria took in,” Catra said as two clones in matching tunics walked by, hand in hand.

“Big Spacebat fans here, I guess,” Adora said with a smirk, eyeing a clone and Etherian snuggling beneath a flowery tree.

Catra was looking over at where a handful of children were literally hanging off one long-suffering clone when Melog meowed up at them. “What do you mean *your* friends?” she replied, frowning down at them. Adora gave her a questioning look and she continued, “Melog says they want to introduce us to some of their friends,” Catra said, trying to remember when Melog had been in Plumeria.

“Does Melog have many friends outside our circle?” Adora asked as Melog trotted off ahead of them, tail raised high in the air.

“Fucking apparently,” Catra grumbled, nodding politely at a cheerfully waving clone in a sun hat that had holes cut out for his ears.

Just past the tree line around the central meadow where the Heart Blossom grew, Adora and Catra found themselves wandering through sparsely-spaced cottages, each with their own trees and little fenced gardens. Plumerians of all ages bustled about their homes, stopping between chores for friendly chats. Here and there, clones joined in the mundane activities, usually smiling and eager to wave at them as they passed.

Melog trilled before they veered off through an open gate, Adora and Catra close behind. They slowed to a stop on a path that led to a quaint, mid-sized cottage, but Melog trotted on to sit beside

the legs of a clone wearing a sarong and a crop top. All white had been cut from his hair, and the color reminded Catra of honey, which she had recently seen in person. On one of his shoulder sat an old woman with little white flowers in her pale pink hair and an important looking gold mantel over her white dress.

“What’s going on here?” Adora whispered to Catra, but she could only shrug.

As both the clone and the old woman reached up into the tree, she instructed him with a strange, slow affect. “To know if a pear is ripe, just ask it. Hold it like this,” she gave the pear in her hand a tilt and a twist, and it dropped freely into her waiting palm, “and if it's ready, it will come to you.”

When she was done talking, Melog meowed for the duo’s attention. “Well hello my strange friend, it’s good to see you again!” the woman said as the clone lifted her down. She grabbed a fancy staff from the trunk of the tree for support as she knelt to pet Melog. Her eyelids were so droopy it looked like she kept her eyes closed, but she noticed Adora and Catra before the clone did.

“I know you,” she said in Adora’s general direction, her face lighting up with a bright smile. “Glen, Ash, come here!” she called over at the cottage. “The She-Ra is visiting!” The clone beside her turned curious, dark yellow eyes on them.

“I’m so sorry to bother you,” Adora began, but the woman was already waving her off.

“Nonsense, nonsense, it is an honor,” she said, still in that odd, dragging lilt. “Cedar,” she looked up at the clone beside her. “I want you to meet Adora, the She-Ra.”

“It is an honor,” Cedar repeated, bowing.

“Oh, no, please,” Adora stammered awkwardly. Catra grinned in wicked satisfaction as Adora blushed.

The door to the cottage banged open and a bearded old man in a long blue tunic came shuffling through. The clone that eased himself out of the too-small doorway after him, like Truth, had roots a similar blue to his skin, but his eyes were soft, sage green. “I finally get to meet her! After hearing about all your fancy royal nonsense, I finally get to meet Etheria’s hero!” the old man crowed, moving at a very slow pace considering the amount of shuffling he was doing. The clone with sage-colored eyes followed patiently behind, taking a step every few seconds.

“Sorry if my cat’s been bugging you,” Catra said to Cedar. “Their name is Melog, and they said they wanted us to meet their friend’s family.”

Cedar smiled widely before he knelt next to Melog, who immediately flopped onto their back for belly rubs. “So you’re called Melog,” he said, scratching the purring feline with a wide smile. “I am glad we are friends.”

“What a slut,” Catra whispered as she watched them roll around, just loudly enough for Adora to hear over Melog’s enthusiastic purring. Adora stifled her snort as she moved to shake hands with the old man, who’d finally made it over.

“Thank you for bringing them to our home, Melog,” the woman said before looking back up at them. “Adora met me as one of Princess Perfuma’s advisors,” she said to Catra. “My name is Poppy, and this is my family. My husband Glen,” she gestured at the beaming old man. “And our boys, Ash and Cedar.” The towering clones both bowed low.

“They look just like you,” Catra said.

Adora made a small choking sound, but the other four all laughed. “My husband and I are a childless couple,” Poppy eventually said, smiling up at the two clones. “Helping out with the kids in the community was always plenty for us, no need to make more. Oh!” She turned toward Ash. "Speaking of community. The nice young man that taught you basket weaving wanted to know if you'd like

to learn how to carve." She winked at him and he blushed furiously.

“Couldn’t tell you what changed,” Glen continued blithely, “but taking these two in just felt right. This family is the best thing we’ve ever done.”

Out of nowhere, Catra’s eyes began to burn with gathering tears. She looked away, horrified, and tried to blink them away as Poppy spoke again. “Funny how families sometimes just… happen.”

Catra wrestled back control in time for Adora to grab one hand and Melog to nose the other, uttering a series of echoing noises. She heaved a sigh and narrowly resisted rolling her eyes. “Melog says they brought us to you for good reason?” she said to Poppy reluctantly.

Thankfully, she seemed to understand what Melog meant as she nodded knowingly. “Forgive me my boldness, young ones,” Poppy said, stepping nearer and looking up at them in turn, “but your auras are thick with sorrow and rage. What fresh tragedy bears down on your shoulders?”

Catra rubbed the back of her neck and looked at Adora to answer. “Uh, yeah. Tragedy’s the word here,” she began haltingly. “We heard about another tragedy today. A really, really dumb one. And there’s nothing we can do about it.” Adora’s voice grew thick and she cleared her throat.

Poppy stepped forward until she could take their hands in each of hers and sighed before turning her face upward. “Young warriors, even the bravest hearts must be tended,” she said cryptically. Catra raised an eyebrow but Melog leaned against her leg, listening hard. “Before the boys and I set up for tea, let me give you one of my peoples’ most beloved proverbs.” Catra and Adora leaned forward slightly at the woman’s serious tone. She took a deep breath, then squeezed their hands and quoted, “Ride easy, my dudes, and ride on.”

* * * * *

After an extremely pleasant tea break with Melog's friends, Catra and Adora found Swift Wind, Wrong Hordak, Dale and Truth on their way to whatever nightmare the Cuddle Hut was. As it happened, the Cuddle Hut was a literal hut devoted to cuddling. When they made it to the wide, open doorway of the squat structure and looked inside, they saw that the floor was a cushion of thick green ground cover dotted with pink blossoms, and luminescent flowers hung from vines along the ceiling. Littered all over the ground were snoozing or lounging Etherians and clones, heads cushioned on one another, sharing lazy murmured conversation or else simply enjoying the ambiance. The combined purring of the conscious clones made the air feel like it was humming, and even Catra could see the appeal of napping in such a comfortable space.

They spotted their friends near a wall, all laying down with closed eyes. Perfuma was sprawled out over Scorpia, whose head was resting on someone’s thigh. Glimmer’s legs were laying on Scorpia’s and Perfuma’s, her upper half was in Bows lap, and Bow’s head was resting on a clone’s stomach. A second clone, tucked into the first one’s side, seemed utterly at peace with his eyes shut and his claws in Bow’s hair, scratching his scalp lazily.

“Hello, friends,” whispered a blonde man near the door with flowers painted on his cheeks. “We welcome you to rest here and be warm for a time before you journey on.”

“Oh, uh,” Catra answered awkwardly as she started to pick her way across the prone forms all over the ground, “no thanks. We’re just picking up.”

“Right on!” he continued in a whisper. “Have a beautiful day.”

“Hey guys,” Catra muttered once she reached her four companions on the ground, unsure of how to rouse them.

Glimmer and Perfuma both stirred slightly, though Scorpia only snored. The clone scratching Bow’s head, however, snatched his hand back suddenly and stammered “Oh, oh my deepest apologies, I thought you were my friend, he was there before-”

“Sh sh sh sh sh,” Bow interrupted without opening his eyes. “Don’t stop.”

Catra snorted and Perfuma opened her eyes, taking a deep breath and smiling up at her blearily. She tapped Scorpia’s shoulder lightly until the larger woman woke with a snort. “C’mon guys, I still have shit to get done and I’m sure you do too,” Catra said, thinking of Chelle. She made her escape from the shockingly pleasant space as Bow whined in protest behind her.

She was still mulling over the situation she’d left in the refugee camp when the others staggered out of the hut one by one. As Octavia’s face swam in her imagination, she turned to Scorpia and asked, “Hard copies of our personnel files would probably still be at the Fright Zone, right?”

Scorpia blinked, disoriented. “Wha… uh.. yes? Yes. Maybe. I would assume so. I don’t see why not.” Wrong Hordak was back on Swift Wind as they approached with Truth and Dale. “Why do you ask? I thought you never wanted to see that place again.”

“Yeah,” Catra said, rubbing the back of her neck and scuffing at the ground with the toe of her boot. “Yeah I was just thinking that some of that information might still be useful, is all.”

Scorpia’s expression was puzzled, but she shrugged. “We can check as soon as the alliance is ready to tackle the Fright Zone. So far as I know though, it’s still radio silence over there.” The rest of their party was all out of the hut by then, stretching and yawning.

Catra sighed and rolled her neck and shoulders. “No worries. The alliance still has plenty to handle before we jump on that dump,”

she said, wondering if Hordak had already addressed the refugees' water issue with Mermista.

"Where is Mushroom today?" Perfuma asked, looking over at the clones. "I'm sure they'd love to show him their progress with the luminescent fungi down in the grotto."

"Mushroom's the weird one, right?" Catra asked. "With the dark eyes?"

Bow, who looked grumpier than usual, scowled at her. "You know, you might be weird too if you'd been created to surgically mutilate infants into programmable cyborgs." Everyone in the group cringed. "But he's with Entrapta, working on the virus."

"Oh fuck me," Catra said, slapping both of her palms to her face as the same realization dawned on Bow's, "*fuck me*."

"Um… n-no?" Truth faltered.

Catra ignored him and dragged her hands down her face with an extended growl. "Stupid Sivtria." She opened her eyes again and glared around at the group. "Guys, we have to wrangle the gang back together into one place again."

"What? Why?" Glimmer asked, rubbing at one of her eyes.

"Because," Catra growled, trying very hard to keep her tone passive, "we fucking forgot Entrapta."

Everyone but the clones exchanged looks of horrified frustration before erupting in aggrieved groans.

Chapter End Notes

> In my head, I imagine Plumerian culture as, like, all the very best intentioned stuff from festival culture. I even got the cuddle hut from one I was dragged into. Normally I am NOT a toucher-like I legitimately do not enjoy hugs. But goddamn, just lounging around with a bunch of other happy humans

flopped over pillows and chit-chatting with friends over head scratches and napping? It sucked me the fuck in. Granted, there was a lot of ecstasy going around at the time, which was probably behind a lot of the cuddliness, but my memories of the cuddle hut are extremely fond.

If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you've got. It is very much appreciated.

"I am confused and concerned,"

Chapter Summary

The gang tries to get their thoughts together after their encounter with Sivtria before they all meet for a chat with Entrapta. Hordak learns more about the way the princesses do friendship, and Catra makes plans for a search.

Chapter Notes

FYI, this series is a post-canon story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization angle. So uh, expect all the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you're dealing with tough stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anybody for anything.
Centered around Catra and Hordak. Aged up significantly for super adult themes, but it's still set in the canon universe so truth spells are a thing and the only sociopath involved was Prime. If you're not into easy redemptions or quick-fixes for Catra and Hordak, I totally get it, but I spent a lot of time and effort on hashing shit out in the five stories leading up to this one, and you are welcome to inspect those to your heart's content.
Thank you, and happy reading :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora and Catra were back in Salineas, walking through the great hall on their way to her room when they happened to cross paths with Hordak, who was wearing his old cloak and skulking his way out of the palace. "Hi, Hordak," Adora said in a tired voice, waving at him wearily.

"Hey, Hordak," Catra said, stepping to waylay him. "Do you know when Entrapta's going to be back tonight?"

“She does not keep a schedule when she is conducting research,” he said, frowning down at them.

She rolled her eyes, but smiled. “Of course she doesn’t. Did you happen to talk to Mermista?”

He nodded. “I am to meet her at the docks come nightfall.”

“Oh yeah, what's wrong with the refugee thing again?” Adora asked, her brow furrowing.

Catra sighed. “The camp here needs some serious attention, but nobody’s in imminent danger. Just war stuff.”

Something about Catra’s expression had caught Adora’s attention. “There’s more to it than that, isn’t there?”

She didn’t want to open the Octavia/Chelle can of worms in front of Hordak, so she deflected. “I think the situation the refugees are in just kind of rattled me, is all. Refugees have always kind of fucked me up, you know? They've just been through so much.” She looked up at Hordak. “There’s got to be something we can do about that, right?”

He was staring off into the distance, and there was something hollow about his expression again. “Certainly material gain will ease their suffering, but I’m afraid refugees are in a uniquely difficult situation, even by wartime standards.” They looked at each other before looking back at him, unsure what to say. He met their eyes and sighed again before continuing, “They have experienced a bewildering loss of context, their known world broke apart beneath their feet.” He went back to staring off into the distance.

"And we can't help with that?" Adora asked.

Hordak's voice was unusually quiet and he didn't look back at them when he answered. "The ordinary was mutilated until it offered no safety or comfort, even within face-to-face interactions.” He huffed a bitter near-laugh. “Refugees have been

forced to play out in real time the crumbling of the Etherian way of life as the people knew it. They literally watched 'home' die." Catra felt goosebumps rise on her arms, but she raised an eyebrow at Adora, who shrugged back. Hordak behaved as if he'd forgotten they were there and was talking to himself, narrowing his eyes at the wall. "The comforts and safety of family and private space… the refuge of the inner life… the war killed that for them."

"Hordak?" Adora asked gently. He started and looked around, blinking. "Have you cut back on those interviews like Glimmer told you to?"

He scowled at her. "I certainly have. By a wide margin, in fact." He straightened his cloak with a haughty sniff. "My attentions are much more widely spread."

Catra squinted at him. "That doesn't really sound like you're caring for your emotional health though, which were her *actual* words."

"Don't you two have something better to be doing than questioning me about self care?" he complained, frowning even harder. "I, for one, have duties to attend to." He turned with a swish of his cloak and walked away as they exchanged amused looks. "Oh, and Catra," Hordak called from near the entryway. She turned around and waited. "I know you don't want to hear this from me, but Mermista is going to want your impressions of the situation in a report that her Archivist can file."

Catra heaved a gigantic groan as he left and Adora gave her a sympathetic face. "This is what I get for doing work, Adora," she whined.

"You're doing such good things though," she appealed as they started walking again.

"I don't want to write a report," she continued in her laziest groan as she pulled out her communicator and started tapping out a

message to Entrapta.

“I’ll help you, we can do it together.”

She gave one more dragging whine before sighing and moving on, lighter now that she’d bitched about it. By the time they’d reached her bedroom, Entrapta had replied to her message. “Alright, we’re set. We’ll meet her in the lab when she gets back tonight.”

Adora cracked her neck and quirked a brow. “Which means we have a few free hours.”

Catra looked away and frowned. “I need to go spend some time in that drainage town.”

“Why?" she asked, surprised. "And in a few hours? What about Entrapta, I thought she was our priority tonight.”

Catra sighed and looked around. “You’re right. Should we get more information from Hordak about those ‘other’ predators Sivtria was bullshitting about?”

“Glimmer said he didn’t know much, but he wants to help us get a better survey of the political landscape around us.”

Catra groaned again. “That sounds like the most boring thing ever. I don’t know if I can do that right now.”

Adora looked at her sideways, quirking a corner of her mouth. “So… that still leaves us with two or three hours. What do you want to do?”

Catra’s brain finally switched gears and she caught her drift. “Oohhh,” she said. She must *really* be distracted, usually Adora was the oblivious one. Catra crossed her arms and arranged a thoughtful expression, pretending to consider their options. “Mmmm…. fighting and/or fucking?”

Adora grinned, stepped forward and kissed her. “That’s my girl.”

* * * * *

Adora was getting faster, but Catra could still avoid her indefinitely in hand-to-hand sparring fairly easily. She ducked, weaved, stepped and jumped out of the way of every blow Adora tried to land. This time, however, she wasn't doing it to annoy. Catra provided high-speed and intelligent defense while explaining her experience with Chelle and her family in the refugee camp, and Adora worked on her speed and agility in offense while listening to her and asking questions. Punching out their feelings had become their favorite medium for tough conversations, and Catra was considering making a suggestion to Bow and Glimmer.

Catra ducked under a swing and stepped away from a jab, chatting smoothly. "...but I don't want to bring up Octavia to the family until I know where she is, you know?" she asked, thinking of the way the mother had reacted at the mere mention of her lost daughter. "I mean, I know she's alive because I'm *almost positive* I saw her myself."

"What? When?" Adora asked, feinting a jab and aiming a kick.

"From that tavern where Hordak and I had the bar fight."

"You mean the tavern where you and Hordak were attacked by a mob?" Adora said, swinging fast and stepping toward her in time.

"Same thing," Catra said, jumping up and away from a sweeping leg. "And I didn't exactly *see* see her. It was through a window that wasn't exactly clear." Adora cocked her head, trying to distract from her blows with her footwork. "I'm like, 95% positive it was her," Catra insisted, ducking under another heavy swing. "It's a lead, anyway, until we take back the Fright Zone."

Adora stopped advancing and paused for breath, wiping her sweaty forehead on the back of her forearm and breathing hard,

cheeks pink, taught muscles and luminescent skin glistening with sweat. Catra fought the urge to roll her eyes. Adora was way too pretty for somebody in the middle of a workout. “Sounds like a solid plan,” she huffed, putting her hands on her hips and catching her breath. After a few more seconds, she started rolling her neck and shoulders. “Other than that, how are you doing?”

“What do you mean how am I doing? I’m the same as ever," she said, furrowing her brow and cracking her knuckles. "Hordak got stabbed at the tavern, not me.” Adora gave her an unamused look and a raised eyebrow, and Melog meowed loudly from the corner. Catra rolled her eyes. “Fine,” she said, taking a moment to think.

“C’mon, I’ll hold the bag for you,” Adora said, motioning her to the punching bag and stepping partially behind it.

Catra sighed, rolled her shoulders, retracted her claws and began punching lightly, finding her flow. “So, taking responsibility for my actions is one thing,” she paused to look back at Melog and raise her voice, “but Melog and Perfuma…” she said pointedly before lowering her voice and turning back to the punching bag, “have this whole thing about taking responsibility for your emotions, right?”

“Right,” Adora said patiently, leaning into the bag.

“And I do get why that’s probably, like, a good thing and whatever,” she said, rolling her eyes again before she started putting more force into her blows. “But it’s really fucking with me.” She heaved a deep breath and switched her weight lightly between her two feet, feeling out her balance and sorting through her thoughts. “First of all,” she said, starting to punch again, “the way we grew up, intense emotions were considered weaknesses, right? And to be fair, weakness is *fucking embarrassing*,” she whined, throwing her shoulder into a punch with a satisfying thump.

“Not to mention your emotions were weaponized against you by Shadow Weaver your whole life,” Adora said from behind the bag.

“Anything you wanted or feared or anything… back then it was leverage.”

“*Exactly*,” Catra said, relieved that Adora was keeping up easily. “Like…” she made a frustrated noise, punching harder. “Now I have to learn how to be all *open and receptive* ,” she said, saying the words as if they were as ridiculous and unreasonable as they felt. “And I’m fucking *terrible* at being open and receptive.” She pulled back, breathing hard and sweating. “It’s not just humiliating,” she landed three hard blows and felt Adora lean harder against the bag, “it’s… it’s terrifying.” She slammed her fist into the bag one last time and held it there, panting. Then she dropped her arm and leaned her forehead against the firm canvas. After she caught her breath again, she turned her head and spoke to the side to where Adora’s face had appeared around the punching bag. “What about you? How are you doing?” Adora groaned loudly in reply and leaned her head back stepping away.

Catra let Adora think about it as they settled into stretching, sitting on the ground across from each other once their breathing and heartrates slowed. She lay her torso flat along the ground between her outstretched legs, reaching out beyond them along the floor toward Adora, who uttered a strained grunt, desperately trying to reach her toes. Catra propped her chin on her hands and watched Adora hold the hunched pose for a few seconds, grimacing, before releasing her breath and straightening back up. Her expression was somber, almost dejected as she stared at the ground in front of her. "Seeing all the people and clones today… I guess it kind of gave me a lot to think about.”

Adora furrowed her brow and Catra let her think some more as she spread her legs apart and started bending toward each to in turn. Catra braced her hands on the floor and scooted her torso back along the floor until her legs lay in a straight line from side to side. “What do you mean?” she asked gently.

“The healing… like, the healing power of all that compassion…” she straightened up and shook her head, squinting at the ground. She was still shaking her head when she pulled her feet in so that

the bottoms pressed together in front of her. "I think it's the most amazing thing I've ever seen."

"Which is saying something," Catra added as Adora pulled her feet as far in as she could, hunching over them.

As Adora grimaced some more while pushing down on her knees with her elbows, Catra pulled her ankles back and together so that she was laying straight, propped up with her hands and forearms pressed to the ground. She kicked up with one leg and flipped her body up over her head, curling forward until she could cross her ankles and rest her toes on the ground. She held the pose, peering at Adora from between her own calves as the blonde chewed her lower lip. "If She-Ra and Etheria inspired other worlds out there before… maybe we can still use that."

Catra sighed and flipped back until she was sprawled out on the ground with her head resting on her crossed arms. "I don't know if she was inspiring, per se, but you certainly seem to have made an impression on Sivtria this morning." She snorted and smirked, but Adora kept staring at the floor like it had told her something devastating. "What are you frowning so hard about?"

"I'm thinking about what Dale said."

"Oh."

"Yeah."

"Why are you thinking about the… what did Glimmer say? Decorative corpses?" she asked.

Adora sighed, long and low. "Because that's the kind of thing people do when they get angry enough."

Catra heaved a sigh and rearranged herself so that she was sitting cross-legged across from Adora and waited until she looked up at her. "Adora, no. You are not that person. You would never-"

“Stop.” Adora interrupted in a quiet voice. “Stop.” Suddenly, her face looked too tired and sad to argue with. “You don’t know what I would or wouldn’t do… because… I don’t even know anymore.” She raised her eyes to Catra’s again and they were overbright. “What I felt today… what I felt when Sivtria just smiled at Bow instead of telling him how many she... I don’t really know what I’d do if I was that angry again.”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “Adora, be as dramatic as you want, but I can tell you now you wouldn’t go into ‘decoration’ mode.” Adora’s mouth quirked. “You’re scary when you’re angry, but you’re not batshit.” She moved forward until she was sitting next to her, still facing the opposite direction with her torso turned to Adora’s. “Adora. No matter what that virus makes you feel, it does not keep you from being Adora. Nothing ever could. Even when you’re She-Ra, you’re still Adora.”

Adora leaned her forehead against Catra’s. “Thanks.”

“Whatever," Catra said, a purr starting in her throat. "You know I’m a sucker for a pretty face." Adora placed a hand at the base of her skull and pulled her into a tender kiss. Her lips soft and warm against Catra’s.

The intensity of the worry she'd felt over Adora all day long fueled Catra's responding embrace. They both leaned back slightly so they could wrap their arms around each other, curling their bodies inward as well. They were both still sweaty and flushed from the work out, but they were far too comfortable with each other's bodies to care. She pressed herself against Adora happily, eagerly, digging her fingers through the damp roots of her silky hair beneath her ponytail and relishing the strong arm wrapped tight around her waist. Adora tipped her head back slightly and began moving her mouth over hers gently, sweetly, and Catra’s tail wrapped around her hip and thigh, flicking at the end.

"You did mention fighting and/or fucking. How do you feel about the and/or part now?" Adora asked, moving the hand from Catra's

hair down her neck slowly, trailing her fingers along her collarbone lightly.

"I'm feeling the 'and' option pretty hard," Catra responded, her heart leaping in her chest as Adora's fingertips trailed down the center of a breast to pause on her nipple, raised and firm through the thin fabric.

"Your room is kind of far away," Adora said, and Catra could feel her smile in her sweet lips.

"We know the closets better than the cleaning staff," Catra reminded her, repositioning an arm to wrap around Adora's lower back before dropping her hand down to rest on her ass.

“How is its that every time I find you two it looks like you’re about to fuck?” came Glimmer's voice from behind Catra.

Catra and Adora pulled apart and looked around. Glimmer stood straight-faced with her hands on her hips as Bow bounced on the balls of his feet and stared at the ceiling. Adora started giggling and Catra said, “Seems to me like that's a *you*, problem.”



Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Uh huh," she said, raising a brow at them. Anyway, Bow just made a really good point and we have things to write down."

Catra and Adfora exchanged confused looks, but Glimmer didn't take time to explain before she grabbed them and teleported away.

* * * * *

Hordak arrived at the docks once it was dark, and to his mild surprise, Mermista was already present when he got there. She wasn't alone, either. A few children stood around her and she was talking to them in a much friendlier manner than she usually displayed.

"Thank you so, so much for these. I can tell you worked really hard on them." Hordak retreated enough to hide himself around a warehouse's corner, peeking to watch the interaction unfolding by the shore. "I can't wait to put them up at home," Mermista continued. "Buuuut… here's the thing. I was already running a little low on room for dolls, and I was carrying these ones around because I wanted to give them away to free up space. I don't suppose you'd be interested in a trade?"

The children responded with enthusiastic assent and there was a bit of conversation and shuffling about between them. "Thank you," they each said in turn

"Alright. Now go home, it's too late for you kids to be outside anyway." The children immediately scurried away and Hordak made his approach, smirking.

She groaned and rolled her eyes. “And I suppose you saw that,” she drawled, putting a hand on her hip and heaving a sigh.

“I did, but I’m not sure what it was that I saw.”

She rolled her eyes again and started walking toward the refugee camp. “It’s, like, this weird old Salineas tradition. Honestly, it’s kind of annoying, but like, whatever.” She took a deep breath before dragging on. “It’s customary for little kids in Salineas to have, like, dolls of the reigning Princess, i.e. me. It’s also customary that the child give the doll as a gift to the Princess if they ever meet her in public.” She tsked and made a frustrated noise. “But like, what even is that? I don’t want to take kids’ dolls, that's ass.” She sighed again. “But, they get so excited that I can’t just tell them no, either.” Hordak was fighting a smile as he listened and she continued to avoid his gaze, frowning and walking steadily, backpack slung over her shoulder. “So… I just have dolls made by the dozen so I can trade with the kids when it happens. I take the ones they made, they get the fancy ones, I’m not running around my kingdom literally taking toys from children… everybody’s happy. Except my archivist. Because I make them organize and store the dolls.” She finally looked over and he raised his brow. “The kids *make* the dolls, Hordak. I’m not just gonna, like, throw them away.”

“I am impressed by your commitment to your kingdom’s welfare.”

She shrugged and frowned. “I mean, yeah. I’m their princess.”

"I simply did not imagine that a princess's sense of duty would entail such base topics as sewage systems and refugee camps."

He realized the second the sentence left his mouth that he'd been rude and regretted it instantly. Mermista, however, addressed the misstep before he could. “You know what? Hang on. Let’s get something straight.” She stopped in her tracks just before they reached the edge of the camp, turning to face him fully. “My people, are my life, okay? They are always my priority, and that doesn’t fucking change, no matter what I’m up against, got it?”

"Understood," he said, but Mermista wasn't done making her point.

"You want to know the truth? The truth that never reached the Fright Zone, that not even my friends and family know? The truth is, my dad didn't retire and leave me Salineas. I *took* Salineas." This time, his brow shot up in genuine shock as she continued. "I worked the City Council and the City Guard for years, and as a teenager I took control and sent my father away forever. Right now he's living quite comfortably, far away from me and just as useless as he's been his entire life." She fixed him with a blazing look, eyes narrowed and jaw set. "My people needed him, and he *failed* them. *I* had to step up and be what they needed, and that's what I fucking did." She took a small step closer and lowered her voice and shoulders, calming somewhat. "And you know what? It was easy. Do not underestimate what I will do for my people. You see something to improve, you fucking come to me and it will get done. Do you understand?"

"I do," he said, bowing slightly. "You continue to impress, Princess Mermista."

She leaned back, pulling a face. "Uh... okay. Didn't think you'd be so on board, but… cool." She crossed her arms, looking around at the outskirts of the camp before catching his expression. "Why are you smiling?"

He hadn't realized he was. "My circumstances were entirely different, but I remember living beneath an image much larger than myself. I imagine the weight of your persona is a heavy thing to bear."

Her expression softened and she went back to surveying their surroundings. "Yeah, I guess."

They were soon well within the camp. Very few people were out about, and as soon as they saw Hordak they either reacted with rage or terror. When they saw Mermista, however, they

immediately demurred and disappeared into their respective hovels.

As they walked and surveyed the conditions around them, neither were surprised to see everything Catra had mentioned. When they reached the one fresh water pump, surrounded by soupy mud from too much foot traffic, Mermista heaved a deep sigh. “This is my bad,” she said, shaking her head.

“How so?” He asked, thinking of how many new points of supply they should put in and where, though it wouldn't be a permanent solution.

“Refugees don’t have the resources to make themselves heard over property owners and business owners, and I know it. I should have kept a much better eye on the people I wasn’t hearing from.” She closed her eyes and shook her head again before taking a deep breath and setting her jaw. When she opened her eyes again they were calm, clear, and determined. “Come on. Let’s get to planning this shit out and putting shovels in the ground.”

On their way back from camp, both stayed silent, focusing on their own thoughts and concerns before Mermista spoke to him again. "So that thing Sivtria said about others... you really aren't sure exactly what she was talking about, or you don't want us to panic?"

Hordak looked over and considered her. "I told you what I know of Prime's former allies. I would not protect your innocence or delicate sensibilities for any reason, much less when the safety of Etheria is at stake.

Again, she surprised him when she smiled and nodded at him approvingly. "That's exactly what I was hoping you'd say."

When they were walking back past the warehouses, three figures stepped from an alley between buildings. They stopped in the road and watched Hordak and Mermista as they approached in

the darkness. The unusual behavior put his hackles up, and he was glad he was out with the Princess tonight. When they drew near enough to make out each other's faces, Hordak noticed that the three had swords though they looked very young. One looked like they might still have pimples.

"I'd recognize that silhouette anywhere," one of them said, and by the malice in his tone Hordak could already tell he was looking for conflict. "Rumors are true, then. You really are out here, walking around, showing your face among the people you-"

"Mate, do you not recognize the Princess? That's fucking Mermista," one of the others broke in.

"Oh…" the other said, uncrossing his arms and changing his attitude immediately. "C'mon let's go." They hurried to walk back the way they'd come.

Hordak let out the breath he'd been holding and looked over at Mermista, who was scowling at where the three had disappeared. "There is no way I was that bad when I was a teenager. No way."

He huffed a near-laugh and wore a small smile as they walked on. "Those three were juveniles," he reasoned. "Apparently, young Etherians often become far too distracted by their own overwhelming emotions to consider those of other Etherians. Give them time. Barring significant interference, their frontal cortexes should develop further."

Mermista actually let out a laugh. "You know what, Horde Scum?" she asked, looking over at him again. "I think I'm actually starting to like you guys."

"Strange," he muttered.

"Actually, speaking of, there's something else I wanted to talk to you about. Before I forget." He gave her a quizzical frown and she sighed heavily. "So, when Entrapta and I were mad and yelled at each other… you know, the day she was going a little nuts-"

He gave her a sharp, stern look and cut her off. “She was not ‘going nuts’ she was exhausted. Her aggression was a symptom of severe fatigue,” he corrected.

Mermista put her hands up immediately. “You’re right, you are absolutely right,” she said. “My bad. Anyway, she gave me a lot to think about. Like… you know, who has a right to be mad about what. And… I meant it when I said I’ll never forgive you for what you did in the war. And my people get to process all that anger and grief you caused on their own terms and in their own time. But thinking about the future...” She looked at his face and waited for him to meet her eyes. “I can do a lot more for my people through forgiveness than by memorializing their rage. I guess I want you to think about the kind of future *you* want to see, and how you can help make it happen.” He frowned at her in confusion. “Not just technical skills in rebuilding, but also what you can mean to others, and the unique advantages you have in reaching certain people.” She was frowning up at him with no hint of attitude or boredom, only serious focus.

“I have no clue what you mean.”

She let out a kind of combination between a groan and a sigh and tried again. “Like, I know you mean a lot to the clones,” she said, and he didn’t have an argument on that point. “But also, like…. your whole thing and what it says about peoples’ capacity to change and grow. You and other ex-Horde.”

Hordak stayed quiet for several seconds before answering, “Thank you, your Highness.”

She rubbed her hands over her face before holding her hair away and blinking for a few moments to refocus. “Right. Next is Entrapta.” Hordak looked at her curiously as she retrieved a datapad from her bag and flicked the screen on. “Oh. Oops.” She looked up at him as she stowed the pad again. “C’mon, we’re late.”

They started back up the way to the palace at a much faster walk. Hordak was dying to ask what was going on that involved Entrapta, but he figured he'd see soon enough. However, he had to slow before long, his upper heart protesting at the brisk pace uphill. Mermista slowed to match without mention.

"So," she said, staring at the pink crystal on his chest that was glowing bright with added stress, "you wear her crystal, but what does... she… hang on."

"What?" he asked, confused by her incredulous expression.

"I'm just now realizing something… you were rampaging around, publicly wearing your ex's love token while hoping to meet her in battle where she would see it?" He blushed furiously and felt his ears swivel back. She grinned and rolled her eyes. "You are something else." He pressed his lips together and kept his eyes ahead as they walked. "Anyway, she gave you the crystal, what did you give her?"

"I… I don't follow."

"Oh," she said slowly, nodded in comprehension. "So, that's like, a whole *thing* here on Etheria- trading love tokens."

"Love tokens."

"Mmm hmm. Think Netossa's and Spinnerella's necklaces."

His ears lowered further as he recalled the clashing accessories. Then he looked down at the crystal on his chest, back up at the road, then at the crystal again. "Oh dear," he said faintly.

Mermista chuckled. "Don't sweat it, I seriously doubt she cares." He groaned. "Worried?" she asked, raising an amused brow.

"I'm still waiting for rival suitors to remember the war is over," he confided.

She smiled widely again as they neared the palace. “I don’t think anybody’s going to try and romance your girlfriend, bud. I feel like you’re fine on that one.”

Hordak expected the meeting to be in their private room, so he was surprised when the lab doors opened to reveal a large group of people. Catra, Adora, Swift Wind, Melog, Scorpia, Perfuma, Bow, Glimmer, Sea Hawk, Frosta, Double Trouble, Wrong Hordak, Imp and Entrapta were all present. However, in the time it took Mermista to say, “Oh shit. Double Trouble, where have you been?” Hordak realized that nearly every single person there was crying.

“You seem busy,” he breathed before turning and fleeing.

“Oh no you don’t,” he heard Glimmer say as the doors shut behind him, but he wasn’t about to turn back. She didn't make it through the doors in time, but he’d only gotten a few yards before he heard her appear in the hall behind him.

“Wha… urgh,” she started running after him, “you’re her friend too,” her words flowed into a grunt as she made her leap. “Gotcha!” she said as she bowled into him, knocking him off his feet from behind.

They teleported directly into the center of the loose ring of people in the lab, landing in a heap on the floor. “Hordak!” Entrapta shouted happily.

“How did you get so far, you weren’t even running,” Glimmer griped as she clambered back to her feet. “Oh, sorry Hordak,” she said as Entrapta helped him up much more slowly.

“I am perfectly fine,” he said, not looking back at her. Instead, he was frowning down at Entrapta. He'd assumed otherwise with his first brief glimpse of the room, but he could now see that Entrapta had definitely cried recently as well. “Never mind, I am confused

and concerned," he said, looking between Entrapta and Wrong Hordak, waiting for someone to explain what was happening.

Princess Mermista spoke up, using the patient tone he'd heard her use several times already that night. "We're here to apologize to Entrapta and have a friendly heart to heart."

"Don't worry. Most of what we had to say is in letters so she can handle it on her own time," Catra said, jabbing her clawed thumb at the pile of folded papers on the table behind her.

Hordak sat down on the crate in a space that Entrapta and Wrong Hordak created between them as Glimmer spoke. "But… we also wanted to say it in person," she said. "And we were just doing that! So you and Mermista are here just in time."

"What made her cry?" he muttered to his brother from the corner of his mouth.

"They were thanking me for my work," Entrapta said, wearing a sweet, earnest smile. "And they apologized for all the times they made me feel bad without realizing it, and for not noticing."

"And for not valuing her enough," Catra said.

"Not respecting her enough," Mermista added.

"For mistreating her and disparaging the things that make her the Entrapta we love," Perfuma said tearfully.

"I am so sorry you had to have a breakdown before I realized how hard you push yourself and how much you give," Bow joined. "I'm *so* sorry."

Entrapta sniffed and fidgeted in her seat. "Well, hopefully you won't have to deal with this again. I've learned a lot and I'm sure I can avoid-"

Adora interrupted her. "Entrapta," she laughed with an incredulous smile, "it's okay to get overwhelmed. It's okay to struggle. We'd

rather be there for you while you're dealing with it than have you hurt yourself trying to avoid it." Entrapta's eyes filled with tears again she nodded meekly before a piece of hair flipped down her mask. Hordak clenched his hands in his lap, wishing he knew what to do.

"Not broken, just built different, remember?" Adora murmured gently.

Entrapta twisted her fingers over each other with her masked face tilted downward. "I can't explain how much this means to me... you wouldn't understand," she said quietly, head still bowed.

"Probably not," Adora admitted, "but I'm going to keep trying. And you can tell me about it anytime you want, okay?"

Entrapta gulped and Catra spoke up. "Same goes for me, Traps. Any way I can make the tough times easier, you know?"

Everyone muttered their agreement and somber quiet followed, other than the rustling of clothes as people dabbed at eyes. Then Scorpia blew her nose loudly and some of the intensity broke. "We've been talking a lot," Frosta said, "but Entrapta hasn't. I want to know if she's got anything to say, of if there's other stuff we can be better about."

"Yes," Sea Hawk said. "Please, speak your heart and mind, friend."

Entrapta didn't respond for a few moments, still twisting her fingers. But then she stilled, clenched her fists slightly before standing, and raised her mask. "Actually, I do have a few things I wanted to say. Especially after everything... everything you guys just said… um…" She paused again and a piece of hair strayed back to her mask, but she batted it away. "Ugh, I'm bad at talking about things that aren't science."

"No you're not," Bow said with a kind smile. "We're listening."

She took a deep breath and tucked her chin. "Okay. Ooookay." Hordak felt a piece of her hair slither around his hand and he

grasped it lightly. “So... I wanted to say that I’m really proud of you.” Several people looked taken aback and Hordak himself cocked his head, interested.

“For apologizing?” Catra asked. “I feel like apologizing has kind of been a theme, for like, a couple months now.”

Entrapta shook her head. “No, although those were some of the nicest things anyone’s ever said to me.” Catra flushed lightly and rubbed the back of her neck. “I wanted to say that I’m really proud of everything we’re doing together. So much is being achieved all over Etheria, and it’s so exciting!” The ends of her hair curled momentarily and her voice picked up slightly. “Even when I just wanted to get us out of Despondos, I never even imagined Etheria would flourish like this. You’ve all done such amazing things, and you’ve grown so much over the past few years.” Perfuma placed a hand over her heart, and Hordak noticed that she was still wearing the scrap Imp had traded her around her wrist.

“Buuuut,” Entrapta continued, glancing over at Hordak. “Prime took a lot out of us, and I know we’ve all been really tired, too. And… sad.” Faces fell around the room. Sea Hawk and Bow exchanged glances, as did Catra and Adora. “We won, but it’s hard not to be sad with… everything.” The hair around Hordak’s hand tightened slightly. “I just wanted to say that it’s okay. You’re all really strong, and we’ve already done so many impossible things…” she faltered and gulped again, but all eyes were still trained on her. “I don’t want to see you lose your spark, you know? I miss the laughing.” Her voice had dropped so low that several of the group leaned toward her to hear. “A lot, actually. I… I can’t stop thinking about what Bow said to us, when he took over Prime’s feed to the spires, remember? About how we have each other, and we have love.” She took a deep breath. “I told Prime he would never win, because he can’t stop love. So… even though we’re tired, and sad, I know we can win. It’s what we do." She smiled slightly. "So just... remember to keep laughing, okay?” As she finished her speech and her time at the apex of the room’s

attention, she slammed down her mask and pressed into Hordak's side.

Silence stretched as the assembly sat and thought. Adora had leaned head on Catra's shoulder and Catra had wrapped an arm around her waist. Bow had buried his head in his hands and Glimmer was rubbing her back, tears in her eyes. Scorpia and Perfuma were crying too, of course, they seemed to cry more than any of Entrapta's other friends save Bow.

Swift Wind and Wrong Hordak exchanged meaningful looks and nobody else seemed to know what to say. Finally, it was Catra who broke the tension. "I don't believe I'm about to make suggestions for morale," she said, shaking her head at herself, "but Entrapta's right, as usual." Entrapta looked over at her from behind her mask. "Love won, just like Entrapta said. When we…" she paused, looking over at Adora, "when Adora and I were… when I was asking her to stay… for the last time…" Adora's eyes filled with tears and she looked away sharply, wrapping her arms around herself. Bow, who's entire face was wet and blotchy, gave her a curious look that Catra ignored as she gulped and blinked away tears of her own. "I chose love instead of rage, and it reached her. At the end there, when we were nearly beat, Adora chose love instead of rest." She cleared her throat and sniffed, wiping at her eyes impatiently. Entrapta raised her mask slowly and Hordak felt another piece of hair wrap around his arm. "Again and again and again, the only reason we made it through the day is because we chose love." She sniffed again. "I'm not about to start questioning the pattern now." She looked away and scowled before pulling Adora into a hug and hiding her face behind her ponytail.

Frosta spoke next, was smiling. "I miss the laughter, too," she said. "But I don't know how to make you guys feel better."

"Make more time for each other? Spend it loving harder?" Catra suggested, throwing a sideways glance at Adora, who shrugged and smiled.

“You guys are the best,” Bow whimpered, bottom lip trembling.

Glimmer laughed as she pulled him into a tight embrace. Then he stood, pulled Glimmer up with him, and motioned Entrapta over. Adora pulled Catra up and over to join them, and before Hordak knew what was happening, everyone in the room had stood, including Entrapta.

“No no no no no…” he muttered, but Wrong Hordak and Swift Wind already had him blocked in. Entrapta raised herself up on her hair so that she wasn’t crushed between two clones and a horse and wrapped a lavender lock around his waist. Above nearly all the other’s heads, Hordak focused on her arm around his neck as he patted Wrong Hordak’s and Swift Wind’s backs awkwardly.

They all held the pose for far too long, but Hordak was eventually released as the group moved apart. “Okay, but like, actually where have you been?” Mermista said to Double Trouble as they broke away.

They shrugged. “I wanted money so I left to take some work, but I’ve been back for a few days now. Didn’t want to miss *this*.” Hordak stepped back from the group and eavesdropped as Perfuma wrapped Entrapta into a lengthy hug.

“You now you’re still considered a war criminal under supervision like Catra and Hordak, right?” she asked, raising an eyebrow but smirking. Elsewhere, Frosta started making an argument for more frequent shared activities.

“Ugh, it’s been months,” Double Trouble complained, rolling their eyes. “Plus when I realized you guys were going to win I traded sides, remember? And I helped? Like Scorpia and Entrapta who aren’t generally considered war criminals?”

“I don’t know if you’re effectively pleading your case,” Glimmer broke in, smiling and hugging Bow to her side with his arm slung over her shoulders.

“You guys didn’t even know I was gone,” Double Trouble chastised. “And besides, you know you can’t keep me anywhere I don’t want to be unless you put me in one of those magic forcefield things.”

As Scorpia finally released Entrapta, Frosta pulled her and Glimmer aside to chat about whatever a “sleepover” was and Sea Hawk approached Bow, saying something about boys at night. “So,” Catra said, approaching Double Trouble while Mermista pulled out her datapad and started flicking through messages. “Was the work any good?”

Double Trouble sighed and shifted poses. “The pay wasn’t anything to write home about, but the audience was actually somewhat refreshing. Elberon was looking for entertainment for their little festival- you know them,” they put a hand on their hip and smiled silkily, “any excuse to throw a party.”

“Ooohh I love Elberon’s parties!” Adora said, joining in from Catra’s side. “You said they threw a whole festival?” Entrapta winked at him as she joined in conversation with Glimmer and Sea Hawk.

Double Trouble smiled and offered an affected little chuckle, clasping their hands near their face. “It was genuinely adorable. They were celebrating the integration of a group of clones into their community. So they hired me on as J. D. Butterbee,” they said, transforming into lanky yellow Elberonian in a tuxedo and top hat, sweeping the hat off and bowing low in a grand gesture. They popped back up and transformed back into themselves before continuing, “And clones are such a delightfull crowd to entertain,” they said, glancing over at Hordak and Wrong Hordak fondly. He frowned back. “Even the worst cliches are brand new to them, and they’re incredibly responsive audience members.” They sighed and struck a new pose, ready to change the subject. “Speaking of Elberon, has anybody seen Flutterina since the end of the war?”

“She’s a real person?” Adora asked. “I thought you made her up.”

“Awe, leaving already?” Bow called at Mermista, who was walking with Sea Hawk toward the lab doors.

“Princess stuff,” she drawled, shrugging. “I have some planners to wake up and an archivist to annoy.”

“Actually,” Glimmer heaved a huge sigh. “I have a few things to do before bed, too. I’m going to be in touch though,” she said, waving a communicator in one hand and pointing around at the group threateningly with the other. She left with Bow and the rest of the room’s occupants began making their goodbyes.

Catra walked over to Hordak with her arms crossed. “That wasn’t so bad now, was it?” she teased.

“Yes. It was,” he replied in a flat tone. He took a deep breath. “But I was very gratified to see it. I think… I think Entrapta has good friends,” he said, nodding slightly to himself.

Catra offered a half smile and looked back at the others. “I never would have believed this kind of shit could exist in real life, but they keep fucking proving me wrong.”

Now Hordak smiled, observing Entrapta’s affectionate conversation with Scorpia, Perfuma and Adora. “It still doesn’t feel very… real, in some ways,” he muttered, trying to figure out what he meant.

“I know,” Catra said. “Like we’re in a different reality or something.

Hordak grunted and nodded, then raised a brow as Double Trouble bowed deeply to Entrapta and raised a piece of hair to brush their lips across. “We have been wrong about quite a bit in the past,” he reasoned, watching Double Trouble make their slinky exit. They glanced back and made eye contact with him just before the lab doors slid shut behind them, flashing a wicked smirk.

“Maybe this really is *their* world,” she said in a low voice, frowning over her crossed arms as she watched the rest of the group hug each other goodnight.

Chapter End Notes

Obviously, I used a lot of creative license having fun with Mermista’s character in this story. Truth be told, I didn’t pay a whole lot of attention to her at first, but when I started thinking about details around her for these stories (and I know I’m just picking at and running with a lot of details that probably weren’t even intentional,) it got more and more fun to think about. Her dad retired, but where the fuck is he while his daughter is fighting for their lives? Also, when we first meet her, she’s stayed behind after the whole damn city was deserted, totally alone save one loyal servant, there to defend the Sea Gate and therefore all the ocean provinces from the Horde. Alone. That’s pretty badass. And, even though she was annoyed with having to do it, the bitch is utilitarian enough to fuck with sewers. Which is also badass. Anyway I hope it’s also fun to read.

If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you’ve got. It is very much appreciated.

"...what did you have in mind?"

Chapter Summary

Iiiiiiiiit's a smut chapter. Porn through the first half, some Catra plot in the second, plus two new pieces of fanart anonymously gifted for the fic!
Cheers :)

Chapter Notes

FYI, this series is a post-canon story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization angle. So uh, expect all the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you're dealing with tough stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anybody for anything.
Centered around Catra and Hordak. Aged up significantly for super adult themes, but it's still set in the canon universe so truth spells are a thing and the only sociopath involved was Prime. If you're not into easy redemptions or quick-fixes for Catra and Hordak, I totally get it, but I spent a lot of time and effort on hashing shit out in the five stories leading up to this one, and you are welcome to inspect those to your heart's content.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Once Imp rode out of the lab on Emily, Hordak and Entrapta were the only ones left in the giant underground space. He looked down to where she stood at his side, pigtail wrapped up his arm, wearing an odd expression. "How are you?" he ask, turning toward her.

She wrinkled her nose and thought for a moment. "I feel overwhelmed and a little spent, but… I also feel good. In a weird way. Not like, excited or touched or even that happy, but… hmm." Her hair slid from his arm and she started clearing up the tools

she'd been using all day while he restacked crates the princesses had used as seating. "I feel… not relieved… I feel strong. Really strong… it's great," she finished, knocking over an arc rod and catching it with her hair.

"You feel strong?" he asked, cocking his head.

"Yeah," she responded, her voice picking up some of its usual energy. "Not like, lifting heavy weights strong, which, my hair isn't quite what it used to be," she sighed and his stomach clenched. "Strong on the inside. Steady."

He nodded, still unsure, but he was also distracted by thoughts of Sivtria and Tarsis, as well as the things Mermista had said to him. "I'm very pleased to hear that you're feeling well," he said as he set a toolbox on top of a crate before turning to step back to their work area. She'd appeared right behind him, however, and he nearly ran into her. He would never understand how someone so clumsy could sometimes be so quiet, even considering the hum of machinery around them.

She stood on her feet and looked up at him, her expression soft and sweet. "Slow down," she said soothingly, grabbing his hips and shifting him sideways so she could put a socket set away in the toolbox behind him. She was moving more slowly than usual, and he wondered how tired she really was. She looked back over her shoulder and smiled again, "Don't waste your energy on fussing."

"I am not fussing," he muttered, double-checking to make sure the soldering setup was off.

"I heard Catra tell Glimmer about the tiny Etherian in here," she continued, walking toward him on her feet again. "Sorry I wasn't around for that. Mushroom forgot about how much we have to sleep and called when it was still dark. The vibrating woke me up so I went to visit the pieces of that infected disk thing with him."

“No need to apologize,” he said, looking around himself to see if anything else was out for Imp to pilfer. “Did they catch you up on what happened with the delegation from Tarsis?” he continued. “We need to discern what brought Sivtria near enough to project like she did. The realism they described suggests some element of magic rather than tech, which means she’s still as adept as she was a millennia ago, and she was close enough to Etheria to use its magical energy.” He took a breath to continue, thinking of the anger that still roiled among Salineas’ refugees, but she reached out and took his hands in her gloved ones.

“That will all be there tomorrow morning,” she said, holding his hands out before herself and looking up at him. “Do you want to go to bed early? It’s been a long day.”

Normally, Hordak would have resisted. He hated going to bed while he still had ideas to hammer out or there was work to be done, but he’d needed to get off his feet for hours. He looked down at her bulky gloves and squeezed her fingers lightly before glancing at her face and nodding.

“Come on, let’s go warm up together,” she said, moving toward the door while he agonized over whether or not to tell her his heart had been acting up again.

“I’ll be right there, I need to set out more food for Imp,” he said as she opened the door with her hair. “He keeps bringing me rats and he’s gaining weight again,” he added in a distracted mutter. It wouldn't have been an issue if his wings were growing with him.

Getting Imp to switch to low-calorie snacks was proving to be a steep challenge, and Hordak spent several minutes sidetracked, trying to arrange a plate that might strike the beast as appealing. Then he was back to mulling over different housing propositions he’d heard from Mermista’s planners and developers, doing one last lap around the lab. He grabbed a report off a work table as he passed it and began reviewing the notes he’d crammed into the margins as he walked, mouthing phrases that caught his attention. His eyes were still on the report when he entered the

smaller space of their bedroom, but when the door closed behind him and he lost his light in the dim room, he looked up and around himself.

At the sight of Entrapta, he nearly dropped his papers. Her hair was out and down around her and she sat, legs crossed, atop a stack of equipment cases. Her boots and sleeves were off and she'd definitely removed her breast band, though her white bodysuit was still on. She'd unclipped her overalls and they were slung low so that glowing slivers of her hips were visible between the bottom of her top and the heavy purple fabric. She looked completely at ease, smiling slightly and toying with her work gloves in her lap while she waited. Once she had his attention, she uncrossed her legs so she could lean toward him, hands braced on the box below her. "So… I feel more like myself than I have in a really long time," he smiled back at her and she bit her bottom lip, "and I kind of wanted to celebrate a little."

He stood staring and grinning like a fool as several seconds slid by, though she did seem pleased by his foundering. "C'mon, partner," she finally said, hopping down off her boxes and motioning him over. "Trade spots with me so we can get you out of that armor."

He finally dragged himself into motion, eager gaze darting over her body as she stood with her hands on her hips, eyes sparkling, looking him up and down just as blatantly. He was starting to get used to her appreciative gaze, barely blushing beneath the scrutiny. He was a bit stiff and awkward as he situated himself on the impromptu seat under such close observation, but he felt mounting excitement deepen his breathing as she rose up on her hair and moved closer, watching him all the while.

Her eyes strayed downward and she began reaching toward him, her hand sinking lower even as his gaze remained locked on her face. He gasped as she leaned forward, hand extended to his lap, but her fingers were delicate as she took the report he'd forgotten he was carrying from him gently, transferring it to her hair and

onto a nearby table. She smirked and he started breathing again, trying not to betray frustration.

A piece of her hair wrapped around one of his arms and held it out to the side. Another lavender tendril slid up his other arm, keeping him from aiding her. Instead, he watched her face and hands, focusing on the way she trailed her fingertips over exposed skin rather than the unpleasantly jarring process of removing his armor as she worked up his arm, leaving tingling trails in her fingers' wake. They usually started with disengaging the armor on his torso, getting the most unpleasant of it over with first. Tonight, she worked from the outside in, moving to the other arm while her hair maintained hold of the first, pulling it down and back out of her way.

Once both of his arms were bare, she slackened her hair's hold on him, though it did not release him. Instead, she kept him from reaching out to touch her as she lowered herself to eye level, hovering upright between his knees. She lifted her hands to hover over him, but paused, and brushed her fingertips over the pink crystal on his collar. When she finally placed her palms against his chest, he sucked in a sharp breath at the thrill of her touch, then sighed as the warmth between her hands and his chest built.

"I've been thinking about those last few nights we had back at the Fright Zone," she said softly, moving her hands down the planes of his torso over the soft knit of his dress. He alternated between watching her fingers and watching her face, body twitching slightly as she reached the upper ports at his ribs. Even though he knew discomfort was coming, he felt heat start to build between his hips as his length rapidly thickened. "But I know things are different now," she said, and for the first time since they'd been alone, a note of uncertainty entered her tone. "I need you to promise that if anything is too much, or needs to be adjusted, or just isn't working for you… if you feel uncomfortable for any reason… promise you'll tell me." Her hair placed his hands in his laps and released his arms.

“We’ve already discussed this,” he tried to reassure her, “and it’s been some time since I had a severe nightmare... of... that nature.” Then again, it had been some time since he’d had more than a couple of hours of sleep at a go.

“Please.” She grasped his fingers tightly and gave him a dearly earnest look.

He nodded, tilting his head toward her. “I promise.”

She let go of his hands and moved forward slowly, then she pressed her lips against his gently, drawing a deep sigh from him. When she placed her small hands on either side of his face and floated up to tilt his head back slightly with her kiss, flares of tingling excitement arced between his chest and abdomen. She released his face and moved her hands back to his torso, he went to place his hands on her hips, but found that her hair had snaked back into place to hold his arms at his sides.

His breath hitched when she pulled the tubes from the upper ports on his abdomen, the usual jolt between hardware softened somewhat by her steady touch. She recaptured his mouth with hers and deepened their kiss as she lowered her hands to the second set of ports at his ribs, keeping her fingers braced against the tender skin around the metal. She nipped at his bottom lip gently just before she pulled the remaining two tubes from his abdomen, and sighed when he let slip a small grunt at the confusing mix of discomfort and pleasure.

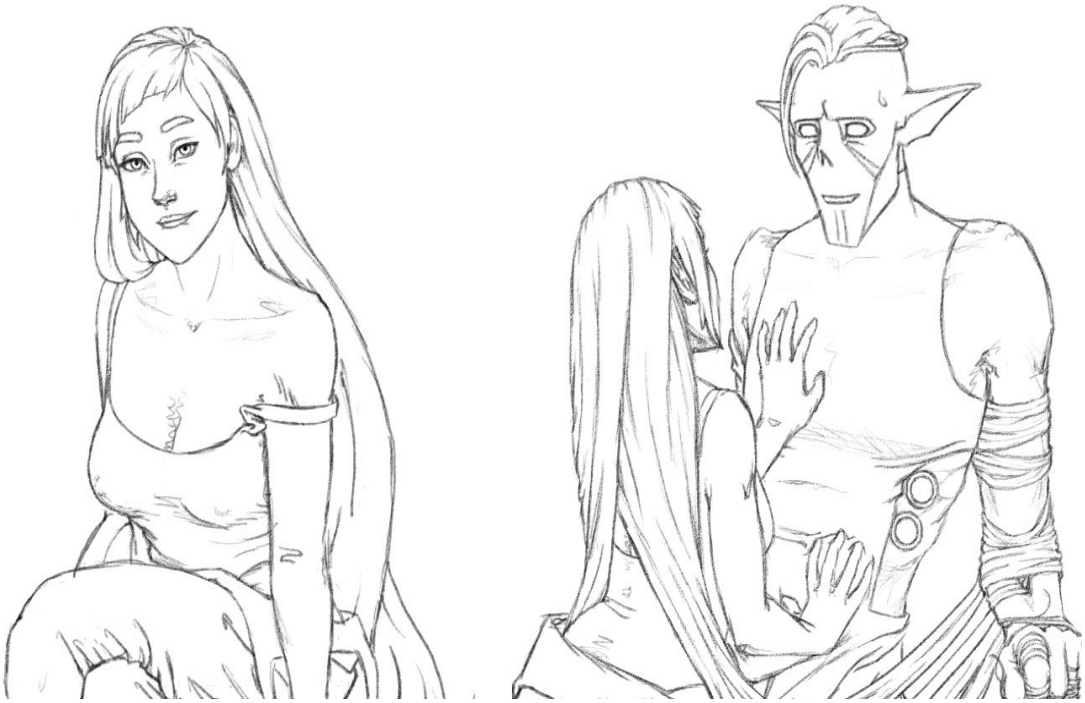
She kissed him once more before she lowered further and pressed closer, body between his spread legs and chest brushing against him. She braced one hand on the case just an inch or two from his groin, and he felt himself twitch beneath the skirt of his dress. As she ran her other hand along the bottom of his rib cage and around his side, her breasts just so happened to be pressed between her arms, and her head just so happened to be tilting away, showing off the length of her neck as well as a spectacular view of her cleavage. His ears lowered slightly in his distraction,

and her fingers dragging around toward the center of his back sent shivers up and down his spine.

He couldn't help a small gasp when her hair brought his forearms together behind him and lifted them until only his claws could reach the case beneath him. She laid her palms on his back and waist, and turned him until she could reach his dorsal port. He braced himself even as heat built into throbbing deep between his hips, but the stab of pain between his dorsal and neck port was muffled within the intensity of Entrapta's attentions.

The loss he felt when she withdrew her hands and moved back must have been plain on his face, because when she rose and met his eyes, she snorted into a compulsive giggle. She bit her lip and pulled his arms back a bit further, though she supported his weight even as she leaned him back, floating closer until her face was inches from his. "I forgot how much of a taunting vixen you can be," he muttered, slightly embarrassed at how breathless, flustered, and fucking *hard* he already was.

She hooked a small finger beneath his chin and lifted, tilting his face back and observing him lazily. "I haven't even gotten you out of your clothes yet," she smirked at him. Then she shifted positions in midair to settle into his lap, straddling him with her legs wrapped around his waist and wiggling mischievously against his still-growing erection.



Entrapta’s libido was certainly back to full strength. Her pupils were dilated and her cheeks were flushed as she stilled, scooted back to afford him some space, and wrapped her arms around his neck. She braced the fingers of one hand on the port's edges at the base of his skull, and grasped the tube with the other, then looked up at him and waited. He nodded his readiness and dipped his head forward to help her keep the angle perpendicular. Again, it was easier than he was used to and his body barely jerked beneath her when she disengaged the port.

They both sighed in relief when she lifted the armor off his shoulders and lowered it onto a nearby table. Now, however, the stiffness and pain in his joints and muscles was intensified by the lack of support. Entrapta noticed him tense and released his arms, leaning back in his lap and watching closely as he rolled his shoulders and neck gingerly. “More sore than usual?” she asked.

“Not too sore for you,” he answered automatically. He nearly told her about his heart again, but the feel of her legs over his hips kept his mouth firmly shut. His upper heart had always given him trouble, with sex and without. He’d corrected it for a time with surgery already, and it wasn’t as if the recurring problem was news to her. And besides, worst case scenario, he still had an

entirely functional, if mediocre heart below the malfunctioning one. And this was *Entrapta* and she was *touching* him and he wasn't about to let one tiresome old health problem among a plethora of others keep him away.

By the time she'd searched his face and accepted his response, he was completely single-minded once more. He was finally able to lift his hands to her flanks and squeeze indulgently, careful to keep his touch light. She insisted she didn't mind, even liked it, but he hated leaving marks on her. "Ready to move somewhere with back support?" she asked, reaching to run a hand up his thigh beneath her own. "I want to take a look at what that magician did with your stab wound today."

He'd completely forgotten he'd had a stab wound in the first place, and was eager to examine the progress himself. When she'd pulled back far enough, he stood, grabbed her out of the air, and carried her to their bed. It seemed as if he could feel his bones on top of each other as his legs bore his and Entrapta's weight the scant few yards to the bed. It was a relief when he was able to stretch his spine out straight and he let out an uninhibited groan.

"Hmm, I love that sound even out of context," Entrapta said, pulling his skirt from his thigh with her hair and feathering her fingers over the slate blue skin she revealed. "Fascinating. Hordak, this looks like it's weeks old," she said, dragging a fingertip along the dark blue scar. At this point he could feel his erratic heartbeats throbbing between his legs, though she ignored the conspicuous bulge mere inches from her hand.

"It is incredible," he agreed, raising his other knee so that the tenting over his loins didn't stand out quite so ridiculously and propping himself up on his elbows. While he readjusted the black fabric in his lap, he was very aware that one of her hands had wandered to rest on his inner thigh.

"I've got to ask them all about it. I wonder if they know how it works." Hordak smiled, watching her lose herself in thought even

as she continued to trace the short scar lightly. After a while, she lay her palm flat, covering the scar with her small hand. She smiled then, and lifted her gaze to make eye contact with him briefly. “Another story written into your beautiful body,” she said shyly. He felt himself flush red and was still and silent for a few seconds before she looked up again. “Was that good or bad? I’ve been practicing.”

“Pardon?”

“Explaining how I feel about you,” she said, staring at him with a frank smile.

His blush burned hot and distracting, but he reached up to cup the side of her head and stroke his thumb across her cheekbone. “It was a wonderful thing to say.”

She beamed, then leaned forward to kiss him. This time, her mouth was a little more demanding against his, her lips more fervid and her breathing hungrier. She coaxed him into open-mouthed kisses and his eyes closed lazily, savoring the feel of his tongue in her mouth, tasting her sweetness as her soft lips moved over his. Their tongues tangled briefly, her hand in his hair, before she pulled away to move on to his jaw and neck. He shivered and gritted his teeth beneath her ministration, still unable to touch her back.

She indulging in a lingering sigh of her own before she pulled his torso forward against hers, piled a few more pillows behind his back with her hair, then pushed him back down among them. He expected her to straddle his waist so they could keep kissing, but instead she shifted further down his body. Her hair continued to hold him down when he made to sit up, and he felt it twine further up his arms. “Hang on a minute, I’ve got a very distracting craving to satisfy,” she said, and he could hear her amusement in her tone. “We can update the log afterwards.”

He watched as she kept moving lower, until she finally settled onto her side along his body, her chest about even with his hips.

She propped herself up on her elbow and rested her head in her hand while she moved the other down to stroke the scar on his thigh once more. He'd already hiked up his dress around his hips to show her the mark on his leg as well as obscure his erection, so when she flipped the front panel of the skirt back over his bent knee, he was laid bare from the waist down. His knees snapped together and he uttered a compulsive little growl, but her smile didn't flicker as he recovered himself and evened his rapid breathing again.

Eventually, she slid her hand under the front of his dress up his stomach, reaching up so she could run her finger down the fat white scar over his hearts in the middle of his chest. Then she circled his abdominal ports lightly before she traced the scars on his stomach, left from various times he'd had to get up at his kidneys over the years and tried a couple of different angles. Lowering her hand still further, she put just enough weight into her touch to ride out the rhythmic movement from his breathing as her palm slid to a stop just above the top of his underwear. "I'll take mine off if I can take these off," she said, hooking a fingertip just below the fabric.

He nodded without hesitation and raised his hips, but waited for a moment while she grabbed the button for her sound dome. He cringed inwardly, thinking of the sight they must have made up to that point, but Entrapta recaptured his attention easily as she let down the straps of her bodysuit. Once she'd freed her arms, she peeled it down her body slowly, apparently pleased with the way his eyes followed the tantalizing motion. Once she'd wiggled it off completely, he lifted his hips again for her to pull his undergarment down his legs, her hair keeping a firm but gentle hold on him all the while.

Completely exposed from the waist down, he tried to avoid outright panting as she started trailing fingers over his hip bone where the undergarment had hidden his skin. He strained against her hold on his arms, and for once he actually made some headway before collapsing back under the impossible strength of her hair. "Are you really not letting me touch you?" He panted.

"Not yet," she teased. She brought a palm back to his thigh, stroking up and down before pulling the stocking on that leg down to his knees. Then she shifted upward, moving over to straddle his leg so that when she made contact, he felt that her sex and inner thighs around it were already slick with her arousal.

He let out another full-bodied groan of frustration and need as she rolled her hips lightly, grinding her wet heat against his thigh less than a foot from his bobbing erection. He felt a drop of precum slowly roll down the side of his shaft, and his upright cock twitched again as he watched her slowly slip her hand between her legs. He could feel her fingers move between their slicked skin and he nearly whined in envy when her eyelids fluttered and a coy smile quirked her lips. He could only see the back of her hand moving very slightly and longed to see more, feel more, *taste* more. "Entrapta," he breathed, trying to plead for more but too distracted to string the words together.

Instead of answering him, she moved her hand further between her legs and dragged her palm over herself as she withdrew it. While his breathing devolved to shallow gasps, her small fingers glistened with slick and his breathing hitched at the sight of viscous strands of fluid stretching between her spread digits. Just as another drop of precum slid down the track left by the first, she reached forward and finally wrapped her hand around his aching member.

A strangled noise escaped his clenched teeth as he threw his head back into the pillows behind him. His breathing picked back up to panting as their fluids mixed beneath her slowly pumping hand. "You don't have to… why are you…" he gasped as he felt her lean forward on his thigh and bend so she could press a kiss to the tender hollow just inside his hip.

"Because you're mine and I love you," she said in her most matter-of-face voice before she pressed another kiss slightly further inward on the plane of his lower abdomen. "And because I'm yours and I like seeing you pleased," she said, leaving another warm kiss even closer to his sex as she continued stroking it

firmly, steadily. “And because you look so good all hot and bothered like this under my hands,” she said through a smile, tilting his cock so she could press a chaste kiss to the underside.

He gasped again through clenched teeth and bit back a moan as his hips jerked beneath her. She shot him another smirk before she kissed her way up his shaft, her kisses growing more open-mouthed and wet. Her lips were wet and shining with their combined fluids as she paused for a beat, then dipped her tongue to lick the precum still gathering at the tip. He whimpered and weakly strained at the hair holding him down, and when she engulfed the head of his cock in her mouth and *sucked,* he cried out loudly, unable to muffle the sound behind his hand or into a pillow.

Her grip on him grew firmer and faster, and he felt her reach a hand to touch herself without lifting her mouth from his straining erection. The sound of the harsh breathing through her nose mingled with her wanton hums of pleasure and the obscenely wet sounds she was making around his cock with her fingers against herself, and he sank quickly in the onslaught of sensation. His longing to touch her became an urgent need, but still, she held him prone.

She pulled her mouth off of him to gasp for more air and let out a breathy moan of her own, hips twitching beneath her own hand. "Please," he begged through a pathetic whimper, rendered a complete and helpless mess within minutes of Entrapta's attention.

"Fuck," she said, closing her eyes and scrunching her face. "I'm already close too, hang on." She finally relented and moved to straddle his hips, breathing hard.

He couldn't help but cry out again when she slowly sank down on his cock, lowering herself slowly, gradually yielding to his size until he was deep within her unfathomable softness. There were always hints of strain at the corners of her tightly shut eyes when she first took him in, but when she opened them and gazed down

at him, raspberry irises gleaming in the soft pink light, she was an absolute vision of beauty and sweetest power.

She couldn't take his full length in an upright seated position, and he was wary of thoughtless thrusts causing her pain. Instead, she leaned forward he lifted his knees to angle his hips so she could press more of herself against him and started rolling her hips, her entire body moving languidly over his. His ragged breathing was soon interspersed with breathless groans at the feel of her inner muscles gripping him. The sight of Entrapta, so flushed and focused as she took him to chase own pleasure, and he'd drifted into near-senselessness much sooner rather than later.

She indulged in forceful grinding, gritting her teeth and closing her eyes as she panted, pressing her swollen folds to the wet skin above his shaft. Then she rolled her hips harder, shutting her eyes and biting her lip. "Almost…" she gasped, threw her head back and failed to bite back a loud, frenzied, desperate sound as her legs began to shiver.

Her climax was a lengthy one, and seemed to build for a while before she peaked. Hordak barely kept himself from following her over the edge, holding stalk still and sweating as she pressed her swollen, dripping sex against him and clung to his body with all four limbs. As her breathing began to even, her quivering heat clenched and fluttered around his aching cock spasmodically.

After several moments of shuddering out her release while still grinding herself hard against him, she drew a great, heaving breath and went limp. When she raised her head to look back into his still-tense face, hers was shining and flushed rosy and glowing. Before she'd even caught her breath, she lifted herself up off of him and shifted again.

He groaned in protest when the cold air his his wet, turgid skin, but she ignored it. Rather, she shot him a short glare with devious eyes and gave him a cheeky grin before moving her hand back to his groin.

When she grasped him firmly again, the sight and sound and scent of it all sent a wave of heat through his body that brought his back arching up from the bed beneath him. She groaned as she ran a greedy hand back up over his abdomen, pressing her fingertips against the heaving stretch of meager muscle even as she kept pumping with her other hand.

He was able to resist longer than he would have guessed, but when she lowered her lips to suck the tip of his cock again, he finally lost control "Entrapta, ha-... agh, I'm going, I-I'm going to-"

She pulled his swollen cock from her mouth with an obscene sound and smiled. "I know," she panted, "I want to watch."

Her words sliced through his fogged mind and pierced him with searing heat. Dimly, through the haze of his high, he registered that his upper heart was aching a bit, but could not have cared less. Helpless moans poured from his open mouth as he grew more senseless beneath her. Arching up from the bed as much as her hair would allow.

She leaned forward, her stroking quickened, and she smirked through her sultry murmur, "Cum for me."

His own climax hit him impossibly hard, everything went quiet as his whole body lurched and shuddered, and little spots of light flashed in his vision behind tightly shut eyes. He dimly felt his own cum hit his dress over his chest and stomach, but his cries were lost beneath the roar of blood in his ears. When the spasming rapture that gripped his body finally receded, he felt himself drifting into the kind of peaceful oblivion that only Entrapta could give him. He barely registered that his hearing was still a muffled buzzing as the fog in his head surged from the corners of his mind, obscuring his vision from the edges inward as it cloaked him in heavy darkness.

* * * * *

Catra and Adora stopped for a while by the drainage wetlands, talking over what they examined as they tromped through mud and tall grass. It was a damn sight better than what the area had looked like when they'd got there, but it was clear that further adjustments needed to be made. But, they reasoned, Salineas' scientists and builders were more than up to the task, and they had Entrapta's and Perfuma's work to start from.

Once they moved on down the main road of the village, Adora returned to the conversation they'd been having before inspecting the drainage sight. "I just really don't want Tarsis to get a foothold in the wider Universe before we get magic to the people. They way things are from Prime, we don't even know how capable of self-defense his occupied worlds are anymore. And I am so, so done with innocent people suffering for no good reason, other than some fancy dickhead's ego."

Catra flipped her hood up and Adora followed suit as they walked deeper into town toward the tavern. After her last little run-in with the locals, she was secretly glad that Adora had insisted on accompanying her on her return visit. Hiding beneath hoods around these parts didn't exactly draw attention, either. The only thing off about their shifty nature in such a mixed populace was how new their outfits were.

"Am I being vengeful again, or does that sound reasonable?" Adora sounded annoyed.

"You're asking me about the difference between reasonable and unreasonable anger?" Catra replied with a raised brow. Adora shrugged and grunted, then sighed, thinking. "I don't know," Catra finally said, "you're angry for everyone, not just about yourself. And when you talk about it, it sounds to me like your anger is pretty called for." She heard Adora's small sigh of relief

over their footfalls on the pitted dirt road, making a mental note to report the continued need for maintenance back to Mermista. “And like… you’re right about a bunch of really bad shit happening needlessly, and ‘blood cries for justice’ or whatever. I feel like it’s pretty normal that you want to help establish a more just universe, especially after what you went through with She-Ra.”

Adora kept frowning, still troubled. “That’s the other part of the problem. The whole idea of serving justice… that's still a form of conflict, right?” she asked, brows drawn.

“And conflict is bound to beget more conflict, and likely violence,” sighed Catra, looking back down at the road to avoid puddles.

“Exactly,” Adora said emphatically. “And not just, like, the direct response either. Look at how mad people still are here on Etheria. People who were never even *in* the war are messed up about it. Like, this stuff is going to affect our *kids* .”

Catra new she was making a collective reference, but she still felt a stupid little thrill in her gut at the thought of having kids with Adora. “And kicking up a fuss in other places means potentially creating the same chain reaction, regardless of why we were there in the first place.”

“*Exactly*,” Adora groaned balefully. "And like, how do we even tell when and if potential conflict is worth the repercussions?” She sighed in frustration and discouragement as they finally approached the tavern. The window was boarded up and tarped over, and Adora raised a brow at her.

“Hordak lost his temper and threw the guy that stabbed him through the window.”

Adora made a thoughtful face and looked back at the tavern. “Seems fair, she muttered.” After taking another slow breath and frowning at the broken window, she looked back at Catra. “Now that we’re here…”

“They probably won’t want to see me in there?” Catra finished. “Yeah, I was wondering how to get around that too but the bar is going to be our best option for info.”

“No problem,” Adora said, putting back her hood and cracking her knuckles. “I got this. Just watch me get my spy craft on,” she smirked before strutting in.

Catra pressed a palm to her forehead before sliding it back through her hair. She loved the shit out of Adora, couldn’t love her more, but the woman had about as much finesse as heavy artillery. She crouched against the tavern wall, hood up and tail flicking, and waited for the inevitable.

Sure enough, it was only a few minutes before Adora slouched through the tavern door, clearly pouting. “They kicked you out?”

“Yeah.”

“But you’re She-Ra,” Catra complained.

“They were not impressed,” Adora explained, raising her eyebrows and shrugging.

“Whatever,” she said as Adora shook off whatever encounter she’d just had inside. “We can still ask around, honestly it’s crazy how many people don’t recognize me without the hair, even with the eyes. We just ticked our easy options off the list is all.”

“So now what?”

Catra put her hands on her hips and surveyed the street around them. “I don’t suppose you’re going to let me rough anyone up for information, are you?”

“Nope,” Adora smiled, shaking her head. Catra rolled her eyes and made to continue, but Adora snapped her fingers and pointed at her excitedly. “Bribery!”

“Strong option,” Catra agreed genuinely, “but, we don’t have much money, do we?”

“Aahhh,” Adora conceded with a groan, “I definitely spent all my money on our new outfits.” Her hand drifted to fiddle with the zipper at the bottom of her jacket and she narrowed her eyes to a squint. “And I don’t regret it.”

Catra snorted and folded her arms. “Alright then, we could stay on the main road. If she’s staying here she’s bound to show up at some point, right?”

“That’s a place to start, anyway,” Adora said, walking further down the road in the direction they’d been going as Catra followed. “Let’s make a loop of the main street, see what we can see.”

“Fine by me,” Catra answered vaguely as she looked around them.

The settlement was a sad, tired place, but necessities were available for purchase. A general store provided a narrow assortment of dubious foods and home goods, and the woman behind the till was amicable enough. There was a “host house” where people could go for tea and company, and they were able to trade She-Ra’s strength in fixing a few things around the place in exchange for a chance to talk to each of the people boarding and working there. Both pawn shops slammed the door in their faces, but Catra reasoned that if she were fencing a store full of stolen goods, she’d be paranoid about outsiders too. They stopped into a tool repair shop and the old man there didn’t seem to be very aware that a war had happened at all, and talked about his boring life in town as if it hadn’t changed in a century.

By the end of the day, they’d actually managed to talk to quite a few people. Much to Catra’s mounting agitation, however, not a single one of them recognized the name Octavia or her description. Every person they talked to, without fail, insisted that they would know if Octavia were living there, they would have seen her around and taken note of a new face, but nothing. “How

did a one-eyed woman who sprouts tentacles out her back when she's pissed manage to slip through this place without anyone noticing but me?" she asked Adora in exasperation as they took a break by the drainage area before heading back to Salineas. Catra itched distractedly at the scar on her shoulder, shoving her jacket back to get at it while she walked to the top of a small hill for a better view, Adora following as she ranted. "I know she was here because I *literally* saw her here, and I *know* she still looks the same," she said, running her fingers through her hair.



"Are you sure you didn't see something similar and just, like, construe it as Octavia? Read something familiar in a random pattern?" Adora asked.

"I'm almost positive," she insisted. "I mean, I was sure enough to spend all day schlepping around here asking about her," she said.

Adora nodded slowly and Catra rubbed her hands over her face, desperately trying not to slip into a foul mood in her dejection. “This is really important to you, huh?” Adora asked quietly.

With her kind words, Catra's anger melted into disappointment, and she heaved a long sigh before speaking again. “I just… I just really wanted to bring that lady’s daughter home,” she said, voice turning thick.

Adora hugged her, pinning her arms down at her sides and waiting until she relaxed into her hold. “We’ll keep looking,” she said against her hair.

Catra nodded and rested her face on Adora’s shoulder, wrapping her forearms around her waist as well as she could under Adora’s strong grip. When she finally released her, Catra stepped back and sniffed, shaking herself. “Whew!,” she huffed, heaving a sigh and swinging her arms. “This reconstruction stuff is way harder than I thought it was going to be.”

“Ugh, tell me about it,” Adora muttered back before turning to head for the road.

Her frustrated tone caught Catra's attention as she followed her back down the short hill. “So I was thinking about what you said, about being more visible in the wider Universe,” Catra began cautiously, trying both to change the subject, and to get Adora to tell her more about her concerns.

“Me too,” Adora said, her face falling.

“Yeah?” Catra prompted.

“You’re not the only one that said I was scary when I lost it with Sivtria,” she said miserably. “I mean, when Micah felt what was happening, like, magically, he immediately ran off to find Entrapta and work on the virus.” Catra wanted to comfort her, but she waited. “And I have to wonder… is that the version of She-Ra that we want to show the Universe?” Catra nodded, brow furrowed and mouth shut. “Prime said the whole thing with She-Ra inspiring

other worlds was that she was a symbol to rally around," she continued, "Until we figure out this virus crap, am I able to be the symbol the Universe needs?"

"I feel like you're putting a lot more on yourself than you need to," Catra said doubtfully. "You can't predict what kind of symbol the Universe needs, you can just do your best." Adora nodded, but she didn't seem reassured. "Honestly I don't even know how relevant it is, all things considered."

"What do you mean?"

"I think the bigger problem with this road trip thing is that we'll need Entrapta to handle all kinds of different tech, she said, "and learn from it and integrate it and shit. And she's not exactly at her best right now either."

Adora didn't answer, but rather lowered her eyes to the road and scowled, losing herself in thought. Catra followed suit and for a long time they walked in silence. Finally, Adora started shaking her head again and took a deep breath to speak. "Regardless," she said, "regardless of this stupid fucking virus, our road trip can't happen soon enough." She looked over at Catra and her expression was serious and determined. "At the very least, we need to extend the Alliance's presence further. Hordak was right, clearly our message wasn't enough. We need to share our magic, and we need to stand as visible opposition against Sivtria and every expansion-hungry asshole like her."

"Violence begets violence," Catra said doubtfully. "Are you sure we're ready to kick that hornet's nest? Are you sure it's even our business?"

"Maybe not," Adora replied bitterly, and her face was still grave as they walked on. "We might be new to this space age bullshit, but we fucking meant it when we said that it's a new era. I know you feel the same way," she shot an accusatory glance sideways.

"I do," Catra agreed, "I'm just… I'm just worried about you. The universe is a big place full of heavy burdens. It's not your job to carry them." To Catra's surprise, Adora didn't argue, but nodded slowly, eyes lowering again. "*But*," Catra continued in her 'it's not over yet' voice, "what did you have in mind?"

Adora returned her gaze to Catra's face and offered a half-smile. "What do you think of asking the Star siblings to become the first off-planet members of the Alliance."

* * * * *

The next thing Hordak was fully aware of was the unmistakable shape and weight of Entrapta clinging to his chest. Then he registered that her naked body was pressed against his bare skin, and he wondered vaguely where his dress had gone. He meant to ask, but his entire body felt heavy and sluggish, and the most he did was stir and mumble before opening his eyes to blurred, swimming vision. His stomach sank when he finally realized he'd passed out cold.

"Hordak?" Entrapta's head snapped up the moment he moved, and her voice was high and sharp. "Talk to me Love, please," she said, moving over him to hold his face.

"You called me Love," he murmured, smiling blearily as he blinked and struggling to recollect his senses.

"Are you back?" she asked hopefully.

"I'm fine," he frowned, confused by her stress as his view of her strained expression slowly clarified. "This isn't the first time I've fainted in front of you, either."

She sighed in relief and leaned back to sit on his stomach. “I know, I know,” she said, "I just… had a nightmare where you died kind of like this. It freaked me out is all.”

She lowered her head back to his chest as he pulled a face. “You had a nightmare that you fucked me to death?”

This time she scowled, throwing him an offended look. “Well, there was a lot more cybernetics involved, but... essentially yes.”

Hordak lay back and thought for a few moments while she held her ear against the fat scar down the middle of his chest. “That’s how I want to die,” he finally decided.

“Hang on, I’m trying to hear…” she muttered without finishing her sentence.

“Although I’d rather have your thighs pressed to my ears and your-”

“Hordak would you shut up?” she said in exasperation, though she was smiling when she glanced up at him. “I’m trying to listen to your pulse.”

He bit his lips as she lowered her head back to his chest, fighting a smile of his own. “Pulses,” he corrected softly.

“Hordak!” He waited in obedient silence until she was satisfied and sat back upright to fix him with a tired look. “Hordak, do you do anything other than work, study, and fuck?”

He opened his mouth to argue, but had to pause. After a few seconds of thinking, he finally offered, “Sometimes I sleep?”

She closed her eyes lightly before growling, "Let me guess, you don't even stop working when you eat?” He didn’t answer and she shook her fists in agitation. “Are you fucking kidding me?” she asked through gritted teeth, still entirely naked. “Do I have to personally make you sleep more? Because I will tie you to the damn bed.” He raised an eyebrow and smirked in response. “Not

like that," she sighed, rolling her eyes again. "Look, either you take it easier, or I'll tell Glimmer you're defying direct orders from the Alliance."

That wiped the smirk from his face. "You wouldn't."

"Don't kid yourself," she said, glaring. "I will absolutely sic the princesses on you if you don't knock this shit off. And I'm talking to Mushroom about your heart tomorrow. I want that thing back in order ASAP."

"Well," he reasoned slowly, and his eyes slid down her body despite himself. "If the problem is about to be fixed anyway…" he looked at where her wet crux was still in contact with his abdomen and inhaled deeply, drawn to the scent of her desire like a moth to flame.

"Oh my… *no* !" She made another incredulous face at him and pushed herself up off his chest. "I'm still mad at you," she huffed as she dropped sideways and bounced into place next to him.

"For fainting?" he asked in disbelief as he rolled over to face her.

"For scaring me," she said, placing her palm on his cheek and gentling her voice. "I want to bang too, but it's hard to stay horny when I'm afraid of you getting hurt," she reasoned, stroking her thumb gently across his cheekbone.

He heaved a lengthy sigh. "That's entirely reasonable," he admitted begrudgingly.

"Don't pout," she teased, moving the hand from his cheek so she could brush her thumb over his mouth. "We can update the log when you've had some rest."

She scooted nearer and slid her hand back on his head so she could take the tip of his ear gently between her fingers. She rubbed it lightly, rhythmically, and soon he'd been lulled into a stupor by the soothing motion. His purr rumbled to life in his chest and Entrapta grinned, closing her eyes and fondling his ear

lazily. As his eyelids became too heavy to lift and her fingers slowly faltered at his ear, he remembered something that brought one last smile to his face before they both fell asleep. “You called me Love,” he whispered in the dark.

The hand on his ear lowered to cup the back of his head and pull it lower, then he felt the soft warmth of her lips pressed against his. “So sleep, Love. We’ll rest together,” she answered, inches away from his face. She let go of his head and snuggled in against his chest where he wrapped her in his arms. He buried his nose in her hair and sighed in contentment, his purr surging once more before they both drifted off.

Chapter End Notes

> If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you’ve got. It is very much appreciated.

"More than this."

Chapter Summary

> The team starts to wrap their heads around the virus, then Catra and Hordak run an errand.

Chapter Notes

> The artist mentioned it again so I figured I'd reiterate that this stuff was made for sharing, if anyone wants to take something and run with it. They artist is anonymous anyway and would get a kick out of whoever enjoyed their doodles.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"It's fine, Adora."

"It's not."

"Sure it is. It's not like I haven't done way worse to you, like, a million times."

"I don't believe I snapped at you. You're the one who had a reason to be upset."

"It's *fine* ," Catra insisted as she opened a large door for Adora and Melog and they re-entered the main complex at Mystacor, doing her best to stay patient.

Adora heaved a heavy sigh as their eyes adjusted to the dimmer indoor lighting and they made their way toward the ceremonial center of the magic school. She'd taken Catra on a short tour of her favorite spots around Mystacor, which included natural pools of hot spring water. Catra had tried to stay casual, nobody else on Etheria would have noticed, but Adora knew her far too well and picked up on her discomfort immediately. Because of her ensuing questions and Melog's insistence on emotional honesty, Catra had

been compelled to detail her previously vague description of Prime's purification ritual.

She'd tried to describe hers, but it had been too difficult to keep up with. So she described Hordak's repurification instead, which turned out to be a miscalculation. She'd forgotten Adora knew she'd gone to her own purification willingly after reconditioning, and when Catra had tried to shrug the entire situation off with a few bad jokes, she'd reacted with frustration and anger. This, of course, was immediately followed by contrition, shame, and further frustration.

Catra bumped Adora's shoulder gently as they walked. "I shouldn't have said it was nothing. I.. uh… what the fuck is it Perfuma says? I invalidated your reaction? Your emotional reaction? Or just your feelings… whatever, you know what I'm trying to say. You had reason to be angry at what I was saying, and I know you didn't mean to aim it at me." Melog gave a low chirrup from her side.

Adora shrugged and glanced over at her sideways, still looking troubled. "I… okay. I totally get that I'm not great at feelings. But… when and how did you get better with anger issues than me?"

Catra snorted into a genuine laugh. "Shit, I don't fucking know," she looked off as her smile faded slowly, thinking about the question for a moment. "You know what? Scratch that. I know what happened." Adora raised an eyebrow at her and Catra was relieved to see that she had her attention again. "I spent a hell of a lot more time than you fucking things up, which became quite the learning experience once I ended up on the Velvet Glove and got a chance to think about it all. A lot of angry hours up there, all alone with my many, *many* regrets." She thought back to that anguished period, where even time and memory had lost its meaning before she'd been rescued. "I knew it was way too late to salvage anything from my life before, but sometimes… I guess I kind of let myself fantasize... about everything I'd do differently if I ever made it out of there alive. Somehow managed to start over somewhere. Anywhere."

“Everything you wish you could go back and do different?” Adora asked with a wistful smile.

“You know how it goes.” She looked back at Adora and smiled again. “Plus what Double Trouble said about me driving everyone away kind of forced me to be honest with myself.” She kept her eyes on Adora’s face as they walked, and waited until the other looked up into her gaze. When she had Adora’s full attention, she continued. “So…” she began, trying to express herself clearly, “when I’d thought that my feelings were the problem, I tried to make them stop, right?” Adora raised a brow but didn’t answer. “But they didn’t stop. They just... went sideways and turned into rage, and I couldn't control it. I think maybe the emotions just have to happen. At least for me.” She frowned at her toes, watching them appear and disappear beneath her as they continued down an empty hall, steps echoing off polished stone. “But right now I'm trying to shift my control from what I feel, over to how I let it affect the people and things around me. Does that make sense?” Adora nodded and she heaved a sigh. “Melog helps a lot, keeps me honest.” She threw another half smile over at her girlfriend, who remained serious and pensive. “Luckily, I got to start over with you after all.” Adora's expression finally eased, and she took her hand in a firm grasp.

They had nearly reached the temple room when they came upon a relatively odd sight; Glimmer, crouched near an intersection in the hallways and gathering a large mass of pink, shimmering energy between her hands. When they approached, she broke focus just long enough to hold a finger up to her mouth, shushing them silently before getting back to her growing wad of sparkles. Catra and Adora raised eyebrows at one another before looking back at Glimmer curiously, but she offered no explanation.

A click and a creak announced the opening of a large door and for a moment, Catra heard several familiar voices and a nasally cackle drifting toward her through the frame. Then it shut and a set of footsteps began to approach, accompanied by the sound of Bow muttering to himself. Glimmer grinned up at them, winked, and

disappeared. A moment later, they heard her gleefully roar “Glitter bomb!”

Adora and Catra peaked around the corner and watched a giant cloud of pink and purple sparkles settle over where the couple lay in a heap on the ground. Bow coughed into his fist a few times before waving his hand in front of his face and squinting. “Glimmer, I’m going to be glittering for *hours* .”

“That was the idea,” Glimmer replied happily, sitting up on top of him as he propped himself up on his elbows.



“Don’t tell me you’re doing that thing again,” Bow said sternly, though the hint of a smirk played at the corners of his mouth.

Glimmer pshed and waved her hand airily. “You’re the dashing, tech-master war hero of Bright Moon. Brave, brilliant, and looking like an absolute snack in that crop top. Of course I want people to know whose bed you come home to at night.”

“Glimmer,” Bow said, twisting his mouth further and obviously struggling to remain stoic.

“And besides,” Glimmer continued, bouncing her eyebrows at him, “you’ve never complained about a glittering smile before.” Bow finally broke into a grin. “There it is,” she said softly, reaching small fingers up to brush over his bottom lip.

“You’re being ridiculous,” he said, though his face was soft and his eyelids were lowering.

“Am not,” she countered, moving her fingers to his jawline. “You seemed gloomy. This is me cheering you up.”

Bow frowned and Glimmer lowered her hand in resignation. “Did you notice how much more Entrapta’s been dropping her tools? ”

“Entrapta always drops stuff. She’s kind of clumsy, Bow.”

He shook his head. “Not like that, I mean, like, her hair. She still uses it a lot but it’s super different, haven’t you seen how much less she’s running around on it?”

Glimmer sighed and nodded. “Yeah, I did notice she doesn’t multitask with it nearly as much as she used to.”

“Or… just *move* like she used to. The woman was a menace just a couple of months ago, but now she’s almost… *unobtrusive*.” He said the word like a grisly diagnosis.

“Hey,” Glimmer said, bringing her hand back up to his face so she could turn his chin toward her. “That’s why we’re here. We’re in the middle of a big breakthrough, remember?” Catra glanced at Adora, who didn’t seem to notice.

Bow took Glimmer’s hand in his and kissed the backs of her fingers. “You’re right.” He leaned forward and kissed her. “And you always make me smile.”

They kept kissing and when they made no move to stop, Catra realized they'd been forgotten and nudged Adora. They smiled at each other before walking back out into the hall and making their way toward their friends with Melog.

"Hey guys," Bow said when he noticed their approach. "Yay! The Best Friend Squad is together and ready for action."

"You bet," Adora said, kicking his foot lightly. "But we also need to talk about a few things." Her attempt at a half smile was more of a flickering grimace, and Bow and Glimmer exchanged a look.

"Sivtria?" Glimmer asked from where she sat on Bow. "What were you thinking?"

Adora gave her a look. "I was talking to Catra about it, actually."

"Any ideas?" Bow asked Catra hopefully.

She was about to start talking about the Star siblings when Adora continued. "I don't know. I'm… I feel kind of confused. And a little scared." Catra gave her a curious look and squeezed her hand. Melog flicked their tail, looking between them all expectantly. Adora groaned, closing her eyes and wiping a hand over her forehead and hair poof. "What on Etheria were we even thinking yesterday?" The other three exchanged confused glances. "We should have gotten together about this as soon as she was gone! How much time have we already wasted?"

"Adora," Glimmer started gently. "Slow down a second."

"What? Why?" Adora responded, her tone forceful. "This is as urgent as it gets and it might be up to us to handle. Too many people are suffering for us to be taking free time."

"What we were doing yesterday was important," Bow said to Adora firmly.

"Tending brave hearts, remember?" Catra asked her quietly. Melog walked behind her to nose Adora's hand. With a long sigh, Adora

seemed to let some of the tension fade from her posture.

"I know this is urgent," Glimmer continued in a small voice, "but… isn't anyone else afraid of being wrong?" she asked, looking up at Catra from beneath furrowed brows.

"Yeah," Bow said, nodding. "We all thought we were so pure." He scowled. "when really, we were being so hypocritical about so many things… and now…"

"Now you're not sure when and if you're right about anything?" Glimmer asked, voicing Catra's thoughts.

Bow nodded. "I still want to do the right thing, but you said it. I'm really, really afraid of doing the wrong thing instead."

"Seems like a reasonable thing to be afraid of," Catra said grimly, trying not to get distracted by her own memories.

"I keep waiting to be manipulated like Shadow Weaver did, you know?" Glimmer added. "Obviously I'm susceptible to stuff like that. In some ways, I feel less sure than ever since Prime, not *more* sure."

"There are some things we can be certain of, though," said Adora. "I feel like it's pretty obvious that whatever it is Sivtria's getting up to, she's doing things that are very obviously wrong."

"Yeah," Catra said, trying to keep her voice gentle, "but we also need to know what's going on with all that before we can make any moves anyway."

Glimmer broke in, face falling slowly. "I let my rage cloud my judgment until I followed it into… *horrific* decisions." Bow shifted his weight on his elbows so he could stroke a hand down her back. "I'm afraid of us making the same mistake with Sivtria because she's so awful, you know?"

Adora's arms were crossed and she was chewing her lip. Catra looked at Melog for an explanation and they gave her a series of

meows and chirrups. “Are you thinking about Sivtria’s clones, or what Hordak said about refugees yesterday?” she finally asked.

Adora clenched her jaw and huffed a frustrated sigh. “Either way, isn’t it enough?” She pressed her arms tighter against herself and frowned at them all in turn. “Take what we’ve seen and heard so far, and multiply it by however many millions of people who’ve been murdered or lost everything since Prime’s death.” Her emotion was rising and she didn’t seem to notice when Melog bumped her hand again. “How can I *not* think about that kind of pain? She-Ra can jump around a freezing vacuum cutting through spaceships! How can I have any right to stay here where it’s nice and comfortable when people are out there dying?”

The other three exchanged another round of strained looks. “We’re doing our best,” Bow repeated Wrong Hordak’s meager platitude from the day before.

“*I’m tired of hearing that!* ” Adora shouted, temper finally breaking.

“Then what *do* you want, Adora?” Catra asked calmly, even a little coldly.

“I…” she sucked in a tiny gasp, eyes widening. “I want to do enough.” Her voice went small and soft again, and it looked like she might start tearing up. “I want to do enough.”

“What does that look like?” Glimmer asked.

“I don’t know,” Adora said, the fight fully drained from her again. “More than this.”

“You know it’s not that easy,” Catra said, wishing she had something better to offer. “We have no clue what messes we might be stepping in, or what we could end up making worse.”

For a few moments, nobody spoke. “Adora?” They all started and looked around at Angella’s voice. She was leaning on her cane,

poking her head through the door that apparently hadn't quite shut behind Bow. "Are you alright?"

"Yes, uh, yeah. Yeah, I'm fine. Sorry about that," Adora said hurriedly, blushing and running a hand over her poof again.

Angella smiled and gave her a patient look. "Are you sure?"

Adora sighed and relented. "We're talking about how Etheria should react to further atrocities in the wider Universe." She pulled a face and rubbed at her side absently. "Especially considering that She-Ra is capable of handling things like… you know… Prime."

Angella nodded slowly, taking a few steps so that she could stand up straight against her cane next to Adora. "I don't know that I have the right to make suggestions," she began slowly, looking at each of them in turn. "What is worrying you about your options?"

Her question surprised Catra and seemed to unbalance Adora, who blinked. "Umm…?" She looked at Catra, who shrugged and gestured at her to go ahead. "I guess… uh… I'm worried about not being able to be the right kind of She-Ra?" She glanced at Catra again. "Like, the She-Ra that the Universe needs, or whatever."

Angella nodded slowly. "Do not forget to be the kind of Adora that *you* need." Adora blushed again and Angella placed a gentle hand on her cheek. "I'm so sorry I don't have answers for you," she continued, "but follow your heart, and I'm sure you'll do well." She tilted Adora's face up to meet her eyes, which were more gentle and kind than Catra could comprehend. "My only advice is that…" she hesitated for a moment, "people are desperately fallible, no matter how well they mean." She dropped her hand from Adora's face and leaned more heavily on her cane as everyone present exchanged sad looks. "I know it's a horror, but I beg you all to keep thinking things through as you go." They all nodded.

"Thanks, your Majesty," Adora mumbled.

Bow spoke up, "I know we can do it. Etherians will figure this out, they're special people. Plus, we should probably try and figure out how to transplant magic before our official road trip anyway."

Angella smiled back at him before she pulled her hand from Adora's face. Then she took a deep breath and turned to Catra. "Now. I breakfasted with Glimmer and Bow, but how have you been, Catra?"

Taken aback, Catra blurted, "Me?"

"Yes," Angella said, still smiling as gently as ever.

"Uh… I am gr-reat," she answered haltingly. "And you?"

"Queen Angella?" Entrapta's high, nasal voice called from the temple room. "Can you come tell Mushroom about what you felt with the destroyed Moonstone in the in-between dimension you got stuck in for a couple of years?"

"I'm being summoned," Angella said, smiling down at them. There were more lines at the corners of her eyes than Catra had ever noticed before. "I trust you all to act with honor," she said, looking at Glimmer, who didn't smile back.

"Right," Glimmer said once her mother had gone. "Who can be spared to visit with our first allies and help get a feel for building the Alliance off-planet? Obviously, She-Ra and I would probably be expected to go, but Adora comes first and if she's got things to take care of, then that's okay." She fixed Catra with a focused stare. "I'm sure Catra will be wherever Adora is." Catra nodded lazily. "We'll definitely want a tech team and a records-keeper. And we need to talk to Entrapta about portable magic. First we should probably get back in touch with the Star siblings."

"Clearly, we need to have another Alliance meeting," Bow broke in before Glimmer could launch into full-on administrator mode.

They all nodded and there was silence for a few seconds before Glimmer spoke again, less urgently now. "I want to hear what our

elders have to say, but considering how everything's gone down over the past lifetime or so, I think we should meet with the other princesses first. We have a few decisions to make about our futures." She paused for a moment. "Who we want to be. What we want Etheria to be."

"Who all do we gather?" Catra asked.

"We should have Perfuma, definitely," Bow said.

"Perfuma always helps keep things moral," Adora said, nodding. "Perfuma will bring Scorpia, Mermista will bring Sea Hawk…"

"Netossa and Spinnerella should probably be included too," Glimmer added, "and Frosta."

"Definitely Entrapta, and how about the old man?" Catra asked.

The others exchanged a round of unsure looks. "Well, isn't he one of the elders that failed us?" Glimmer asked. "For this discussion, we're kind of looking for good judgment and-"

"And you're having *me* sit in?" Catra asked, raising her brow. She felt her eyes narrow slightly and reminded herself to keep her face passive.

"Fair point," Bow said.

"Also," she added, "I think Hordak might technically be younger than Entrapta if we're only counting conscious years. And, he might have done literally everything ever wrong," she conceded, "like, *super* wrong… but he also knows a thing or two about the universe we're walking into- things that the Star siblings might not know- which is more than almost any other Etherian can say." Catra waited for a few moments, but nobody seemed to have a reply. "Unless there were other clones Prime kept close that might know more?" she offered.

"No," Bow said firmly. "We're not pulling any of Prime's favorites into this. We leave them be unless we have no other choice.

Catra's right, Hordak is our best option."

"Alright then," Glimmer said, "I'll start messaging people.

"Glimmer?" Entrapta's voice carried out to them again, "Can you come hang on to your dad and this big antenna at the same time?"

Glimmer immediately disappeared and Bow frowned. "That sounds ominous," he mumbled, following Angella back through the doors of the temple room.

When it was just Melog, Adora and her again, Catra muttered, "Why is Angella so fucking nice? It keeps throwing me off."

Adora shrugged. "Apparently it's just like, a thing."

"Really?" Catra tried to keep her incredulity from coming off as disdainful.

"Yup," Adora nodded, "most Etherians just… expect moms to be nice to their kids."

Catra wrinkled her nose and furrowed her brow in confusion. "Crazy," she muttered faintly.

"Right?" Adora agreed.

* * *

It took another twenty minutes or so, but after several rounds of triumphant cries and maniacal laughter from Entrapta, Catra and Adora were called into the temple room. Entrapta paced and

twirled her fingers and hair in little circles as she explained what was going on, breaking regularly to give frustrated break-downs on points Catra or Adora asked her to clarify. Mushroom, Bow and Castaspella offered input from a gigantic sorcerer's desk piled with spooky-looking lab equipment while Angella watched passively from a seat next to the doors, Micah lingering at her side.

Catra lost track a few times, but for the most part she was confident that she was on the same general page as the others as to what they were there to do. Apparently, Micah had recognized a feeling from She-Ra's almost-tantrum that he hadn't felt since Shadow Weaver's botched spell of obtainment- something… something about ancient energies getting rubbed the wrong way or some shit? Whatever, Entrapta and Bow had explained to her that the virus fucked with tech, but it also fucked with combinations of tech and magic- i.e. She-Ra, Entrapta, First Ones monsters, and potentially every elemental princess on Etheria because their runestones were also First Ones tech. Catra had tried to get Entrapta to elaborate on that particular point, but her grip on the situation was already tenuous enough without Entrapta digressing, and the team needed to focus on the tasks at hand. It wasn't until after Adora had managed to transform into She-Ra and the assembly did some weird shit with wands and meters they said were tests, that it was announced that they were ready to try and do something about 'the energy blockage' they felt in She-Ra. It all sounded kind of dumb and extremely unscientific to Catra, but they were the experts.

"It's doing something to your ability to process Etheria's magic through yourself, that's why it keeps turning destructive," Micah explained to Adora once the light from She-Ra's transformation faded.

Adora groaned. "You sound just like Shadow Weaver when she helped me learn how to heal." She adopted a deeper, more menacing voice and imitated Shadow Weaver's drawl. "'Allow the emotion to be- feel it fully, then let it go. You have to let the energy flow, blah blah blah."

“Exactly,” Micah agreed apologetically.

“I hate to admit it, but Shadow Weaver probably could have helped a lot with this stuff,” Castaspella begrudgingly acknowledged.

“Sucks to suck,” Catra interjected flatly, shrugging.

“Well, She-Ra needs reason to direct and temper rage, right?” Entrapta continued. “Obviously Adora’s still in there no matter how mad She-Ra gets, so the idea is to do whatever we can to help her reforge whatever bridge got jostled up so that she’s got what she needs to maintain a functional flow of magic, haha!” Entrapta clapped her hands, beaming with enthusiasm over the experiment. “Symptom management! Theoretically. Or maybe we can figure out some kind of outlet? Who knows! Let’s find out!” She let loose a peal of maniacal laughter and bounded back over toward Mushroom and their science bullshit.

“I was right,” Catra heard Adora mutter under her breath.

“Huh?” she asked, turning to see Adora staring at the floor with a shockingly haunted expression.

“I was right,” she repeated, squeezing her eyes shut tight for several seconds. “It’s too much… it’s getting backed up in my system, and…” her eyes welled even as her expression soured into something venomous, “and it’s poisoning me,” she finished with a harsh whisper.

Catra placed her hand on the back of Adora’s neck and pulled her forward so that she could press their foreheads together. “We’re going to figure this out, okay? You can do this.” She nodded and Catra stepped back. “So… what now?” she asked, looking around. Glimmer, Castaspella, and Micah stepped forward, surrounding Adora. “Maybe start small?” she suggested, then cringed at how nervous she sounded.

“Try transforming again,” Entrapta called out.

Adora nodded, then closed her eyes and took a deep breath. "For the honor…" she began with her usual build-up volume, "OF-"

"Wait!" Entrapta's warbling shout startled them all. The little woman with dragging pigtails sprinted forward, adjusted one of her portable sensor-things toward Adora by a few inches, then sprinted back to her place beside Mushroom at the dest. "Okay, go ahead." Catra rolled her eyes and Adora gave an annoyed huff before trying again.

The next time Adora said the words, it was with much less gusto. She kept trying, however, and though it took a few attempts, She-Ra soon stood shining before them once more.

Entrapta gave her next order. "Um… uh, try getting mad. But like… just a little bit mad." She-Ra gave her a frustrated glare of confusion. "Perfect! … okay… try a little more anger." This time Adora's confusion was milder and her shoulders slumped. "Wait, where'd it go? You were doing great!"

"This is really weird," She-Ra complained, pulling a face. "Just… asking me to be mad isn't making me feel very mad."

"Think about Sivtria," Glimmer suggested from her side.

Adora screwed up her face for a moment. "Well, now you feel kind of sad and worried," Micah remarked, holding up a hand toward She-Ra's glow as if testing the heat of a flame.

"Think about what it almost cost to stop Prime," Catra said grimly, and Adora's eyes flew open. "...to finally end a war that almost consumed everything." She knew she'd struck a very sensitive chord when She-Ra started glowing brighter and her ponytail started blowing lightly, and she plunged ahead. "Think about what Prime cost us over the years, then think about how he was just the big, fancy tip of a much bigger, equally shitty iceberg." She sneered. "A never ending supply of assholes who prefer a universe where their cruelty can go unchecked."

“Now,” Micah said loudly to Castaspella and Glimmer. Glimmer and Micah both grabbed a hand and for a moment, She-Ra was distracted by their touch.

“Keep her angry,” Entrapta called to Catra, who was growing more uncomfortable with the situation by the second.

She didn’t like what she was about to do, especially because it was so easy, but Catra knew how to upset Adora best of all. “I bet we’re angry about a lot of the same stuff, huh She-Ra?” she let some of her old bitterness trickle into her voice and resisted finching at the look of hurt that crossed She-Ra’s face at the sudden frost. “A lot of old wounds just keep getting opened, don’t they? All those hard lessons that Etherians fought and died to earn over the centuries... and we're still dealing with assholes like Sivtria.”

Glimmer used her free hand to raise her father’s staff, then brought it down hard on the floor below them. Beautiful, glowing, iridescent energy becant to bubble from the bottom of the staff, licking at Glimmer’s feet and legs before sluggishly spreading outward, rolling over the feet of the other sorcerers and crawling up the staff onto Glimmer’s outstretched hand.

As it spread through her body toward Adora, Catra kept talking. “How about all those years in the Horde, learning to serve and win instead of how to be a person? Think about the years I spent there without you. I did well without you. I thrived without you.” It was a half-lie, but Adora’s eyes were growing bright blue as whatever Glimmer was manipulating finally reached her hand.

When the shimmering magic finally touched the seam between hers and Glimmer’s clasped palms, the light was suddenly sucked inward toward Adora’s chest. The heart shape of the failsafe began to glow there, but it was distorted; muddled and flickering as it grew brighter. The energy building at Adora’s chest began to tumble and throb, and slowly its color turned from crystal iridescence to a burning crimson.

“Micah,” Entrapta called.

Micah heaved a deep breath and focused on Adora’s hand. The energy at Adora’s chest began to move more erratically and Adora winced, though Catra couldn’t tell if it was from pain or concern. *She* was certainly concerned, and Melog seemed to be also, growing large and red in tandem with whatever was being moved through Adora. Castaspella raised her hands however, and as they began to glow the energy soothed somewhat. Finally, an extension from the amorphous blob began to draw into Adora’s arm, pulling forward by starts, halting and wavering as if Micah were trying to draw water up a tube without sufficient suction.

“Catra,” Entrapta shouted, and she began to ramble again.

“Remember when Prime finally showed up, even though you tried so hard to keep that from happening?” She-Ra scowled as Micah began to sweat. “Remember when he took Glimmer? When… he took me?” Wind whipped She-Ra’s ponytail and she bared her teeth. “Do you remember the shape we were in when you finally got us back?” She-Ra's entire body seemed to flex where she stood, but she hadn't crushed Glimmer's or Micah's hands.



Entrapta's warbling sound of uncertainty carried over the building whoosh of wind now blowing around the room. "Haa… if you can, keep it up a little longer…"

Catra clenched her fists and swore to herself before continuing. "How many of your friends sacrificed themselves to Prime because they had no choice but to put their faith in *you* ?" A tear finally overflowed Catra's eyes and was blown across her cheek as she continued. "How many of us did he use before it was over, Adora?" She swallowed thickly and cried, "How about the things he said to you? How often does he still show up in your nightmares?" By the time the brilliant red energy roiling at the center of She-Ra's chest broke, Catra was ready to call it quits. When it did, however, everything went white, and nothing but a high-pitched ringing could be heard over the blinding flash that knocked Catra back.

When Catra rolled over and lurched to her feet, dizzy and disoriented, she saw that she was the first to do so. Next, she registered that Adora was kneeling on the floor where She-Ra had stood, head bowed and hands laid limply on her thighs. She stumbled toward her, shaking her head and blinking, coughing to see if she could hear it yet. "Are you okay?" she asked, gripping Adora's shoulder.

"Don't touch me," Adora replied, and Catra withdrew her hand immediately.

Behind and around her, she heard the others pull themselves up off the floor, checking with each other hurriedly to make sure nobody was hurt. Thankfully Angella wasn't even knocked out of her chair. Catra was slightly relieved when Adora held up a finger, signaling that she was at least in the process of recovering herself, but she couldn't pull her ears up from where they lay on her head as she nervously patted Melog.

Before Angella had quite made it over on Micah's arm, Adora heaved a deep sigh and swiped at her eyes. "I don't want to do

that again, it's too dangerous. I… don't want to hurt anyone." She raised weary eyes to look around the group.

"That's okay!" Entrapta chimed from the back. "We've got some *fantastic* data from these tests to work on in the interim anyway!" She sounded utterly thrilled.

"Anything that helps Entrapta?" Catra asked Bow.

"Anything we learn about the virus helps Entrapta," he said, smiling bracingly before his face faltered briefly. "But… not directly, no we didn't."

"She doesn't seem to be dealing with any of the same symptoms," Glimmer noted.

"And we still don't know why," Bow added with a sigh. "But," he shrugged, "different people, different systems, different effects. We'll figure it out," he smiled again and Catra was, to her own surprise, marginally soothed.

She was relieved when Adora finally lifted her eyes to Catra's again and offered an apologetic smile. Catra extended her hand, which Adora took, and heaved her up off the floor into a tight hug. "Sorry Babe," she whispered.

"S'okay," Adora mumbled back, squeezing tighter for a moment before releasing. "And I think I like 'Babe.'"

Catra gave her another half-smile. "Then I'll call you Babe whenever you want, Babe."

Adora rolled her eyes and Catra took the opportunity to kiss her. Entrapta's flat voice carried over other quiet conversation as Adora returned the kiss gently. "... Speaking of space," she was saying, "now I *really* need you to come help me with Hordak. You've put off new armor for this long, but now he needs heart surgery and I want you to at least be there. Don't tell him I said this, but I don't think he's very good at surgery. His stitches weren't even straight, not from any of the procedures, although I suppose that could be

at least partially attributed to large amounts of local anesthetic and pain suppressants. He says with enough local anesthetic, anything is possible, but why not do the thing right if we have the tools and the opportunity to do the thing properly?" She paused for a beat as the room eavesdropped. "Maybe I shouldn't have mentioned the messy scars, that seems pretty private in hindsight. Anyway, I still want you to tell me more about the interfacing between the uniform fabric and the cybernetic network of…"

Catra tuned out Entrapta's rambling when Bow leaned toward Glimmer, frowning, and muttered, "Is it just me, or does it kind of seem like Mushroom's been avoiding Hordak?"

"Is it just me, or did Entrapta just say Hordak's done multiple surgeries on himself?" Glimmer replied, staring over at Entrapta with a disturbed expression. "That guy is fucking insane."

"Yeah, what have I been saying?" Catra interjected, rolling her eyes.

"He needs heart surgery?" Adora asked, but before anyone could say anything else, Catra's communicator started beeping from her jacket pocket.

"Speak of the… huh," she muttered when she saw that it was Hordak who was calling her. She shrugged, ended the ringing, and replaced the communicator.

"But Hordak is calling," Bow said in confusion.

"And what? I'm busy," Catra said tersely.

"Shouldn't we see what he needs?" Adora asked.

Catra gave her an incredulous look, but Entrapta spoke loudly from behind her before she could retort. "Catraaaaa," she called as if summoning her for a chore. "The distress signal on Hordak's pin is going off. He said to tell you and that you'd know what it meant."

“Ooohh,” Catra said slowly, comprehension dawning.

Entrapta frowned at her datapad before narrowing her eyes up at Catra. “Is anything wrong? Is he hiding something?”

She smiled and shook her head in easy reply. “No, I know what’s happening. Don’t worry, Entrapa, nothing’s up with him. I just have to go help with some Salineas stuff.” This explanation seemed to suffice, because Entrapta smiled shortly before slamming down her welding mask and getting back to work.

“Is he in some sort of trouble?” Bow asked.

“Nah,” she replied, exchanging a knowing look with Adora, “but I’ve got to go. If you’re done with her, I’ll take Adora as a witness.” She looked around at the suspicious faces of her friends. “I mean… as a fellow caring and concerned member of the Alliance.”

Glimmer raised an eyebrow, but waved them away with a shrug. “Entrapta says we’re good here, and Bow and I are due for cake and tea with Mom and Aunt Casta. They’ve been making more of an effort ever since we told Mom about how much Aunt Casta helped after we lost her.”

“Perfect,” Catra said, jerking her head at Adora and Melog, who stepped toward Glimmer’s outstretched hand. “To the warehouses at Salineas,” she informed Glimmer.

“I’ll get you somewhere in that general area,” Glimmer said before teleporting. “Probably.”

* * *

As they made their way toward the refugee camp from an upscale bakery in central Salineas, Hordak and Melog in tow, Adora kept shooting skeptical looks sideways at Catra. "I know you told Glimmer you'd explain later, but exactly what am I about to witness?"

"Oh, you're fine," Catra dismissed. "We're just going to go see if anybody's bullying Chelle, and if they are, we're going to politely ask them to stop."

"Why do you need a witness for that?" she asked.

"Because the last thing Hordak and I need is for some rotten little shitass to claim we threatened them."

"Shrewd," Hordak commented, and Catra nodded at him.

"We heard you need heart surgery?" Adora asked across Catra. Hordak shrugged. "Is that why you're not wearing armor? Because you've been sick?" Catra looked at his shoulders and saw that, just like the day of the memorial, he wore no armor. Now that she was looking, Catra could see the sharp angles of his upper body standing out noticeably even beneath the cloak. He raised a hairless brow at Adora. "Right, right. That was intrusive," she said, holding up her hands. "I just hope you're okay is all."

"Regular maintenance is required to keep a failing body serviceable," he said simply, and did not elaborate.

After a while, Adora couldn't help but ask more questions. "So are you, like, good with walking? I mean, I'm just not sure… I don't know how your whole… deal… uh, works."

Hordak sighed, but Catra was curious too. "Yeah, the first time I tore out your crystal, you couldn't stay on your feet." A wave of chilliness from the woman at her side reminded her of Adora's disapproval of using Hordak's disability against him during the war. "But after the second time, a literal chunk of Fright Zone fell on you, and you still managed to come at Glimmer and I with a chunk of wreckage that must have weighed hundreds of pounds."

Hordak shrugged again, but answered more readily than she'd expected. "Any apparent weakness has more to do with pain management than muscle performance. Prime built us to be very strong, but pain levels vary from day to day," he looked over at them sideways. "And I'm sure you're both familiar with what Adrenaline can do for a person."

They exchanged a look and nodded before Adora replied, "So… the first time was a bad day? Or… the second time was adrenaline? Or…"

Melog mrped from beside her, but she didn't need their interjection to notice Hordak's countenance darken. She suddenly didn't feel curious anymore. "You could say that," he grumbled. "I wasn't feeling much by way of physical pain at the time."

Melog bumped Catra's hand with their nose and she tried to convey to them a firm message of 'f*uck off,'* but they didn't stop staring up at her. When Adora gave her a confused look, she sighed in resignation and said, "It was because of… because of Entrapta, right?" she asked, keeping her eyes on the ground as they passed the docks. "You found out what ha… what I did to her and went nuts?"

He nodded and Andora scrunched her face up. "Ah. Sorry. Shouldn't have brought it up." She swung her arms stiffly and sucked in a tense breath. "Just trying to... uh... friendly." She and Catra both cringed outwardly.

"That's Chelle up ahead, isn't it?" he asked as if she hadn't said anything.

It was. She was standing on the side of the road with her arms crossed, her little face puckered up and sour as they approached. Because the child was blue instead of pink like Adora, it was difficult for Catra to be sure, but the blotches around her eyes suggested she'd been crying.

“I’m sorry,” Chelle began as soon as they were close enough to hear her reedy voice over the sea breeze. She started walking toward them, chin tucked, eyes down and brow furrowed. “I didn’t mean for them to press the button. There’s not an emergency, I’m sorry.” She tightened her arms around herself so that both hands were behind her.

“That’s okay,” Catra said as the four of them drew into a loose circle. “Do you want to tell me what happened?”

“I did what they told me to!” she cried, unfolding her arms and stamping her foot in frustration. “Why do they have to be so mean?!” her eyes welled up and she clenched her little fists at her sides.

“They made you show them the pin and then they took it, right?” Catra sighed. Chelle nodded. “Well, it’s no war crime, but it’s a shitty thing to d- uh, crappy… a mean trick to pull.” Fuck she was bad at being child friendly. “All things considered, I think they should probably give it back though, don’t you?” she asked, looking up at Adora and Hordak.

Hordak remained impassive but Adora put on a stern expression. “Remember we’re here to check on things, not terrorize or bully children.” She put her hands on her hips and fixed them both with a glare. “Even if they are jerks.”

“Of course,” Hordak sighed at the same time Catra muttered, “*I know* , Adora.”

Adora looked back down at Chelle and the corner of her mouth quirked. “Although there’s nothing wrong with asking them nicely.” She smiled and stuck her hand out at Chelle. “Hi, I’m Adora, Catra’s girlfriend. She told me about hanging out with you and your family, it’s good to meet you.”

“Hi Adora,” Chelle said seriously as she shook the woman’s hand. “Are you in the Alliance too?” Adora nodded. “I didn’t mean to make the princesses think there was an emergency.”

“I wouldn’t worry about it,” Catra smiled, holding her hand toward Adora for their datapad. “No harm no foul.”

As Catra found the pin’s signal just a few hundred yards into the warehouses, Adora addressed Chelle again. “Why don’t you take Hordak with you and ask them to give the pin back? See if we can still make kindness count on this one?”

Chelle nodded and without further hesitation, reached out and grabbed hold of the edge of Hordak’s cloak. He looked down at where her small hand grasped the worn fabric, then back at Adora and Catra, who nodded in encouragement. “Very well,” he said, and Catra could hear the uncertainty beneath the aloof tone. At his affirmative nod in her direction, Chelle began to lead Hordak down the road.

Catra waited until they were out of Hordak’s hearing range before giggling madly, tail swishing in delight. “Oh, this is going to be good,” she muttered, kneeling to show Melog the datapad. “I’ll take Adora around the back, you make sure they don’t take a side alley if they hear Chelle coming.”

Melog meowed before trotting off on their orders. “Catra…” Adora began warningly.

“Oh, would you calm down?” Catra said before leading Adora off into a jog. “I just want to see their faces when they realize she’s got the old man in her corner. Then we can be responsible and make sure nobody’s running rackets around these damn water sources.”

Adora followed her down a lane that ran along the backs of two rows of warehouses while Catra kept checking the datapad. “Don’t you think you’re having a little too much fun with this?” she asked as they slowed around a corner. Up ahead of them, loitering on a pile of crates, was a scrappy looking little cluster of kids and teens not much younger than they.

"Or are you not having *enough* fun with this?" Catra whispered, ducking down. "Just kidding, be quiet while I record this for Glimmer, she's going to love it."

"Catra!" she hissed, but Catra waved her off with an impatient frown before creeping behind a barrel and raising the datapad.

"Go tell them you're from the alliance or something," she whispered, making sure the alley was in focus, "I think Chelle's bringing Hordak around the other end now."

Adora opened her mouth to argue, shut it, then rolled her eyes and stomped off toward the scraggly little gathering. They heard her coming almost immediately, and they either recognized her or picked up on her do-gooder attitude, because she didn't even have a chance to speak before they all scattered. "Wait," she called over the commotion as they broke into three different directions, "we just need the pin back!"

Nobody heard her, but their exits were already blocked. The ones that had flowed down the side passage were soon spilling back into the main alley, having run into a gigantic feline alien. The group that had pushed past her toward Catra got one look at her hysterical laughter and pointed datapad and turned around as well. Catra followed them as they pushed back past Adora again, just in time for Chelle to round the corner of the alley with Hordak in tow. The entire group skidded to a halt, several stumbling into one another, and Adora caught up with Catra and Melog to watch.

Hordak's eyes were satisfyingly piercing in the muted light between the towering, windowless walls of surrounding warehouses. Chelle, immediately sensing that she now had the upper hand, straightened her posture and let some of the worry leave her young face. The ex-warlord didn't crowd anyone, choosing instead to remain at the intersection of alleys behind Chelle. The assembly was effectively sandwiched and they knew it.

“I believe an item that belongs to me was taken from Chelle, the young woman standing here before you,” Hordak said in his most imperious, Horde Lorde voice. Adora turned fully around so that the kids couldn’t see her pressing her hands over her mouth, eyes screwed up against repressed laughter. “I request that you return it to the person I entrusted it to,” he drawled before finishing with a dramatic growl. “Immediately.”

“What did you idiots do?” one of the teens said, looking down at the younger kids around them. One of the little ones mumbled at the ground for a moment before the teen pinched the bridge of their nose. “Did she *tell* you she got it from Hordak?” More mumbling, and Adora turned back around to watch the unfolding drama. “And you took it anyway,” the teen finished, eyes narrowed in incredulous disbelief. The younger placed something into the older one’s waiting palm before scampering around to hide behind another. After one more menacing glare at their peers, the apparent leader among them stepped forward and approached Chelle slowly, eyes fixed on Hordak. When he realized their fear, he took another couple of steps away from Chelle, and the teen drew near the child.

Chelle held her hand out straight before her, palm-up, and received the pin with a wide smile. “Thank you!” she said brightly once the little gold pin was safely back in her fist.

“Can we go now? Or is there something else you wanted?” the teen asked Adora sullenly.

“Oh,” Adora said, “uh… um… be good?” she stammered. The teen rolled their eyes and led the little troop back down the side alley Melog had previously blocked.

“Aaaaand scene,” Catra said, clicking the datapad off and handing it back to Adora. “Well that was the most fun I’ve had in days.”

“Was that okay?” Adora asked Chelle, who nodded.

“Thank you,” she said again, looking around. Hordak nodded and opened his mouth, likely to excuse himself back to his basement, but Chelle continued before he could. “I’m supposed to ask you something else, though,” she said, looking up between Hordak and Catra. “Grandma said so.”

Hordak, Catra, Adora and Melog all exchanged looks. “Alright,” Catra said slowly. “Ask away.”

Chapter End Notes

If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you’ve got. It is very much appreciated.

"That's what the war did to me."

Chapter Summary

Catra and Hordak are asked to dinner.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Hordak had a hunch he knew where this was going, and felt his ears lower slightly as Catra said slowly, "Alright. Ask away."

"Grandma wants to have you over for dinner," she said, looking up at Hordak and Catra. "She wouldn't mind if the others came too," she insisted before she approached Melog and scratched their mane eagerly. Melog closed their eyes and tilted their head into her touch, and Catra did a double take. "Wait… how do you know Melog? Wait…" she shook her head lightly, "you know Melog?"

Chelle shrugged. "I didn't know their name, but we've hung out before, and I've seen you together so it wasn't weird that they came with you."

"Of course you've already met," Catra grumbled

Adora clapped her hands and turned to them. "If you've never had a home-cooked Etherian meal, you guys are in for a treat."

Catra looked interested, but Hordak was already shaking his head. "It is a very kind offer, but I do not think it would be wise."

"Why not?" Adora and Chelle asked in unison.

"I believe it would be highly inappropriate for me to show my face among the refugees I created," he answered easily. "I do not wish to disrespect my victims by darkening their collective doorstep."

“But Grandma wants you to come,” Chelle said, cocking her head. “How come it would be bad?” she asked, squinting up at Hordak.

Hordak opened his mouth to answer, but changed his mind and addressed the two women instead. “Do either of you know what protocol this situation calls for? I do not wish to tread upon social taboos.” They shrugged at each other before shaking their heads at him. “Is it common for Etherians to invite hated enemies to dinner? I do not understand…” he trailed off in confusion.

“I don’t know,” Adora said apologetically. “I’m She-Ra so I’m pretty sure the rules are different for me.”

“We already had Catra for tea,” Chelle interjected. “Please?”

“Why don’t we ask Mermista?” Adora suggested.

“Sound suggestion,” Hordak said, looking at Adora and Catra expectantly. They looked back. “Well?” he prompted.

“Oh!” Adora said, shaking herself. “Right, you want us to call her,” she said, fishing her communicator out of a pocket and beginning to tap at it.

“You guys get to talk to her whenever you want?” Chelle asked in confusion. “Really?”

“Only when it’s about Salineas or the Alliance,” Catra said. “She’s a very busy princess.” She turned to address Hordak. “Can’t you just use your cuff thing?”

“I can only message princesses, I cannot call anyone but you and Entrapta,” he answered. Come to think of it, it was a request made by certain princesses that had likely been forgotten by now. Perhaps he should have Entrapta enable the function.

Catra scowled at the cuff on his wrist but said nothing as Mermista’s voice sounded from Adora’s communicator. “‘Sup?”

“Is that her?” Chelle asked, looking around at them with big glassy eyes. Adora nodded with a smile.

“Hi Mermista,” Adora said. “Sorry to bug you, but Catra and Hordak and I had a quick question.”

“Shoot.”

“So, we’ve been invited to dinner. By one of your people. A refugee. In the refugee camp. Hordak thinks it’s a bad idea but we wanted your input.”

Princess Mermista remained silent for several long moments while the four of them waited quietly. “And you’ll be there?” she asked Adora.

“Yep.”

“Then I think you should do it,” Mermista continued, much to Hordak’s surprise. “I mean, so long as She-Ra’s there to supervise, then who am I to tell my people who they can and can’t host?” She heaved a sigh. “You’re here to serve them or whatever anyway. Seems to me like they’ve given you your orders, so go be polite,” she drawled.

“Um… okay,” Adora said brightly. “Mission received.” Catra stifled a groan, eyes shut, and he realized she was about as eager for this appointment as he was.

Hordak frowned as Mermista cut the feed and crossed his arms. “Fine,” he said, “but I absolutely insist that we, as Alliance members, provide materials for this… diplomatic endeavor.”

“What?” Chelle asked the other two.

“He says the groceries are on us,” Adora said, smiling down at her.

“You fucking dweeb,” Catra muttered quietly at Hordak. “I don’t believe you just called for permission to stay out for dinner.” He

shot her a scowl, though he wasn't sure what she was making fun of, but she laughed at her own humor anyway.

"Do you know what the ingredients are for cake?" Chelle asked, looking around.

"I know what goes into a pie," Adora offered weakly.

"I can ask my brother," Hordak supplied drily, producing a communicator to start tapping at. "He has taken an interest in the culinary arts as a kind of… your people call it a *hobby* ?" He raised a disdainful brow and didn't bother looking up at them.

"Wa… wait," Chelle muttered, and the other three looked down at her in confusion. She was looking at her feet when she heaved a massive sigh. "My mom wouldn't like it if she knew I was asking you to buy us things."

Catra glanced at Hordak in sudden concern, but he'd already had provisional funds thrust upon him by both Entrapta and Mermista. He gave her a small nod and waved a couple of fingers above his communicator in dismissal, and Catra's expression eased.

"Nah," she said, smirking and looking around at the others again. "The Princess of Dryl is Hordak's sugar momma, we're good."

Adora punched her arm while Hordak gave first them, then Chelle a confused look. She shrugged and offered, "It's something to do with having a girlfriend."

Their exchange made Adora and Catra break into a fit of giggles and Hordak tapped his food as they calmed themselves. "Yeah," Adora finally said, "a sugar momma is… an extra helpful girlfriend."

Chelle's face brightened in comprehension. "Oh! Is Adora your sugar momma?" she asked Catra.

"Pretty much," she said, grinning and shrugging before Adora punched her arm again.

“As far as funds are concerned,” Hordak interjected with an aggrieved sigh, “I think we shall deem this an exercise in public relations, which is call enough for such an expense.”

Chelle nodded vaguely as she turned her mind to happier subjects. “I know all the best places!” Hordak looked back down to Wrong Hordak’s prompt reply, but looked up again at a tug on his cloak. He’d meant to follow behind the others, but Chelle had grabbed the edge of his cloak again and was trying to tug him forward. “I remember flour and sugar,” she said happily as he began to follow in her wake, ignoring the snickering from the two women behind him, “and baking… baking… I never remember if it’s baking soda or the other baking thing.”

* * *

Chelle had led Hordak by the hem of his cloak until he’d assured her that they knew what her grandmother would need, then she’d allowed him to take his place behind them in favor of snatching up Catra’s hand instead. She angled her arm a bit stiffly, but she held Chelle’s hand back as they walked, and Adora soon slipped her fingers into Catra’s free hand. Thankfully, Chelle allowed Catra and him to linger at the outskirts of her field of vision while she and Adora did most of the scurrying and purchasing.

The circulation of published war stories, including positive testimony to the contributions of clones and ex-Horde members, had done much to soften Etherian’s bitterness and anger toward the villains of years past, even in Salineas proper. The widespread and deep-rooted venom they felt toward Hordak, however, was still virulent, if tampened in the months since Prime’s defeat. Regardless of what Mermista had said, he was deeply uncomfortable with appearing in the refugee camp. No small part of his reluctance was sheer cowardice, pure and simple, but he

was deeply perturbed by intruding upon a space in which he was as unwelcome as could be, regardless of the charity extended by Chelle's family.

Hordak couldn't spend too long stewing over how problematic the situation was, because he was soon distracted by a confused tangle of uncomfortable feelings that started as a nuisance, but grew into a physical weight in his chest. He was… he was feeling… what the hell was he feeling? Was he jealous? Why would he be jealous? He didn't even know what to be jealous over.

Hordak cocked his head as he studied Chelle and Adora flitting back and forth between shops and stalls, filling the large basket Adora had bought from a refugee basket weaver that Chelle insisted had been quite posh in her hometown. He had no desire to be out in the open with them or participate in the shared activity of shopping. Nor did he have any particular desire to imitate the process with Entrapta, Wrong Hordak, or anybody else. He tilted his head slowly the other way and narrowed his eyes, arms folded tight against himself. They just looked like they were having so much *fun* . Was that what it was? Again, he didn't think that was quite it. He didn't long to feel however they were feeling… but, he realized with a slow release of comprehension, he wished he knew what it was. That was it. He didn't necessarily envy their joy, he knew he didn't deserve it, but he did wish he'd gotten to know what it was like before he'd missed the chance.

The feather-light bright of fur against the tip of one of his ears made him jump and he looked around. Catra was perched on the railing above him, tail flicking absently near his head, and she was staring intently at their two companions in the market, brow furrowed and mouth slightly open. Melog sat passively on the landing beside her, staring at the street in a matching pose. A storm of emotions swirled over Catra's face, but she didn't seem to know which one to focus on either. He felt the oh-so-familiar sinking feeling in his stomach as he imagined what she must feel, watching the same scenes play out. She'd never gotten to live like that either, and just like him, she'd missed her chance. And yet,

Adora seemed to be able to meet Chelle on that mysterious plane. But then again, she'd earned it. So had her friends. Were Catra and he a detriment to their ability to enjoy such a privilege? Were they a drain on deserved joy? And he… he was so much more than in a similar situation. He was the cause of theirs.

He turned back to the street and continued watch Chelle and Adora, lost in thought. What must it be like for Catra to see the things he'd taken from her mere feet from where he stood, alive and more or less free? What could it possibly be like to contemplate a future that she would share with the man who'd so badly tainted hers? Who had done so many unforgivable things? At least Prime had the decency to be dead and gone.

He jumped again at the wet nose that nudged the side of his head, whirling around to see Melog sticking their head through the railing next to him. Catra snickered and Hordak grunted, "what?"

Melog uttered a long, wavering meow, staring through him with unnerving intensity. One of Hordak's ears twitched and he remained silent, staring back warily. Catra heaved a sigh and Hordak looked up at her for an explanation.

Instead, she said, "It's okay, big guy. We can still add to it. We can still be helpful." He pressed his lips together and nodded. "We'll keep finding ways to help," she assured him again quietly as he turned around.

"And how.. uh… have… how are you?" he minced out before he thought about it. He kept his back turned as he gritted his teeth and cringed hard.

"I'm alright. One day at a time, you know?" If he didn't know better, he'd think he'd heard a smile in her voice.

"Indeed," he muttered in reply.

"How has Entrapta been? Every time I see her she's going off about how excited she is to go back to space, but we haven't

really had a chance to sit and chat for a while."

"Impossibly brilliant, endlessly kind, and generally miraculous," he said, again without thinking enough beforehand. What was *happening* to him?

Despite the dramatic proclamation, Catra read him easily. "And?" she prompted. Melog nudged the side of his head again.

He huffed and scowled. "And betraying more fatigue than I've ever seen her… manage." He clenched his jaw and his fists where they were tucked beneath his arms.

Again, Catra's tone turned conciliatory. "We're figuring it out. The best and the brightest are on top of it, and Bow can pick up the slack no problem. He's taking to all the new tech and science and shit like he was born to it. Fuckin' nerd."

He nodded and a stretch of silence passed. At some point, Adora and Chelle ran over and forced a couple of pale dough-pouches they introduced as dumplings. Chelle crossed to Melog and handed them a morsel of their own as Adora advanced on them, holding a little paper cup.

"It's all about the sauce," Adora explained reverently, eyes shining. She held her little cup of pink goo low enough for Chelle to dunk her dumpling and take an ambitious bite. When she pulled away, he could see an amalgam of unidentifiable matter mixed with cooked vegetables contained within.

Catra and he exchanged a look of trepidation before she slowly extended her dumpling and imitated Chelle's maneuvers. When she began to chew her mouthful, her eyes widened and she flapped her free hand at Hordak to follow suit. "Puffer sometimes sells these down where the pirates hang out, and he says your brothers usually love that kind," Chelle explained eagerly once her mouth was clear.

Hordak did as he was expected, deeply uncomfortable beneath their scrutiny. The taste of the mysterious new food, however,

erased all trace of unease from his mind. The other three burst out laughing at his change of expression and Adora ended up thumping Catra on the back as she choked on dumpling.

When Adora and Chelle had disappeared on one final errand (better hair for her Mermista doll) Catra addressed him again, voice slightly hoarse from her ordeal with her dumpling. "Hordak?"

"Hmmm?" he answered, still savoring the aftertaste of their meal.

"I've really got to tell you…" she began, but stalled. He turned around to give her a questioning look and she sighed before continuing. "Do you remember Force Captain Octavia?" He nodded, thinking back through confused memories. "I'm pretty sure she's Chelle's long lost aunt."

Hordak opened his mouth, then closed it, then opened it. "What's an ant?"

"Oh yeah, that's her mother's sister." Hordak squinted and thought hard as Catra rolled her eyes and groaned. "Grandma lady like, *had* ," she waved her arms in front of her, "four juveniles." Hordak nodded. "One of said juveniles had Chelle." He nodded. "Another of said juveniles became Force Captain Octavia." He squinted for another second as he nodded, then felt his face fall as he began to grasp the implications. "Yeah," Catra continued, sighing. "But she's alive. At least, I've seen her since the war. Pretty sure. Back in that drainage village before we got in that fight." He heaved a sigh of his own and furrowed his brow at the railing below her, thinking hard. "I'm going to find her," she said in a softer voice. He looked back up to her and recognized a haunted look in her eyes. "I'm going to find her, and I'm going to find others."

He nodded slowly. "Queen Angella and King Micah are working on wartime separations. It wouldn't hurt to work from the other direction with Horde personnel files."

Catra nodded. "Exactly."

He lifted a corner of his mouth. "Let me know how I can help."

She nodded again. “Thanks.”

As Chelle and Adora reappeared down the street, he added, “You might approach Lance and George about starting a list of potential war orphans from the families’ side of things, if the King and Queen Mother haven’t already done so. We should be moving onto the Fright Zone soon, apparently Princess Mermista is thinking of proclaiming reconstruction officially achieved soon.”







“Noted,” Catra said as their other two fellows seemed to check through a mental list on their fingers. “Um… I just realized that we’re two ex-villains with a bad record, we’ve been lurking in the shadows, and we’ve been staring at a refugee child for like… a while now.”

He felt his eyes widen. “Stars above, you’re right,” Hordak said, straightening up and looking about their surroundings.

“Dude, could you look more sinister?” she asked, looking around them as well. “I mean, you take resting bitch face to a whole new level.” Hordak frowned and prepared to retreat down their side alley, but Catra stopped him with an outstretched hand. “Hang on, I think we’re good. Looks like they’re finally done.”

* * *

“Mom!” Chelle shouted as soon as they’d reached their worn old tent. “Do you know what a sugar momma is?” Catra burst out laughing again and Adora smacked a palm to her forehead, overflowing shopping basket carried between them. Hordak kept his head bowed beneath his raised hood, hands clasped before him meekly and positively roiling with shame and discomfort.

“She’s not home yet sweetheart,” a warm Etherian voice drifted from behind the curtain that served as a door.

“Grandma!” Chelle continued, completely unfazed as she ripped the curtain aside and barreled into the tent. “We need to find sugar mommas for Mom and Uncle Ray and Gill!”

“Can someone please tell me what a sugar mother is?” Hordak asked impatiently, and Catra laughed harder.

“What about me?” The older voice asked cheerfully. “Aren’t I invited to the party?”

“Oh we can find you a sugar momma too, Grandma,” Chelle responded. “Everybody can get one!” The older woman laughed heartily. “Grandmaaaa!” Chelle continued in a voice bursting with anticipation. “You told me to invite Catra and Hordak and I actually got them to come! And Catra’s girlfriend and Melog came too! Melog is that big cat that visits sometimes. Oh, and we brought groceries!”

“My goodness!” exclaimed the elder of the two, drawing nearer the entrance as the four visitors hovered awkwardly outside. The curtain was pulled aside, a small aquatic Etherian stepped forward, and beamed at the sight of Catra and Adora with their basket. “Girls! Welcome!” Then her eyes found Hordak’s sternum and began to slowly lift. She recoiled slightly when she finally met his gaze. “Ooh, aren’t you ominous?” she laughed nervously before beckoning them all in.

The woman’s manner soon eased as she grew accustomed to Hordak’s presence, undoubtedly helped along by Chelle’s eager acceptance. It didn’t make him feel better at all, but when she set them all to peeling and cutting vegetables over various bowls and makeshift cutting boards, he was at least able to focus on a task.

“So what can I call you, other than lady?” Catra asked the older woman at some point. Hordak finished with his potatoes and sat still and stiff, waiting to be addressed again.

“I don’t know. Everyone calls me Mom,” she answered, shrugging. “Except for Chelle, of course.”

Catra scowled. “Well I don’t call anyone mom.”

The woman shrugged again. “Suit yourself. You’ll just have to think of something, I guess. At this point my given name would sound weird. Remind me of bad times.” Catra scowled and even Adora pulled a face.

“When did people start calling you that?” Chelle asked, looking up at where the woman stood stirring a steaming pot on their tiny

stove.

The woman looked up and away, squinting. “You know, I’d had my babies before then, but I don’t think that started up until we lost our home the first time.” Hordak’s gut clenched. “We stuck pretty close with a couple of other families back then, and I helped take care of so many kids the moniker just sort of took.” She turned around. “Who wants to put the batter in the oven out back? I know it’s hot because Unda finally just finished her foul casserole.”

“I will,” Adora said brightly, jumping up to grab the small, battered square tins full of thick yellow batter.

“I’ll come!” Chelle added, following her out.

Once Adora was gone, Hordak couldn’t help but mutter some of his frustration under his breath at Catra. “We should not be doing this, *I* should not be doing this. I have *no* right to be here, this is-”

Catra cut him off. “Oh calm down,” she said, “we’re almost done. You can go back to your basement soon, I promise.” She raised her voice to address the woman at the stove as Adora and Chelle returned, cutting Hordak off from further complaining. “Is that Oceana’s old Mermista doll?” she asked, looking over at a worn doll of a baby Mermista laying on a neatly made bed.

“My mom gave hers to me,” Chelle said. “That’s Aunt Octavia’s. Grandma says she likes to keep it close.”

A harsh, cold feeling bloomed in Hordak’s abdomen and he cursed himself silently, looking at the doll nearby and lowering his ears in shame. All at once, his mind was flooded with stories he’d heard and read from refugees themselves, and the pain that was vicariously palpable in them was suddenly embodied right before him, in a woman who had shown him nothing but grace and hospitality. A woman who acted as if she hadn’t heard them

mention her lost child, or her abiding grief. He gulped and glanced at the entrance, avoiding Catra's and Melog's eyes.

"Catra told me some of the things she learned from you," Adora said uncertainly, looking between Catra and Hordak with a furrowed brow. "I'm sorry you had such a hard war. And I'm sorry you lost your daughter."

"Ooh, you are sweet," the woman said, finally turning glassy eyes on them. Hordak, coward that he was, immediately averted his gaze. "The refugee road is…" she trailed off and turned back to the stove to cover the pots that were on. Then she wiped off her hands and lowered herself heavily onto the little bed Hordak sat upon, directly next to him. He clenched his hands in his lap hard enough to dig his claws into his palms.

"What was it like, Grandma? What was it like for you back then?" Chelle delivered the question in an innocent tone, but all four visitors froze in discomfort and waited.

Awkward silence stretched among the group for a time as the stove crackled lightly. "Come here, Chelle," the woman finally said, patting her knee. The little girl hopped up off the bed where she'd been sitting next to Catra and crawled into her grandmother's lap, resting her head against the woman's shoulder and looking at her twisting fingers.

Several moments of silence passed, but Hordak got the impression that the woman wanted to reply. "One time I heard Hordak say, um," Adora said, giving Hordak an apologetic glance, "that refugees had to watch home die." It sounded so much more dramatic out loud than he'd imagined it, and he cringed inwardly a bit.

"Huh," Chelle's grandmother huffed, "I never thought of it like that, but that's a good way of putting it."

"It is," said a new voice from the entry.

Catra and Adora both jumped and turned, but Chelle exclaimed happily and ran up to the woman. “Mom! Look who I got to come over!”

The woman was looking, and she was staring directly at Hordak. Her face was passive, but a storm of emotion raged behind her eyes as she hugged her child back. He recognized fear and anger and grief, but he also saw curiosity and steely nerve there as well.

“I think you should get a sugar momma,” Chelle told her, suddenly remembering the brilliant solution. Hordak still wasn’t sure what they were talking about.

“You and me both,” the mother replied, and seemed to ease somewhat where she stood. “So tell me, Hordak, how did you go from causing that mess, to summing it up so nicely for us?”

He swallowed drily again before answering. “In… any circumstance where some lives matter more than others,” he began slowly, choosing his words carefully, “it creates the kind of situation that can easily give way to extraordinarily cruelty. I did not see you as people, and I taught my troops the same worldview.” He sighed. “What I did… was livestock management. I listen to testimonies… I need to know what I did because… I’m sorry.”

“Need to know what you did, huh?” the grandmother muttered, though not unkindly. She heaved a deep sigh and pursed her lips. After a few moments, she hoisted herself to her feet with a grunt and went back to stirring pots on the stove. “Oh, you know how it goes,” she finally began with a heavy sigh, as if she were complaining about a long day’s work. Then she chuckled wearily. “You always think it’ll never happen to *you* .”

“Becoming a refugee is one of those crazy things that happens to the unlucky ones living in bad areas, you know? Never you and your boring family,” the mother added. “No offense,” she muttered into the top of Chelle’s head. “But then the unthinkable happens,

and it comes out of nowhere and it happens so fast… and it throws you for a loop. Like the whole world and everything you ever trusted breaks apart under your feet. Nowhere to grab hold of to stay upright." Adora and Catra exchanged an odd look, but didn't say anything. Sickening hollowness grew in Hordak's torso as he listened to words that had become familiar by now. He knew what was coming, and he didn't want to hear it.

The grandmother spoke again. "But, a refugee also has to realize that if you're alive, then you're still one of the lucky ones." She lowered herself back to her seat next to Hordak and he wished more than anything that he could just disappear like Catra's damned cat. "And it doesn't make any sense, because better people than you didn't make it, and people with more to lose didn't make it, and some people that maybe shouldn't have made it do… none of it makes any sense at all, and it just goes to show that it's all arbitrary anyway." Hordak closed his eyes and felt blood well up in his palms under his claws. "There's no reason in any of it."

"It's hard to imagine trying to make that adjustment," Adora said softly, and Melog offered a mournful meow of agreement.

The grandmother shrugged and clasped her veined, wrinkled hands in her lap. "Oh, at first it's not so bad. I mean, sure, losing everything, having to leave your home and land and pets, losing track of your family and friends… and it hurts more than you think you can stand. But... at the end of the day if you still have people you love, it's enough to make some hope from." She smiled at Chelle with crinkling eyes. "You can bed down together at night and think about how lucky you are to be together, and how you're going to survive the next day." She opened her mouth to continue, but stalled.

"You said that was all… at first?" Catra offered.

The grandmother pursed her lips again and stared at the floor. "It's what happens after that that's really hard to live with."

“What do you mean?” Adora asked.

The grandmother shook her head slowly, mouth still puckered under wide, watery eyes. “Everything that used to help starts disappearing.” She made an odd, painful expression down at her own hands, like she were looking at something pitiful. “First, you make do with what you can, and it’s okay that it takes extra effort and heart, because doing the right thing is worth it.” Adora nodded, staring with wrapped attention. “But… being extraneous is… exhausting,” she reasoned reluctantly.

“And you just get so tired when there’s no end in sight,” the mother said, her voice thicker than before. She pursed her lips like the grandmother did and held Chelle a bit tighter. “When there’s not enough to go around, grandparents and cousins and neighbors start mattering *less…* less than your own kids, even other peoples’ kids, and it’s not right, but that’s just how it goes.” She sniffed and Chelle gave her a worried look.

“Doing the decent, civilized thing stops mattering so much when you’re fighting for your kids’ lives,” the grandmother said, and for the first time Hordak heard some bitterness finally enter her tone. “Everything stops mattering so much. Pretty soon the things you used to hold the most sacred are just another loss in a world that’s gone cold.” Her face twisted threateningly, and for one horrifying moment Hordak thought she might start to weep, but she blinked and squared her shoulders instead. “I don’t know how to explain that. I don’t know how to explain being so helpless and tired… what it was like to face your family every day without having a future to work toward.” She heaved a slow sigh. “It just… wears you down worse and worse, wears you down until you don’t rightly feel like a person anymore.” Hordak shut his eyes tighter as they prickled lightly. “And that does something to a soul. It changes you. And pretty soon after that, other folks stop seeing you as a person, too.” Hordak couldn’t bear to look at the woman, but he heard her throat constrict in her voice. “That’s what the war did to me. Ever since I lost Octavia, I’ve been missing a big part of me, too. I don’t feel quite like a whole person. Sometimes I feel like I’m already a ghost.”

“Mom,” Oceana said loudly. Hordak looked up to see that everyone else in the room had shining eyes as well. “You’re not a ghost. You’re everything to us.”

To Hordak’s great surprise, the older woman burst out laughing. “Oh, there I go, getting maudlin. I just get so sentimental about that time in our lives, but I wouldn’t trade what I’ve got with you crazy kids for anything.”

“And we’ll never forget our sister,” Oceana said gently, setting Chelle on the ground and patting at her backside to go comfort her grandmother. “She took a big part of all of us.”

* * * * *

Several hours later, Hordak and Catra made their way back toward the palace alone. Adora had been called away on princess business, and Catra had sent Melog with her. Hordak seemed even more thoughtful than usual, and Catra had to admit that the little cakes that Chelle’s grandmother had made were, in fact, life-changing. It was her first time having Adora’s so-called “home-cooked” food, and it was a whole new field of experience that she’d have to keep exploring.

They had made it about halfway through the warehouses before anything bad happened. Catra was starting to dread these creepy old buildings, and her misgivings were vindicated when a large bottle shattered against the back of Hordak’s head, shards of glass and splashes of ale flying in all directions. Hordak stopped in his tracks, sticky liquid running down the back of his neck, and muttered “ *rude* .”

Catra had already whirled around when Hordak caught the second projectile- another bottle- before it hit him in the face. A group of four was walking toward them from a side alley, and they looked like they were out for trouble. “Shit,” she muttered.

“We knew you’d be back,” one of the strangers shouted at Hordak, who grunted. “We knew your ego would have you out and about soon enough.”

Catra bent her knees and extended her claws fully. “You know these guys?”

“About as well as anybody else throwing scrap at me,” he replied. “I’m not wearing my armor,” he added quietly. “My neck port is exposed.”

“I know,” she said, “don’t worry about it.” Catra had no intention of letting either she or Hordak come to harm that night. But how much damage she’d do in the process of their escape, she didn’t yet know.

“And who’s your little friend?” one of them called.

“Don’t you recognize her? She was his second-in-command when they took Salineas. She was by his side the whole time our city burned.”

Catra felt her tail start to bush and the next person’s comment started her sweating. “Pretty little thing. Kind of sexy without the Horde uniform.”

The bottle in Hordak’s hand burst like a grenade, making both her and the strangers jump. “Easy big guy,” she said, though she was currently thanking her lucky stars to not be alone, “don’t stop thinking. They’re civilians. Remember they’re civilians.”

He growled long and low, which only made her tail bush out more. This wasn’t safe. Nothing about this was safe. “We know you’ve got bark and bite, Lord Hordak,” another stranger shouted. “But the war is over. There’s only so many people you can kill

before they finally put you down like they should have at the end of the war."

"We need to go. I'm going to kill one of these dumbasses if we're not careful," Catra said, starting to back away. Before they could go anywhere, however, a towering pile of crates began to teeter for no apparent reason. It was far too old to be unsteady as it rested, the wood of the boxes was bleached and dry and splintered. And yet the crates, which were stacked high above them all, swayed further nonetheless.

"Look out!" Someone shouted as the tower started to fall. Nobody was in the way, but the fall was dramatic, loud, and dusty enough to create total distraction.

Catra and Hordak were both so distracted, in fact, that they didn't realize they weren't alone until two pairs of hands grabbed them by their collars and yanked them backward, pulling them a few yards before darting sideways down another alley. She and Hordak were able to exchange a quick confused look as a mysterious green Etherian lead them into a darkened doorway and closed the door behind them. The window next to the door was dirty, but still somewhat clear, and the mystery man waved them to duck down while he peeked out the bottom of the window. He ducked down as well when they heard several sets of thudding footsteps as the aggressive strangers ran up to the door. They grabbed the handle and shook the entire frame violently, but the man they were with winked and put a finger over his smiling mouth.

Catra whirled around as she heard a fourth person make a sound in the abandoned building. Another mystery man was standing yards away near another door, smiling at them. The thing was, he was the same person as the man who'd grabbed them in the first place. She looked from one man, to his double, then back again.

"We're Chelle's uncles," the one nearest them whispered with a wink. "She's told us about you two. You're fine by us."

Catra and Hordak exchanged a bewildered look before the second uncle spoke up. “We’ll keep them distracted for a few minutes, you two make straight for the palace cellars, okay?” They nodded.

With that, the brother that was far away let himself out of the second door and slammed it behind himself before sprinting off. “They went out the back!” Someone called from feet away, and they heard the group of trouble-makers tear back down the alley to circle the warehouse.

“Thanks,” Catra breathed to the smiling Etherian next to them.

“Thanks for watching out for Chelle,” he answered. “Now go, and go fast.” He winked at them and gently opened the door. She saw Hordak nod at the man before he led their way back into the night, and she did the same before she followed Hordak into the darkness outside.

Chapter End Notes

> If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you’ve got. It is very much appreciated.

"...it's allowance day,"

Chapter Summary

> [It's another smut chapter- Catradora- starts pretty soon in and lasts the rest of the chapter.]
> Catra and Adora get a break and spend it with each other. Trouble still looms on the horizon.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra, Adora and Melog were eating breakfast with Mermista and Seahawk in the Salineas Palace's dining room, listening to Sea Hawk regaling Mermista with his recent adventures on the high seas. In his current version of things, he'd fought off fifty or so hostile pirates in the middle of a squall, several of whom had been clones. Adora watched with wide eyes and a full mouth, chewing hard and shoveling down food even faster than Catra.

"And there I was, surrounded by the regrouping crew… I thought for sure my time had finally come, and all that I could think of was you, my darling." He gestured grandly at Mermista, who rolled her eyes and raised her eyebrows. "I leapt up onto the ship's railing and declared for all to hear: 'I die gladly in the service of my princess, Her Majesty Mermista!" He leaned forward and narrowed his eyes, lowering his voice conspiratorial. "I was on the verge of leaping back into the fray to take whoever I could with me when *suddenly*, out of the throng of pirates came a friendly face- the pirate Scar had recognized me! 'Hold!' he said, 'For that is the legendary Sea Hawk, my friend and comrade in arms!"

"Uh huh," Mermista muttered through her mouthful of breakfast.

"He vouched for me and hence we were saved! Another close call for Sea-"

“Guys!” Glimmer shouted from Mermista’s side where she’d just appeared. The Princess of Salineas jumped and coughed out a piece of breakfast. Bow, who’d also appeared, thumped her on the back lightly. “Listen up,” Glimmer continued. She turned a data pad around in her hands and the table found themselves facing the Star Siblings on screen. “Tell them what you just told me,” she said.

Tall Star raised an eyebrow before speaking. “Sivtria’s been taking planets,” she said. Catra felt her throat tighten and sensed Adora tense beside her. Melog shifted uncomfortably in their chair. “Most of the ones she takes are empty, which is how she’s claiming she’s doing good. Starting to organize the mess Prime left behind, or something like that.”

“Does it look like she’s angling at something specific?” Adora asked.

Tall Star shrugged. “I can’t say for sure that it means anything, but she’s headed our way. She’s not moving very fast, she’s only taken about five worlds or so…” She glanced at her siblings. “And it doesn’t look like she’s hurting anybody other than clones.”

“But she’s still executing clones?” Bow said in an odd voice from behind the screen.

“The ones that are left, yeah. A fair few are being given the means to flee, though.” Bow nodded.

“We’ll send out another message saying they can come here,” Glimmer muttered to him.

“Anyway, we’ll be there in about six hours and we can plan a return visit then, okay?” Jewel Star asked.

The room nodded and Glimmer cut the feed. “Can your kingdoms handle more clones?” Mermista asked her.

Glimmer sighed. “Well, it certainly wouldn’t hurt if Salineas started accepting refugee Spacebats.”

Mermista bit her lip and glanced at Catra. "Hmmm, uh," she looked at Sea Hawk, who shrugged. "I need to talk with my advisors, see if they'd be safe here, but I think that Restoration and the testimonies might have eased things up a bit."

"That would be amazing," Bow said in a relieved breath and Mermista smiled at him.

"Before I forget," Glimmer said, handing the pad back to Bow, "it's allowance day." She tossed Adora and Catra each a bag of coins.

"Yes," Catra hissed, though she wasn't even sure why she was excited.

"I've got plans for today, hold on to that," Adora muttered from the side of her mouth. Something about her tone sent a small thrill through Catra's chest.

The door to the hall clicked open and to her surprise, Entrapta came bouncing through, closely followed by Hordak and Emily. "What brings the Basement Nerds up to a group meal?" Catra said, scooting hers and Melog's chair to make room for them.

"Mermista asked us to be here," Entrapta replied, still blinking sleep out of her eyes.

The princess in question was already up and headed their way, Sea Hawk on her heels. "Thanks guys, I have a bet to settle with Sea Hawk." She motioned the couple to follow her to the window, squinting at the stained glass.

"Darling it won't be fair if we're using colored light," Sea Hawk muttered.

"There. There's a clear spot," Mermista said, pushing Hordak into position and shifting Entrapta to match. Adora, Bow, Glimmer and Catra exchanged confused looks.

When Mermista was satisfied and Hordak and Entrapta stood blinking in the bright light, the princess and Sea Hawk drew

nearer their faces. Hordak's ears tilted back and he threw several nervous looks over at Entrapta. "Darling," Sea Hawk said softly, a smile clear in his voice.

"Fuck you Sea Hawk."

"Daaarling, I wiiin."

"Fine! You win! But I still say no." Mermista growled and stomped away from the other three.

"What are you guys talking about?" Glimmer asked.

Mermista scowled as she sat back down, fully pouting now. "Hordak's eyes aren't red red anymore, they're the color of Entrapta's eyes. So now I owe Sea Hawk a new boat or whatever," she rattled off, lip curled.

"Awwe," Bow said, clasping his hands and looking over his shoulder again. Entrapta had raised up no her hair and had Hordak's face between her hands in a firm grip, lifting one of his eyelids to get a good look at his eye. His blushing was visible across the room.

"So we've got six hours before we have to be in Bright Moon for the Star Siblings?" Adora asked Glimmer.

"Yep, you're free and clear."

"Melog," Adora said, turning to the alien cat. "I'm taking Catra out and we're going to need some privacy for this one. Melog winked and meowed before finishing their fish and vanishing. Probably off becoming an Etherian celebrity, or at least some kind of legend. Adora turned to Catra then and smirked. "I've got Darla for the day. Want to go for a ride, hot stuff?"

* * *

Adora made a pit stop near the market at Bright Moon, and as they made the short walk from Darla to wherever Adora was going, Catra wrapped up what she was trying to say about Hordak. “If it were just him that’d be one thing, but it’s the difference in how we’re treated that’s bugging me so much. And it’s just because She-Ra’s my girlfriend.”

“You’re so sensitive about stuff with him,” Adora said, bumping her shoulder. “It’s adorable.”

“No, it’s not," Catra shot back, irritably. "This morality bullshit I caught from you is wildly inconvenient and I’m pissed.” Adora snorted. “But at this point, just doing the right thing is easier than trying to avoid it.”

“And the right thing is?” Adora said, looking genuinely curious as well as amused.

“I’m going to keep looking out for him. We can keep helping each other, I guess. Whatever it takes to keep going.”

“I love you, Catra,” Adora said.

“Don’t be a sap,” Catra smiled, pushing her lightly. Adora giggled and stumbled a few steps.

They walked for a little while in silence, but before they reached the clearing she could see up ahead, Adora stopped in her tracks. When Catra turned around and raised an eyebrow, Adora cocked her head and suggested, predictably, “There’s more.”

Catra rolled her eyes and groaned. “It’s whatever.” She heaved a giant, dramatic sigh. “It’s just…” Adora waited while Catra rubbed the back of her neck and thought. “Sometimes when he talks about it… like, Prime…” Something finally clicked into place and Catra felt her face fall.

“Catra,” Adora ventured.

“Fuck,” she grunted, then rubbed at her eyes, suddenly feeling much older than she had moments earlier. “Fuck, Hordak. Of course Prime was his first love. He was all of their first and only loves, just like that evil bastard wanted it.” She looked up at Adora, who looked disgusted.

“That’s so fucked up.”

“That’s what it was…” Catra said, nodding at the ground, eyes wide. “Those are the words for it. That’s what he did to them.” She ran her fingers through her hair and heard Adora approach slowly before placing a gentle hand on her shoulder. “How does it keep getting worse, the more time passes? That shouldn’t… it’s not right.”

Adora wrapped her up in a tight hug. “I know. I think that’s why people are always mad about hindsight.” Catra chuckled. “I’m so lucky to have you.”

“What?” Catra said, pulling back enough to give Adora a baffled look. “I’m so lucky to have *you* . *I’m* a self-centered asshole.”

“No you’re not. Not anymore.” Adora cupped one of Catra’s cheeks in her hand and tilted her face toward hers. “You’re the strongest person I know and I love you so much.”

It was ridiculous, but tears welled in Catra’s eyes nonetheless. “I love you too, Adora.” She leaned her face back against Adora’s shoulder and for a while, they simply stood and held each other.

When Adora dug her fingers through Catra’s hair, she sighed and loosened her arms. “Are you ready to go do a little shopping?”

Catra nodded and smiled up at her before stealing one more kiss.

* * *

First, Adora had stocked up on snacks and beverages, which wasn't at all out of the ordinary and gave nothing away as far as her plans for the day. Then they bought fancy desserts, which was intriguing, but still insufficient for theorizing. It was very unusual for Adora to successfully keep a secret from her, and Catra's curiosity was starting to lean on the verge of irritation. Her attention focused back on the present, however, when Adora pulled her toward a tiny shack with fully curtained windows.

"Sometimes, when Glimmer and I had lady dates, we'd go to naughty shops for the fun of it," Adora explained, a mischievous smile twisting her lips as she leaned forward and grasped the door clasp. "We usually only ever giggled and gossiped, but… I mean…" She opened the door and held it for Catra. "A girl can dream."

Adora had brought her to a sex shop. Both of Catra's eyebrows shot up in surprise as she looked around at her girlfriend. "And when did you get so worldly?" she teased, sauntering toward a wall display of brightly colored and profoundly intimidating toys.

"Hello ladies!" chirped a shop attendant, who was too short to appear above the counter without the steps she now ascended. "Let me know if I can help with anything or answer any questions." She smiled warmly and went back to her puttering.

Now Adora was blushing, and it was just too fun to watch for Catra to admit that she was feeling shy, too. Instead, she donned a careful smirk, meandered her way around the shop and eventually came upon some merchandise that didn't make her question her grasp on anatomy. Adora was quick to follow her. They whispered and giggled like kids as they each made a selection. Catra opted for a subtle approach and, Adora, who may have considered Catra's choice as a challenge, took a bolder option.

“For fuck’s sake Adora, it’s not a contest,” she muttered at her while she finalized her decision.

“Who’s competing?” she asked innocently. “I just figured if we’re already trying something new, why not lean in?”

“What is it with you and maximum effort?” Catra griped, frowning at the back of Adora’s head as she made her way toward the attendant.

* * *

For a long time they didn’t talk, just hung off of one another as they carried their shopping back to Darla and started making their assent. Once they’d broken Etheria’s atmosphere and the Velvet Glove was well out of sight, Catra was sitting on Adora’s lap in the captain’s seat, purring lightly. She’d let Adora’s hair down from her ponytail and was combing her fingers through it lazily before she finally broke their comfortable silence. “So, you took me out to buy toys and desserts, and now we’re taking your sweet vintage ride up into space to use said toys amongst the stars?” she said softly, mouth hovering near Adora’s neck.

The blonde gulped. “What do you think?”

“I think you know how to show a girl a good time,” she purred, leaning forward to press open-mouthed kisses along her neck, nipping lightly at the tense cords there. Adora hummed in response and pulled Catra closer against her.

Kissing Adora was usually a supercharged experience, her energy and excellence a worthy match for Catra’s libido. Today their approach was gentler, more tender. “I love you,” Adora whispered as she ran her hands over Catra’s body.

One of Adora's hands was soon drawn to Catra's breasts, and she began to caress and cup and gently squeeze, teasing her nipples through her shirt with feather-light touches. "Love you too, Babe." When she opened her mouth to deepen the kiss, Adora's tongue slipped in and stole her breath. She was firm and demanding as she tasted everything her tongue could reach, Catra's own tongue moving around it while Adora claimed her mouth.

Their breathing had grown heavy by the time Adora lowered her other hand to grip Catra's ass, and the added pressure of Adora's thumb pressed into the flesh just above her tail made her gasp. Her sex was swollen and starting to throb, and she grew even hungrier for Adora's body. Both of them were slipping hands beneath the other's clothing, running strong fingers over softest skin and fur. When Adora pulled back, Catra took the opportunity to breath. "Take your clothes off," Adora said, and the hint of demand in her tone sent a thrill through Catra's stomach.

She considered challenging her, but Catra decided to get up off of Adora's lap, walk a few feet forward, then turn to stand and stare at the gorgeous woman before her. Catra knew she was hot, but performing a strip-tease was miles from her wheelhouse. Instead, she focused on keeping her movements fluid and very, very slow.

Catra hadn't worn a bra that or any other day in her life, so when she peeled her top up over her head and arms, her breasts were out on full display. Adora licked her lips and her breathing deepened as Catra took a slow breath and slid her hands down to her belt. She unclipped her boots one by one, and began to drag one down her body, folding in half while she did so. When Catra went to lower her pants, Adora undid her belt and pants as well, shifting them lower on her hips. Catra thought she was undressing to match, but then Adora slipped a hand down beneath the soft fabric of her underwear. Catra's breath hitched as she watched Adora's fingers start to move against her sex. She was slouching comfortably in the captain's chair, watching Catra with rapt attention and a slightly open mouth.

It surprised her when, as she began to slide her stretchy waistband down over her lower abdomen, Adora burst out, "Stop!" Catra looked at her in confusion, but Adora simply grimaced and began to speak to the empty air. "Darla?"

Catra's stomach lurched as she remembered the ship was just as present as Adora and herself. "Administrator detected," Darla's AI replied in a pleasant voice. "How may I be of service?"

"Do you think you could maybe… give us some privacy? Catra and I are on a date and-"

"Sexy Time Protocol initiated," Darla said before Adora could finish her sentence. "Goodbye." Nearly everything on the ship went dark.

"Eeeew that was definitely Entrapta," Catra complained, more out of habit than actual bother. Her focus was still fixed entirely upon Adora.

Adora called for Darla a few times just to see if she was awake or not, but when the ship made no reply, she turned a sultry gaze back on Catra. "Where were we?"

Catra was already halfway across the floor and pounced before Adora could get out another word, nothing left on but her leggings. Her mind and body were screaming, or singing, and when she landed on Adora in the captain's seat and pressed their bodies together, the physical heat between them was overwhelming. Adora sighed into her mouth and Catra let out a little moan.

Adora's fingers lifted and Catra saw by the glisten that they were the fingers she'd just had buried in her own folds. Their wet touch on Catra's chin sent a jolt through her entire body and she let Adora tilt her head up gently. Then they were kissing again, and it was by far the most important thing in the entire universe at that moment. Their kiss wiped every concern, hope and memory from

Catra's mind, leaving her in a hazy state of rapture, unconcerned with the world outside of their shared reality.

Catra would never understand how Adora could pack so much into a kiss. Their whole history, their soul-deep bond of friendship, their devotion, their burning passion for one another- it was all there in Adora's lips moving against her own. Catra could feel care in her kiss, she could feel the little thoughts and feelings that belonged only to her, and she could also feel promise. She could *taste* it- everything Adora wanted to do to her was in that kiss. And yet, the kiss was so gentle, so soft, that Catra soon found herself reeling.

Catra pulled away for a ragged breath and to try and collect her thoughts. "Where do you think you're going?" Adora muttered, digging her fingers into Catra's short hair and pulling her face back against her own. Fuck Catra wanted her.

"Bed," she gasped, dragging her mouth away from Adora's again.

Adora cocked an eyebrow and a slow, goofy grin spread across her face. She was so fucking beautiful. Catra nearly caved and went back to kissing her, but the mental image of Adora spread out and naked on twisted sheets was enough to get her up, groaning with the control it took to pause, and dragging Adora up after her by the hand.

Adora lunged, trying to pull Catra back into her embrace, but she was too slow. Catra dodged back behind the chair and snatched their bag up off the ground, prepared to pull Adora into a chase down the ship's main hallway. Instead, Catra was bowled over where she stood, taken completely by surprise as Adora leapt over the back of the captain's chair and onto Catra. They both fell to the ground, laughing hysterically, cupping each others' heads so they didn't knock against anything as they tussled.

After a few moments, Adora pinned Catra on her back and took her mouth in another breathtaking kiss. Catra did her best to keep her wits about her, but Adora's kisses tended to make her stupid.

Before she knew it, her hands were up above her head, wrists caught in one of Adora's hands, while the other roamed up and down her side. She waited for Adora to take a breath before breaking her grounding and rolling out of the way before she could right herself.

Catra was off down the main hall, tits out and giggling, while Adora was still staggering. She let Adora catch up to her next to the bedroom she'd used before, still laughing, a purr starting up at the back of her throat again. Adora caught Catra up around the arms and picked her up, swinging her back and fourth, squeezing tight and laughing with her. With Catra still in her arms, she kicked the bedroom door open and hauled her through it.

When she leaned her back against the door so it slammed shut behind them, she set Catra down again, catching her breath. The sound of their heavy breathing was loud now that Darla was so quiet, and the unique tone of Adora's panting was like music to her ears. She made to turn around in Adora's arms, but a hand on her hip held her still. So she leaned back against Adora, content to wait and see what she was trying to work out of her system.

"I meant it," Adora said in a breathy voice, "I'm lucky to have you."

"Idiot," Catra whispered through a chuckle. Adora pulled her tighter against her and her mouth was on Catra's neck before she had time to respond. Her lips parted and she purred through her open mouth, eyes closing, reveling in how soft and warm Adora's lips felt. She shifted so that one muscled arm was wrapped tightly around Catra's waist, and moved the other up to her chest, certain and demanding and fucking *thrilling*.

Catra started to grind back against Adora and felt her groan as much as heard it. The sound was so perfect that she rolled her hips again. This time when she moaned, Catra's name escaped on the breath.

“Say it again,” she whispered, turning her head so she could see whisps of Adora’s golden hair floating on her breath above her.

“I *need* you, Catra,” she said, a little louder, her voice gravely with their heated kiss and the intensity of her want.

Need. She said she needed her. Catra reached up and weaved her fingers through Adora's, pressed across her chest. She traded name for name as she dragged Adora’s hands squarely over her breasts, where they began to knead gently. “I… I need you too, Adora,” she let herself whisper.

Adora fondled her nipples between light fingers, drawing more uneven breathing from Catra’s lips. “I want to be with you, Catra,” she said, emphasis obvious. “I want to make you feel good. I want my name in your mouth when you come for me.”

“Where the fuck did you learn to talk like that?” Catra asked, thinking of Adora’s relative naivety.

She felt Adora’s smile against her mouth again. “You weren’t the only one thinking about all the things you never said,” she whispered, breath tickling the hair beneath Catra’s ear. There was a thickness in her voice then, and though Catra was deeply touched, she also felt a hint of concern. She made to turn around again but again, Adora held fast. “I love you. I… promise you won’t…”

Now Catra broke her hold and turned around, sweeping a lock of hair back from Adora’s forehead before cupping her cheek. “What’s up, Dummy?” she asked, as gently as she’d ever said anything.

To her enormous relief, a smile flickered across Adora’s pink lips and she shook her head. “I’m just being dramatic,” she said.

“Tell me,” Catra said.

Adora met her eyes and to Catra’s surprise, blushed. “Be mine? Only mine. I’ll be yours, we can be… just promise you’ll stay with

me," she said, and now her eyes went shiny. "Even though I'm changing," she said, her voice breaking on the last word.

Catra leaned up and pulled Adora into an earnest kiss, pressing her lips hard against hers. "I'm not going anywhere. Not so long as I have you."

"Promise?"

Catra kissed her again, pressing the length of herself against Adora's body. "I promise."

She hadn't noticed where Adora's hands had gone, and she gasped when she felt her fingers slide up her ribcage over her breasts. Adora took the opportunity to take her mouth again, sliding her tongue back in against Catra's. While they kissed, Adora turned her body and pushed gently so that her back was against a wall instead. Then Adora's hand was in her pants, and her groan was ragged and delicious. When the hell had she gotten so wet?

Adora's fingers weren't rushed or urgent, but they were firm and certain on Catra's core, guiding her pleasure with as much certainty as she might handle a weapon in training. Catra loosed Adora's hair and carded her fingers through it, fine and silky, so different from her own. When Adora brought her mouth to Catra's neck again, she barely maintained the focus necessary to grab the other's shirt and pull it off over her head.

Soon she was beyond even that much reciprocation, surprised at how close she was already. Adora gave no quarter, reading her body easily and chasing down her pleasure with steady focus. "Adora… Adora," she moaned, and Adora grunted into her neck, moving her hand a bit faster. Catra ran one of her hands up Adora's extended arm, feeling the muscles straining there in tandem with the sensation between her thighs.

Catra clung to Adora's shoulders as her hips began to buck reflexively, and Adora pressed against her even harder. Her purr

had stuttered out, replaced by whimpers and bitten back moans, her ears held low as she drowned in exquisite sensation. She moved her arms up to wrap around Adora's neck, feeling her sweat with effort, hoping she wouldn't let Catra fall as her legs began to quake beneath her.

"I got you," she whispered into Catra's neck, as if she'd read her mind. "It's okay, I got you."

Catra came into Adora's hand quietly, strangled whimper slipping through clenched teeth, her entire body shaking violently. Adora held her up, just like she'd said, supporting her entire weight as her legs trembled and gave out. She wasn't paying attention to how, but they both ended up on the floor, crumpled against the wall, clinging to each other and sweating lightly.

"Fuck… *fuck* ," Catra muttered, shaking some clarity back into her head.

"That was quick," Adora muttered, self satisfaction evident in her voice.

"Yeah well," Catra huffed, shrugging, "it's you."

Adora nuzzled her neck as Catra blushed. She didn't give Adora much time to cuddle, however. Catra had a score to even.

"Agh!" Adora blurted when Catra shoved her back sharply. She fell on her ass and sprawled out on the floor, looking extremely disgruntled before Catra climbed over her. Her face softened. "Oh," she muttered before they were kissing again.

Catra worked her way slowly down from Adora's lips to her neck, and Adora slid her hands under the back of Catra's leggings and gripped her ass. They helped each other out of the rest of their clothes and Catra luxuriated in Adora's naked body, drawn irresistibly down to kiss and nuzzle her creamy breasts. Adora hummed and sighed as Catra pulled her pink nipples between her lips, toying with them between her teeth and with her tongue, eliciting whatever noise she could.

Once she'd spent some quality time with Adora's breasts, she continued down Adora's body, pressing kisses in a line down her battle-scarred skin down to her fragrant sex. Catra reasoned that, since Adora had driven her through her first orgasm within a matter of minutes, it was only fair that she give her a taste of her own medicine. She dragged her tongue through Adora's slick folds a few times, savoring her taste, before she plunged two fingers inside of her, listening to her sharp gasp with satisfaction.

Catra began massaging the front of Adora's walls rhythmically while licking and flicking with her tongue, losing herself in the taste, scent, texture, and the feeling of having Adora's hands fisted in her short hair. Adora's moans grew more breathless quickly, and Catra was satisfied to feel tremors in her thighs before long. She pumped her fingers deeper and pressed Adora's lower abdomen with her free hand, moving her lips and tongue in utter rapture.

When Catra focused more attention on Adora's clit, her hips started to jerk and shake beneath Catra's mouth. She knew Adora's body well enough to keep her on the edge a bit longer than necessary, enjoying her frustrated whines and shuddering gasps. She tarried until Adora began to beg, then she pressed her lips flush against her dripping heat and suckd her clit, pressing her fingers up against the hand on Adora's abdomen.

Adora came spectacularly beneath Catra's eager mouth, trembling and whimpering and gripping Catra's hair in a shaky grip. When Catra had drawn the last aftershock through Adora's core and the other was a sweating, flushed, panting mess, Catra finally crawled back up her body. Her hair fanned out around her head like a golden halo, and her arms felt like home when Catra collapsed at her side, tucking into her body like Adora was her only shelter.

They took some time while their breathing slowed, simply holding each other, fingers and thumbs stroking skin lightly. Eventually, an undignified snort erupted from Adora and Catra laughed at the sound itself. "What?" she asked, looking over at Adora's smiling face.

“We didn’t even get to those stupid toys,” she snickered, gripping Catra to her side more tightly for a moment.

Catra started purring again, tucking her head back against Adora’s shoulder. “The night is young, Babe. And so are we.”

Chapter End Notes

> If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you’ve got. It is very much appreciated.

"Not everyone wants to be the best versions of themselves."

Chapter Summary

> The Alliance makes plans, then receives troubling news from the Fright Zone

Hordak felt the gentle hands on the sides of his face holding him upright as his vision cleared slowly. So much light. Too much light. This wasn't right… he wasn't in Bright Moon or Salineas… this was Prime's architecture. He blinked tears out of his eyes and Prime's face swam into view. Hordak's whole body began to shake, knees trembling against the cold, hard floor. How? How could he be back? "No, dear brother," he said, offering a sympathetic look, "I have not returned, little brother. I was never gone."

His trembling doubled and Hordak fought the urge to pull away from Prime's touch. The larger man let go of him and stood, holding his hand out. Immediately, one of his brothers handed him a crisp white cloth. "You reek of fear, brother," he said, wiping off his hands. "And I mean that literally. You're throwing off the stench of terror in waves, it's… really rather disgusting." He frowned over at the silent attendant. "The rest of you don't do that, do you?" he asked. The clone shrugged.

Prime looked back at Hordak and took note of his trembling. After an irritated glance at the cloth in his hands and a sigh of impatience, he sank to his knees and gathered Hordak in his arms, pulling him forward and holding him against his chest. "My poor, deluded brother," he said softly, gently rocking Hordak, who began to sob in sheer exhaustion. "These memories of your false god, your Entrapta. They cause you such pain."

With another, gentler sigh, Prime continued, "Her friends abandoned her because of you. You were all she had *she trusted you* ." He sounded appalled, as if he felt sorry for her. "And you let

her die, frightened and undoubtedly in pain… all alone and wondering where *you* were."

Hordak's throat burned and he cried harder, still shaking badly in Prime's embrace. The larger man let silence stretch for a time, one hand cupping the back of Hordak's head, holding his face against his shoulder, still rocking him slightly. "Profess your loyalty all you like, but I have seen your heart. I see all. I know all." He slid the hand on the back of his head down to the back of his neck, but his hold remained gentle. "Even now, lost in confusion and grief, you do not want me to take your memories of her. They are all that is left."

"Please," Hordak managed to choke.

"You still don't understand." He made a soft, sympathetic noise. "She was never yours. I own your memories, just like I own your body, everything you are… just as I own her. She belongs to me, brother. She belonged to me before she ever found you." He finally stopped rocking him. "Must I demonstrate the order of things again?"

Before Hordak could start begging, he felt a sharpened claw punch hard through the membrane of his neck port. He wasn't ready for it, it was an aggressive movement and it hurt . The claw pulled downward, opening the hole it had just created, and Hordak felt a trickle of blood roll down his neck along Prime's grasp. " *Please* , I…" he gasped, "I'm so sorry, brother."

"Not sorry enough, poor thing," Prime crooned softly into the top of his head, pushing the claw further into Hordak's port against his whimper of protest. "Not sorry enough." The claw pushed even further, too far, it would do damage… but then it finally withdrew. After another moment's pause, Prime returned to stroking Hordak's hair. Unexpectedly, Hordak felt the brush of Prime's lips as his elder brother kissed the top of his head lightly. "I'm going to hurt her. I'm going to use your hands to do it. And you get to watch it all."

His eyes flew open and he sucked in a ragged gasp. The first thing he became aware of was that he was drenched with a cold sweat. The second thing he became aware of was Entrapta's face above him, her hair wrapped loosely around his forearms to keep him from lashing out at her as pain stabbed through the center of his chest. He grunted at the intense, fragile feeling radiating through his ribcage and stopped struggling. A small whine escaped his clench teeth, unable to clutch at the source of the pain.

"Hordak? Are you back?" Entrapta looked anguished, there were tears in her eyes. He was panting, hearts pounding irregularly as they pumped adrenaline through his system, but he managed to nod and she relaxed visibly. "Shshsh, it's okay. It's okay," she whispered as his breathing grew shallow and sharp. He knew full well he was starting to hyperventilate, but he couldn't calm down.

"I don't- I don't know…" he gasped, no sentence in mind to finish.

"Breathe, Love. Breath with me." The pet name struck a chord and he focused on Entrapta's face above him, breathing loudly and slowly for him to mimic. "It's okay."

Hordak struggled for longer than he should have, but eventually he managed to match his breathing with Entrapta's and felt his hearts start to slow, one after the other. She moved back to make room as he hoisted himself up, but when he reached for her she went to him eagerly. He wrapped himself around her and clung to her for comfort, regardless of their absurd size difference, and she cradled his head and stroked over an ear. "This was a bad one," she said softly. He nodded. "What happened?" This time she didn't ask him if he wanted to talk about it.

It took a few tries before he could speak, but she was patient. "It shouldn't be as hard as it is, they don't even make sense…" he choked.

“The nightmares?” He nodded. “What… happens to you? Do you have to relive it?”

He shook his head and sniffed. “Yes… no… not really, but…” He grunted in frustration and tried again. “Nothing ever happens the same way and the timing is never right. I can’t even remember exactly how it happened.” He took a few jerking breaths. “Sometimes it’s truly ludicrous… last night Swift Wind was there, but… it still *feels* the same. It always feels the same.” He clenched his teeth, struggling to think beneath the intensity of feeling.

Her face was screwed up with crying, but she kept comforting him gently. “It’s okay, I’ve got you.”

He dissolved into tears again and held her tighter, fighting off some of his more vivid recollections. “The things he said he’d do to you…”

“It’s okay,” she repeated, “it’s okay.”

She let him hold her and kept stroking his head the entire time it took for him to calm, making soothing noises all the while.

Their measured breathing was the only sound for a time, but then Entrapta spoke again, her voice soft and low. “I know it’s not the same, but sometimes I have dreams where I wake up in the past, back on... during bad times.”

“I’m so sorry,” he whispered.

“No, no that’s not what I meant to… I just…” He lifted his eyes to her glance and waited patiently. “I mean, I know that nothing about this feels normal, but…” she made an apologetic face, “I think maybe it is normal. I still dream about being back in a dark place, I know the others do too. It’s okay.”

He tilted his face to kiss her slowly. “I’m so, so sorry.”

“I know,” she said, “but I don’t want you to be. I want you to be here with me, now, not back then. I’m not sorry for everything

that happened, even if it did beat us up a little." She wrapped herself back around him, nose in his hair.

"Star of my life," he muttered into her tight embrace, "I love you more than I can express."

"I know," she whispered back, fondling the tip of one of his ears between her fingers gently. "I love you too."

"After everything?"

She rubbed her nose in his hair. "Always."

* * * * *

Adora was nearly late to the Alliance meeting with the Star siblings. They'd meant to return on time, but figuring out how to get Darla out of "Sexy Time Protocol" proved more difficult than they'd expected. Catra, on the other hand, was significantly late to the meeting. This was because, as Adora was bringing Darla down for a landing, Catra was staring out the front window at a group of civilians walking toward the military camp. Not that the civilians themselves were anything to take note of, but something about them caught her eye. It took another few moments to figure out what it was, but as soon as she finally realized she was looking at the top of Octavia's head, she started shouting.

"Adora! Adora it's Octavia! You have to let me out, I've got to get to her!"

“Let me land first,” Adora said, speeding up Darla’s decent by a fraction.

“Can’t wait, open the back and let me out!"

“What- no! You won't be able to catch up to her if you break your neck."

"Adoraaaa," Catra yelled, dancing back and forth with her palms against the window, watching the little group disappear past the tree line.

"Catra,” she muttered, looking around at her with her eyes wide and brows furrowed.

“Now Adora! Do it!”

“Fine,” she said. “Darla, you know what to do.”

“Opening cargo hatch,” Darla replied in her ever-placid tone.

Catra tore off toward the back of the ship and was relieved to see the Whispering Woods rushing toward them from below. She leapt into thin air as soon as Darla dipped below the tree line, regretted it as she fell for much longer than she’d anticipated, and hit the ground hard. She rolled out of it, cursing herself, and was sprinting on all-fours before Darla’s landing gear touched grass.

“I’ll find you at the meeting,” she shouted without turning around, not knowing or caring if Adora had heard her.

She kept running in the same direction she’d seen the little group moving in, and expected to see them through the trees as soon as the light dimmed beneath ancient trees. As the seconds slid by while she ran, however, confusion and frustration replaced her expectations. Where the fuck had they gone?

In pure confusion and mounting agitation, Catra ran in circles for longer than she should have, looking for any sign of the group everywhere in the vicinity. When she finally had to admit defeat,

she let out a lengthy roar, on the verge of tears. Her disappointment was overwhelming and infuriating.

And none of it made sense. This was the second time she'd seen Octavia before she'd seemingly disappeared. What in the hell was that one-eyed psycho even up to?

By the time Catra finally trumped into the war room twenty minutes later, defeated and at her wits end, the meeting was already wrapping up.

"Did you…?" Adora immediately asked as Catra noted who all was in the room.

Catra shook her head, scowling bitterly. Glimmer was the only one standing, leaning forward and staring at what looked like maps and lists. She was flanked by Bow and Adora on one side, and her parents on the other. While Catra moved to take the empty seat between Adora and Entrapta, she took note of Hordak, all three Star siblings, Castaspella, Juliet, Mermista, Scorpia, Perfuma, Frosta and Double Trouble.

"Find who?" Bow asked, but Catra rolled her eyes and shook her head again, trying to signal that it wasn't important enough to stall the meeting.

"Okay," Glimmer said, addressing the room at large. Everybody's got their orders? Can you all be ready by tomorrow morning?" The room of people nodded vaguely. "Right." Glimmer heaved a huge sigh. "You're all dismissed. Catra, you stay so we can catch you up." Everyone else moved to rise and leave. "Entrapta, Hordak, you two stay as well. The Star siblings and Bow have boring science nonsense to discuss."

The rest of the room was eager to leave before the technical talk started, and the door soon closed on their downsized group. "So what's the poop?" Catra asked, trying to refix her attention to focus on the present.

Glimmer heaved a huge sigh and launched into a hurried recap. "So we figure we need to spread magic around as quick as possible so we can hopefully get it established elsewhere in the Universe before Sivtria gets too far. The more isolated magic is, the easier it will be to target. *But*, any magic anywhere is going to be super vulnerable as a high-price target which means we need to help protect the magic we export." Catra nodded as she took a breath.

"Which we can definitely do," Bow added, but protecting Etheria still needs to be our priority."

"Do we even know how to transplant magic?" Catra asked, and was perturbed by the momentary silence that met her question.

"That's what *I* said," Adora muttered.

Entrapta piped up. "I've been working on it with the magicians!" she enthused.

"Of course you have," Catra replied, wondering if Entrapta was getting the rest she needed.

"We've been learning *tons* ," Entrapta continued, "and even though it'll probably still take some failed experiments, we should be able to commence trials as soon as we can get there." Hordak remained stone-faced as she talked, arms crossed over his un-armored chest.

"Yeah, but how long is it going to take to do all that?" Adora asked, frustration clear in her tone. "How are we supposed to get ahead of Sivtria if She-Ra can't heal planets like she healed Etheria?"

Hordak finally spoke, looking as dour as ever. "I will remind you all," he began, and Catra recognized his 'why do I have to keep explaining the obvious' voice, "that showing up in an unfamiliar place, changing every aspect of life for the residents there, then simply *leaving* , is likely to create more chaos than benefit." Adora crossed her arms to mirror his posture. "A sense of agency is vital

to both interplanetary relations and localized social stability. Both sides of this issue would be better off if Etheria delivered material relief and protection, but fostered independence amongst our allies. They will be better prepared to wield their magic if they cultivate it themselves."

"But the longer we take, the more time Sivtria and other jerks like her have to do awful things," Adora interjected.

"And what do you think?" Catra asked the Star siblings.

Tallstar shrugged. "We don't know anything about magic. We're happy to have the help we can get and we'd rather take your lead than shots in the dark."

"Well," Bow began, throwing an apologetic look over at Adora, "the rest of us think that Hordak's approach is the safer one to take before we're better prepared to fight." Adora scrunched her nose back at him. Catra wasn't dumb enough to say so, but she agreed with the others too.

"One thing we all agree on," Jewelstar broke in, "is that all of this should be as secret as possible."

Catra nodded along with the others as Adora took a deep breath, preparing to speak. "So, here's what we were thinking: I stay here to protect Etheria while several of our heavy hitters are gone." Catra nodded again. "Glimmer and Micah go for magic stuff, Bow and Entrapta go for tech stuff, Perfuma and Frosta come as back up and to see if they can contribute to the whole transplant thing. Wrong Hordak goes to do clone stuff and bring back any who want to come, and the rest of everyone stays here on guard. Well," Adora looked over at Mermista. "Mermista's declaring reconstruction officially over and throwing a party with her people, so she might not be super on guard, but that's fine."

Mermista shrugged. "I'll be here if you need me. Worst comes to worst, I'm sure Sea Hawk can keep the party going without me." She frowned as a thought struck her. "Although that definitely

makes arson more likely.” Then she shook her head again. “It’s whatever, we’ll figure it out.”

Conversation paused then, and Catra looked around to see if there was more. “Sounds good to me,” she affirmed after a few more moments of silence.

“Can we talk about the secret part now?” Entrapta asked in a stage whisper, fists clenched in excitement and eyes sparkling.

“Secret?” Catra asked, intrigued.

Glimmer jumped in. “Yeah. So that whole plan is also kind of a cover.” Catra nodded approvingly. Officially, we’ll deliver the aid and stuff, but the magic we bring won’t take.” Catra cocked her head in confusion.

“On purpose,” Bow added.

They all froze and conversation stopped short as the door to the war room clicked and slowly opened. Then the high ranking Brightmoon soldier Juliet, Castaspella and another Entrapta slipped in and shut the door behind them. An unusually menacing growl sounded from Hordak's corner and the other Entrapta blanched.

"Oops, sorry about that, Hordak," Double Trouble said as they turned back into themselves and gave a nervous laugh.

"Perfect timing," Bow smiled at the three alliance members by the door.

Glimmer nodded. “Anyway, Entrapta’s not actually going to be Entrapta.”

“We’re going to hide the real magic,” Tallstar said. “We found ancient chambers deep below the old capital. That’s where it’ll start.”

“Double Trouble will pose as Entrapta with Glimmer and the others,” Adora said. Catra caught Hordak’s ear flick as Double Trouble took a preliminary bow. “If you’re okay with it, Melog will come too, and they’ll take the real Entrapta, Aunt Casta, and Juliet down to the caverns.”

“Okaaay,” Catra said, eyes narrowed.

“I’ll set up a shield to try and keep people from picking up traces of what they’re up to down there,” Entrapa said, loud and excited. Catra nodded.

“Aunt Casta will work on rooting the magic down there where it’ll be harder to attack,” Glimmer added, making eye contact with the sorcerer, who smiled and nodded.

“And Juliet will protect the process while the Star siblings keep attention off the whole thing,” Bow finished. Juliet didn't react, but Catra caught a subtle flush on Castaspella's neck and ears.

“And if that doesn’t work, we’ll try again!” Entrapta said, “and again, and a-”

“Hopefully it’ll work the first time,” Starla said hurriedly, petting their pet bird.

“Either way, it’s probably best we figure out how to do this without She-Ra, just in case," Adora said in a tired voice.

Catra caught the Star sibling’s confused looks and covered. “Just until we get things all sorted out here at home,” she said, reaching over to squeeze Adora’s hand.

Conversation lulled again and they all looked around at each other. “Is that it? Did we cover everything?” Adora asked, looking at Bow, who nodded.”

Hordak stood without further ado, towering over the rest of them and frowning, as always. “Thank you for respecting my advice,” he

said before giving one of his stiff little bows. Then he turned and swept from the room.

Entrapta rose up on her hair and said, by way of explanation, "we have to go explain to Wrong Hordak what's going to happen with Hordak's heart surgery, and he's *definitely* going to freak out." She grinned at them and then scampered off after Hordak.

The door shut behind them and the rest stood to leave as well. First were Juliet, Castaspella, and Double Trouble. Another few seconds of silence hung between them before Catra reached the door next, but Starla spoke up. "*That* was the clone she was trying to find?" She asked with a raised eyebrow, obviously referring to Hordak. Catra snorted hard.

"Is he always that grumpy?" Jewelstar asked, giving his sisters a confused expression.

Catra, Adora, Bow and Glimmer all looked at each other incredulously. Then Catra started laughing, and the other three joined in. They laughed and laughed, harder than was necessary, and Catra ended up leaning on Adora for support, who clung to her while she wiped tears of mirth from her eyes.

"Yeah. Yeah he's always been…" Catra kept laughing as she opened the door and held it for Adora, no clue how to wrap their past with Hordak up in a sentence.

"Difficult," Bow supplied, and Catra laughed harder.

The Star siblings stared at them with raised eyebrows, unamused with their vague answer.

She and Adora split off from the others to make for the training room, and Catra saw Double Trouble walking alone up ahead. She called out for them to wait up, and they did so, lounging against a wall and examining their nails idly. "You called, Kitten?" they asked when they drew near.

"This is what you were up to after the memorial, wasn't it?" Catra asked, lifting a corner of her mouth. "You were learning to play all of us, weren't you?"

"Clever clever," Double Trouble replied, giving her a faint little round of applause.

Catra tilted her head. "But why? Did Glimmer put you up to it?" Adora remained silent as she looked back and forth between them.

Double Trouble heaved a giant sigh and shrugged. "Look," they began, with none of their usual pomp. "My powers have always just... creeped people out or put them off. For a long time, I had to hide them if I wanted to stay wanted. Even out in the Crimson Waste." Adora shifted on her feet and Double Trouble looked away for a few moments before meeting her eyes again. "When I used my abilities to get work, my magic actually felt like powers instead of affliction, and at the end of the war..." They rolled their eyes, and seemed more uncomfortable than Catra had ever seen them. "I mean, circumstances are obviously a bit different when the world is ending, but when the sides stopped mattering, I got to use my powers to help save the universe." They crossed their arms and gave a tight shrug. "I used them to help save people, and it felt really good, and it felt good again when I posed as you when we first went to Salineas." Catra and Adora both nodded. After another brief pause, Double Trouble heaved a dramatic sigh and relaxed their shoulders somewhat, raising an eyebrow in a familiarly aloof expression. "My job was to help with reconstruction, but it seemed to me like my special skills are best used when I get to strengthen the team." They looked down at their nails again and smirked in an evocative nonverbal '*you're welcome*'.

"We're lucky to count you as one of us," Adora said in a strong, confident tone.

Catra thought she caught a flash of pleasant surprise in Double Trouble's eyes before their smirk twisted wider. "I still want to be

paid, of course. I do not work for free, even if I do like you."

"Awe, Catra!" Adora began, grinning. Catra took a step back, but not quickly enough. Adora caught her and Double Trouble up in each arm and squished them in a Scorpia-worthy hug. "They *like* us!"

Catra and Double Trouble both groaned and squirmed their way out of her grip.

* * * * *

“This will be the first time they go on a mission together without me,” Adora said miserably as Catra fastened her boots to her belt.

“It’s just one mission, and it’s only for a few days,” Catra reasoned.

“I feel so useless.”

“What do you mean? You’re still perfectly capable of literally slicing through spaceships,” Catra said, scratching at her scalp and ruffling up her short hair.

“Everyone keeps saying that fighting will just make things worse, but fighting is the only thing I’m good for anymore.”

“That’s not true,” Catra said, heaving a sigh. “It’s just a weird time right now. We’ll be able to do more soon.”

Adora gulped thickly and Catra looked over to see her staring at her folded hands in her lap. Catra grabbed her hands, crouched

down in front of her, and waited for Adora to meet her eyes. “We were supposed to stick together. We’re the Best Friend Squad,” she muttered down at her hands.

Catra heaved another sigh, remembering how much it could hurt to be left behind, even temporarily. “This is just for now,” she said, lifting a finger to tilt Adora’s chin up. “I promise they won’t decide they like adventures better without you.”

A flash of relief crossed Adora’s face and Catra was glad she’d guessed right. Adora wasn’t meant to be part of the support crew, she was a fighter. She just didn’t want to miss out.

Before Catra could reassure her any further, Glimmer appeared in their bedroom. “Well, everybody’s ready to go, but Swift Wind and Wrong Hordak are... a little upset. Adora, you might have to go handle your horse.”

Adora cocked her head in confusion. “I get that Wrong Hordak is still wrapping his head around things like illness and surgery, but what’s got Swift Wind worked up?”

Glimmer heaved an exasperated sigh. “He says the *last* time a best friend went to space, you were gone forever and it was a really bad time.”

Adora rolled her eyes and Catra sniggered. “This should be good,” she muttered through her smile.

Adora rolled her eyes, but before she could answer, Glimmer’s communicator started going off. She pulled it out, opened the display, and happily cried, “Bow!... wait, is something wrong?” Glimmer said, sliding quickly from exuberance to trepidation.

Catra and Adora immediately stood and went to stand with Glimmer, looking down at Bow’s face. His brows were furrowed and he was frowning. “I’m not sure, but I want a second opinion on what we should do. Can I borrow you guys for a minute? In the throne room.”

Without replying or hanging up, Glimmer handed Catra the datapad. “I wonder wh…” Adora began, but, Glimmer had grabbed them both and teleported before she could finish.

“What’s up?” Glimmer asked as they landed, Catra stumbling slightly, still unused to the jarring process.

“Wait, *she’s* still alive?”

Catra looked up and felt her ears fold back as she made eye contact with Other Kyle and the lizard lady with the great biceps on four arms. “Good to see you too,” she muttered as she straightened, frowning at them.

“They’ve just arrived here from the Fright Zone, looking for asylum,” Bow explained. “They’re the first news we’ve gotten from inside the compound since Prime fell. Apparently some guy from the Crimson Waste came in and took it over as soon as he realized the clones weren’t fighting back anymore.”

Catra groaned. “Let me guess. The asshole with the whip and the dumb name? What was it?”

“No,” Other Kyle interrupted. “He wasn’t even part of the first group that took over. Lashor didn’t show up until yesterday, but-”

“Tongue Lashor,” Catra rolled her eyes. “Can you guys believe...” She looked around at Adora and Bow, but the other two were still focused on the women they were talking to. Catra turned her full attention toward them and for the first time noticed that they both looked the worse for wear. She eyed their shabbiness and hunted looks. Both were already permanent characteristics of theirs when she’d first met them as wandering outlaws in the Crimson Waste, but something had changed. “Why are you here? Why did you leave the Fright Zone?”

“Tongue Lashor helped us escape last night when we caught him smuggling-” Other Kyle fell silent when her reptilian companion elbowed her in the ribs again.

“That’s why I called you,” Bow interjected. “They say that there are people there who need help, and they need it sooner rather than later." Catra looked back at the two bandits and folded her arms, frowning.

Bow was just beginning to speak again when the two women’s eyes went wide and they pressed against each other, clearly horrified. The other four looked around the throne room in time to see Hordak break off conversation with Wrong Hordak, looking distinctly harassed, so he could pluck Imp out of the air. The little demon struggled momentarily, but Imp eventually handed a deeply annoyed Castaspella her golden circlet. Hordak released him and went back to lecturing Wrong Hordak on how to properly look out for Entrapta. “Is that… Hordak?” Other Kyle asked quietly.

“He’s with us, now,” Adora said dismissively. “Tell us about the Fright Zone. What’s happening there?”

But the two women before them had turned towards each other and seemed to be having an unintelligible discussion, just staring at each others’ wide eyes and exchanging tiny gestures and the beginnings of words.

“Hey,” Catra snapped at them to draw their attention back. “What’s happening in the Fright Zone?”

But she already knew they’d missed their chance. Other Kyle glanced over at her companion to exchange one more grim shake of their heads before turning wary eyes back to Catra. “Sorry,” she said, “we shouldn’t have come here. We’ll go now, if you’ll let us.”

“What?” Glimmer asked, disoriented and annoyed. “No, you’re not leaving. Tell us about the Fright Zone!”

Other Kyle shook her head firmly. “Look, you guys have been great and all, and we’re grateful, really we are. But there’s a whole planet out there. Not everyone is interested in what the princesses are selling. Not everyone wants to be the best versions of themselves.” They seemed to look at Hordak and Wrong

Hordak again and pressed even tighter together. Instead of continuing, they both just shook their heads again.

"Fuck!" Catra groaned, stepping back as Bow and Glimmer tried to coax the silent women into cooperation. She looked over at Adora, who was worrying her bottom lip. "Fuuuck," she repeated in a groan. She didn't know what else to say, and suddenly there were too many thoughts flying around her head to sort through. The concern in Adora's expression made it worse.

Adora looked over at her and crossed her arms, speaking slowly. "If there's people that need our help, and they won't say what's wrong… but they left and were willing to come to us…" She grimaced. "That's not good, is it?"

Catra felt the hairs across her body slowly rise to stand on end. "Something is very, very wrong."

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